Obsidian, Act I: Wolves At The Gate

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/67769321.

Rating:
Not Rated

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Entrapta/Hordak (She-Ra), Angella/Micah (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Mermista/Perfuma (She-Ra), Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra)

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Additional Tags:
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by AzimuthStars

Summary

Twenty years ago, a grand city was overrun by a thousand Horde soldiers searching for a runestone. Within the city of Half-Moon, only one survivor escaped: a child, rescued by the king of Bright Moon. Now, this child must find her place in a war she's thrust in the middle of after a soldier harboring an ancient power finds her way to Bright Moon's doorstep. Meanwhile, after being kidnapped by a powerful dark sorceress, that child's sister must grapple with the beginnings of a downward spiral that threatens to turn her into the very thing she despises.

Notes

Here it is. The beginnings of a rewrite I've been meaning to do for a very long time. Sisters was a passion project I was never quite happy with, and I felt it was time to give it the love it deserved. More descriptive writing, more scenes, better characterization, and more. I'm hoping to update this far more consistently than the original project and pass where we left off in Volume II by the end of the year. This is the definitive version of the story, as of today the original fic is defunct and this one takes precedence. I sincerely hope you enjoy what has been a very enjoyable project for me to work on that has sparked a renewed passion for writing for me.

Chapter 1

Prologue, Part I: Another Time Undone

Fire and brimstone. That's the only way Micah can describe the remnants of the once beautiful village known as Half-Moon, burning down before him with what he could only describe as a thirst to return to the grounds of Etheria. Thick, black smoke billows from the ground, threatening to choke every rescuer on the beach like a tumor deep in the lungs. Anger mixes with despair as he walks this desolate place that once stood as the proud home of the magicat people. Two soldiers flank him as he despondently surveys the destruction, his boots crunching as he walks across charred remains of once-beautiful buildings adorned in obsidian, whose rubble covers the ground so thickly Micah cannot see the path under it.

Somewhere, in the distance, a sudden shrill squeal makes Micah's body move into action faster than he truly registers what he hears: the sound of a child crying out for her mother, a mother who by now must be long dead. The thought stabs a dagger into his already aching heart as he comes to the edge of a collapsed home. It looks bigger than the others, and parts of it remain standing in places. The building had to be a leader's, he surmises from the size and complexity of the rubble.

Another cry breaks him from his admiration, this one muffled beneath pieces of stone and wood. His heartbeat quickens in panic. "Don't just stand there! Help me with this!" He tears piece after piece of rubble away, casting them aside for what seems like hours until he sees them. Beautiful eyes of gold and azure peeking out at him, above them a set of cat ears and a head of thick, unkempt hair. She can't be more than a few months old, Micah estimates, as he reaches down to her. She eyes him curiously, calming as he picks her up. A soft purr begins to

emanate from the magicat child. So far, she is the only survivor of this terrible tragedy.

"Somebody get me something to wrap her in. She's hurt and hungry, but she'll live." He orders the two soldiers, who quickly retrieve a blanket from one of the still-standing buildings. A pang of fear clutches at his heart like the hand of a shadow. There's only one person Micah knows is capable of genocide like this. She's supposed to be dead.

The shadows move at the corner of his left eye like dancers in musical theatre. Despite the fires, the air suddenly turns cold enough that Micah could swear his blood was freezing inside him. He turns in the direction of the building darkness to behold the form of pure evil he once called master.

The sight forces a sardonic chuckle from him. "Light Spinner. I killed you."

"As if death could stop me." The woman seems to glare at him through that mask of hers, tendrils of deep black fog billowing out around her like snakes. She almost seems to glide across the ground as she walks. "How long has it been now, child? Ten years? Fifteen?"

"As if you give a damn." Micah spits, his hand tightening around the staff he hadn't realized he'd drawn. "Why the destruction, Spinner? Why murder an entire race of people?" He can't see behind that mask, but he knows a cold smile has crept over her face. The kind of smile only worn by someone with no remorse for their actions.

The show of empathy seems to entertain the woman. She gestures to the large temple seated at the foot of the mountain Half-Moon was seated beside, chuckling darkly. The cold that the woman brought with her leaves him, replaced by a hot rage he hasn't felt in years. The child in his arms begins to cry again, afraid both of Micah's sudden anger and the figure who he once called master looming over them.

Micah turns to one of the soldiers and places the baby in her arms. "Get her to the boats, Juliet. There's not much time." The soldier opens her mouth as if to argue, but Micah gives her no chance to. "GO!" He shouts, the soldier saluting and taking off away from the collapsed building. A glare finds its way into his eyes as he turns to the evil, towering sorcerer mere steps away from him. He'd visited the temple at the base of that mountain before. "It's a runestone. You're here for a runestone."

She cackles. "Very astute, Micah. I knew you were my favorite pupil for a reason, you know." Light Spinner lunges, attempting to catch him off guard by blinding him in shadow. He sees the trick, sidestepping and countering her with his staff. The force of the gravitational spell he casts sends her skidding to one knee, a scoff being the only sounds she makes.

"You've grown yet again, my young pupil. Unfortunately, there won't be any counter to my newest power." Black lightning bolts fire out of her gloved hands faster than Micah can stop them. The electrical shock courses through him, setting every nerve alight and tensing his body up so that he crumples to the ground.

He screams in pain, his skin feeling as though it's melting as he watches Light Spinner step toward him. She kicks him over with a boot and slams it down on his leg with such a loud ***crack*** *Micah is sure he'll never walk the same again. The woman seems to look down at him with pity, which gives him just enough an opportunity to fight through the pain and grab her leg. He drags her feet out from under her, her head hitting the ground with a painful crunch.*

Micah coughs, climbing to his feet. Blood splatters on the chunks of wood and slab he stands on as he looks down at the shell of the woman he respected. "You monster. I trusted you, Spinner."

She cackles, rising from the ground. Her body shimmers as if she were disappearing below the sea, her form fading in and out. "Light Spinner is long dead, my child. Tremble before the name of the Shadow Weaver, Force Commander of the Horde and the

greatest sorceress on Etheria." She finally disappears into thick smoke.

Micah falls to a knee, clutching his chest as a particularly aggressive coughing fit overtakes him. His vision swims, and the last thing he sees before passing out is the soldier he entrusted with the baby running toward him.

[---]

Micah gasps awake, the sunlight through the infirmary windows almost too blinding to bear as his eyes jerk open. He sits up fast enough to cause jolts of pain to shoot down his spine and into his injured leg. An involuntary groan escapes his mouth, loud enough to send a few of the medics rushing to him and insisting he lay back down. After several nights of consistent pain and nightmares of his former mentor, he almost welcomed the doting infirmary healers.

"I wouldn't try to stand just yet. Your leg is fractured in three places including a particularly nasty one in your femur, not to mention the nasty electrical damage to your peripheral nerves." The medic looks him up and down, checking the burns covering Micah's skin from head to toe. "I will need you to stop shaking, though, sir."

Micah hadn't realized he'd been doing it until the medic said so. He takes the wrist of his off hand in his right, attempting to find an emotional center in deep breathing as the healers in Mystacore once taught him. He forces conjured images of his wife and infant daughter to the forefront of his imagination, using them to keep himself grounded in this moment. Another thought rushes past them nearly as quickly, one of the little magicat he saved in the rubble. Micah hears the infirmary door open, and looks to see the same soldier he'd given the baby to in the remnants of Half-Moon.

"Juliet." He says, happy to see her alive and well. He was worried the ships had been attacked after his incapacitation. "The girl. Is she safe?"

The soldier nods. “She’s stable. Happy bouncing baby girl, probably about three months old. She’s under observation for now but she should be free for someone to take her soon.” She shakes her head. “That is, if she’ll stop crying for more than a few minutes at a time. She’s been going at it nonstop for hours.”

The thought of anyone else taking in that little girl scares the sorcerer terribly. She was the last of her kind now and Micah couldn’t bear to let anyone else raise her when he’d pulled her from that burned out building himself. He nods at Juliet resolutely. “Bring her to me, and send for my wife.”

The soldier nods, quickly shuffling out of the room and leaving Micah alone. More than an hour passes when she finally returns, stepping through the door with the child in her arms. She approaches Micah’s bed and gently lets him take the little girl. To the two’s amazement, the warm embrace of the sorcerer is comfortable enough for her to stop crying. Instead, she becomes fascinated with him, staring up at him in wonder with those beautiful mis-matched eyes of hers. Eyes that despite being only months old already seem so tired. A curious hand reaches up and yanks at strands of his beard, earning a chuckle from Juliet, who just seems relieved that the child is quiet now.

“Does the girl have a name?” The familiar, posh voice of Queen Angella cuts through the quiet wonder of the room like a sword. She approaches with that familiar regality Micah could never have had in all his days as king. A soft smile creeps up her face as she stares down at Bright Moon’s newest inhabitant.

“I was thinking maybe Catra.” Micah says, grinning. His wife groans and pinches the bridge of her nose in frustration, earning a giggle both from the baby and from her husband. Micah already knows he and the girl are gonna get along great.

“Don’t tell me you’ve already decided we’re adopting her. And isn’t that name a little on the nose, dear?”

“I don’t think so. I think she likes it. Don’t you, Catra?” The baby smiles and laughs, giving him little punches on the faces as she tries to grab his cheeks. His expression grows somber as he looks back to his wife, who’s piercing eyes fill with worry. “She’s the last of her kind, Angella. She needs a home. I know Glimmer would love having a sister.”

The queen sighs, staring down with a soft smile at Catra, who looks up at her in awe. She chuckles fondly, never being able to truly say no to Micah when she knew he was right. “I just don’t know if we’ll survive two of them.”

[---]

The next year seems to pass them by so quickly. The girls are so young but so full of life, life that Angella and Micah can’t wait for them to experience. Their first birthdays, though they wouldn’t remember, are grand celebrations for Bright Moon’s royal family of four. The people all the way down to the common folk adore Catra: in her they see Bright Moon’s duty to continue to protect Etheria from the Horde, and the drive to prevent any more destruction from wreaking indiscriminate hellfire on the little planet they call home. Though the Horde could destroy their cities and burn their libraries, they could not remove the indomitable spirit of the Alliance.

That is, if it isn’t for the tragedy that strikes little over a month after Catra’s first. Micah is running almost as soon as he hears the crash from down the hall, blinking sleep out of his eyes desperately and ignoring the pain in the leg that still hasn’t properly healed. He’s barely conscious, running on pure adrenaline as he swings the door to Catra’s room open. Micah quickly checks the crib he’d suspended above the ground for her comfort (He’d read that magicats liked to sleep up high). To his relief the crib is still occupied by the sleeping girl, who apparently was in such a deep sleep she’d not registered the sound that had awoken him.

Crying echoes from the next room in the hall, and just as quickly as Micah had come to Catra's room he ran for Glimmer's. The rooms were not far apart, maybe only a few paces, but the strain he's putting on his leg finally gives way to a shooting pain that sends him tumbling to the ground. He curses loudly, climbing to his feet and limping into the room where his other child slept.

"Glimmer!" Angella's voice comes from beside him. The sound had awoken her too, and she had taken off for Glimmer's room as Micah checked Catra's. In the arms of the same dark sorceress who had given him his bad leg was his daughter, wailing. She coos at her in her arms, the baby seemingly calming for a second before sensing her parents fear and beginning again.

"See what you've done? You've scared her, the poor thing." Shadow Weaver croons, a dark tone lying just beneath her words. "You know, this one is quite powerful. I can sense the magic in her, coursing through her veins. She'll make a worthy successor, more than either of us could ever even attempt to be."

"You take your hands off my daughter, now." Micah commands, stepping towards her. Shadows whirl around his legs, but don't deter him as he moves. They grab and clutch and claw at him but he remains determined. A dark urge tapped at the back of his mind. If there ever was a time to channel his former master, now would be it. A small blast of magic charges in his palm, only big enough to disorient Shadow Weaver. He has to do this right or he'll risk hurting Glimmer, something he'd never forgive himself for. Another step and he lungers, blasting at her but missing entirely as she disappears into shadow. Laughter echoes around him hauntingly, the cold chuckles of a woman who's too far gone.

"Farewell, Micah." Her voice echoes in his head. He yells in frustration, in anguish, as reality sets in for him. Angella is sobbing, having come to the same conclusion he now is. Angry, hot tears fall from his face, wetting the floor below as he climbs to his feet. Angella's arms find her husband, and she holds him for who knows how long as he struggles to regain any semblance of composure.

“I- I lost her. I lost Glimmer!” Micah cries, collapsing back to the floor. Angella kneels beside him. They don’t leave the room for the rest of the night. The kidnapping strikes fear in the hearts of every kingdom in the Alliance. If Bright Moon’s finest couldn’t keep their own family safe, what good could they do for everyone else? It’s as if overnight the faith in the war shifts from hope to desperation. How many more children does the Horde need to kidnap before they’d be satisfied? The answer truly was that there wasn’t one.

They’d continue until the work was done, and Etheria was theirs.

[FIFTEEN YEARS LATER]

“Catra.” A voice in the distance calls to her, as if trying to rouse her from slumber. She waves a sleepy hand, grumbling and rolling over. “Catra!” The voice jerks her awake, looking around the room for the source before peering over the edge of her hanging bed frame. Bow waves up at her from below, grinning widely as if he *enjoys* being up in the morning.

She waves a hand at him. “Get me up in like, two or three more… hours…” Catra nods off, falling back into that state between sleep and wakefulness with ease. The magicat was naturally a restless person, having stayed up reading because she'd been unable to sleep. When she finally did get shut-eye, it usually came at very early hours of the morning.

“Catra!” Bow’s voice jerks her awake again, causing her to involuntary hiss as she shoots straight up in bed. She peeks over the edge again with a growl, spying him still standing there with a patient grin.

“What?” Her tired rasp comes with more teeth than she intends.

“It's your birthday and people want to celebrate!” Bow says sheepishly, smiling in that dumb way that softened her every time. It wasn't actually Catra’s birthday, just the day her dad found her in that burned out town, but despite her protests everyone

celebrated it like it was. She was sure Micah had a surprise up his sleeve and definitely wanted to see, but the bed was far too comfortable to ignore. If it was to be her birthday as foretold by the universe, then her one wish this year is to sleep like a corpse.

"But I wanna sleep!" Catra says with a pout. "Booooow!"

Bow raises an eyebrow. "Guess you don't want to see what your dad made you. Oh well, maybe he'll give them to Juliet."

Catra jumps down immediately and grabs him by the shoulders. "He *made* me something? What is it? Have you seen it?" Her eyes seem to sparkle in excitement.

"Well, it wouldn't be a surprise if I just *told* you." Bow declares with a broad smile, breaking free from Catra's grip and gesturing her to follow. "C'mon, you'll see."

Catra is surprised the boy had come to wake her up. Usually on this day her father would be the one bursting into the room in excitement, but she surmises the surprise must be pretty special if he sent Bow to come meet him somewhere. The archer leads her down a set of stairs and through a large door into the courtyard where the royal guards do daily training exercises. She nearly hops up and down in excitement as they walk. She didn't usually like people to know she looked forward to this day because the festivities honestly make her more uncomfortable than anything. She'd always just preferred to be grateful for things as they were.

She spots her dad to the side of the courtyard, who waves and gestures her over. He still struggles on that leg all these years later but refuses to walk with a cane, opting instead to 'tough it out.' Catra has always thought he was too stubborn for his own good, but maybe she had to get that from someone.

"Kitten!" Micah nearly tackles her in a hug as she approaches, his grip tight enough to crack ribs if so chose to.

"Hey dad, couldn't get me yourself, so you send Bow?" Catra teases, a smirk plastered on her face. She knows he's got

something special planned, but her mischievous nature can't help but give him hell for it.

“Hey now,” He releases her from the hug. “Today’s a big day! I wanted to make sure everything was ready!” He gestures her to follow him through a small door attached to the courtyard. Through there was the armory, which only confuses Catra more.

Catra raises an eyebrow. “Must be pretty big if you had to prepare.” She turns red in embarrassment, though it’s difficult to see beneath her fur. “You really didn’t have to, dad.”

“Oh come on, Catra. You were excited a moment ago!” Bow grins, earning a playful shove from the magicat.

“Alright, alright. Let’s see it.” Catra smiles, a genuine, dangerous content creeping into her. Micah grins and turns around, walking to a table huddled in the corner of the courtyard. When he returns, he’s holding a box that he hands to Catra. It’s small but heavy, much heavier than it looks from the outside. “Jeez, dad, what’d you get me, bricks?”

Micah laughs. “Open them up and try them on, kitten.”

Catra does as she’s told, opening the box to reveal a pair of padded and iron plated gloves. They were covered in some sort of mechanism on the backside. She curiously slides one over her left hand, not quite gleaning the purpose behind the mechanism from the action alone. She eyes her father, who smiles softly.

Catra studies her left hand as if she's never seen it before. Five metal claws sit at each fingertip, sharp as steel and blackened by the forge. Wonder fills her heart as she eyes them, the design alone seeming impossible for her dad alone to pull off. She grins at her father. “Dad, these are awesome! How'd you design these? It had to have taken months!”

Bow chuckles from beside her. “I might've helped.” He says, blushing. Bow isn't really the bragging type, which Catra supposes is why he didn't mention his involvement before.

Micah grins proudly. “Might have stolen the hand measurements from your suit for princess prom last year. Good thing you wore gloves.”

Catra pulls him into a hug, her heart struggling to maintain composure as she embraces her father. She'd always been so grateful to this man, who'd given everything for her and might still, but this was a new level of commitment.

“Thanks, dad.” She mutters into his shoulder. Despite being a good head taller than her father she always found herself like a little girl again in his arms. A nagging feeling tugs at her, though, and she pulls back from the hug and stares at him curiously. “Why?”

“Why what, Catra?” Micah tilts his head. Catra suspects he knows what she's about to ask, but can't parse it from his expression alone. “Something wrong?”

“Why give me a weapon?” She says nervously. She's never considered herself much of a fighter, and the idea that Micah wants her to learn attracts a deep seated fear in her heart, one that she'd tried to bury.

Micah looks at her proudly. “You're not a little girl anymore, Catra. You're my pride and joy. One day you'll be queen of this kingdom and I'd like you to have something to defend yourself with.” He sighs. “Which is why I'm gonna teach you to use them as best as I can.”

Catra shoves the feeling down for now, only nodding. Her father wasn't a stupid man, and she supposes if he wants her to learn to fight it's probably better to have the skill and never use it. She doesn't get to continue the train of thought, though, as Bow thrusts another gift into her hands: a trackerpad not unlike his own.

Catra turns beet red. “Bow! You didn't have to! You work hard on them, give this to someone important!” Bow grins, but doesn't say

anything at first. Catra realizes what he's about to say pretty much instantly and glares. “Don't.”

“Then take it.” Bow laughs, pulling his best friend into a hug. They'd not known each other long, but they'd become an unlikely yet very close pair around Bright Moon.

Catra grumbles. “I'm not that important. But thank you.”

[---]

The next day, Catra still isn't quite sure how the gloves work; she can't quite get them to extend when she wants them to. Sure, she’d made them work yesterday but Micah and Bow hadn’t fully calibrated them to her hands until that evening. They almost seem to have a mind of their own, opening and closing whenever she seemed to move her hand the wrong way. Before bed, she had put them on to try to see if she could make them cooperate and instead ended up with quite a few shredded pillows.

"You have to flex your hand backwards to unsheathe them!" Micah calls from the sidelines.

Catra tries it and to her surprise the claws surge forward with a loud snap, sharpened and ready to go. She looks down at them for a moment, pondering what she is about to do. Is she really a fighter? Is she cut out for this kind of thing? She looks up at the dummies and eyes each of them closely, sizing them up for a beat before her mind settles into resolve.

"AH!" She yells, rushing at one before toppling it over and slashing at it aggressively.

"Catra!" Micah calls, waving his arms. "CATRA!"

Catra stops and looks down at the remains of the dummy before she looks up at Micah with a grin. “How was that?” That feisty, fearless part of her fights against the voice inside that tells her how bad of an idea this whole charade is. She pushes the voice

down, choosing to enjoy training with her new claws without thinking too hard about the implications.

"You have to be more elegant than that, kitten." Micah laughs. "Fighting isn't just about landing your attacks. It's a dance between yourself and your opponent for the upper hand." He steps over and widens his stance, his fists raised. "Come at me."

Catra's expression changes to one of surprise, she looks down at the gloves soberly and retracts the claws. "No. Dad. I don't want to hurt you." She shakes her head.

"Come on, Catra. It'll be fine. I'm a big boy." Micah chuckles. “Show me what you've got!”

Catra eyes him fearfully, before she decides he wouldn't do this without being certain. Her eyes fill with determination and she lunges at Micah, regretting the brute force method immediately. The sorcerer steps aside, picking her up and throwing her over his shoulder.

"Ow." Catra groans, her back screaming in pain from the force of hitting the hard dirt in the courtyard. She climbs to her feet, stretching for a moment to loosen up.

"See? You have to anticipate your enemies moves as well as your own." Micah says, placing a hand on her shoulder. “Let’s try it again.”

Catra nods, backing up and readying herself. When she jumps at him this time, she watches closely for an opening, finding it when Micah attempts to grab her. She jumps out of the way and parries his swing, distracting him while she uses her off hand to grab his arm and toss him over her shoulder.

"Dad! Oh gods. I'm so sorry." Catra covers her mouth, abject horror strewn across her face.

Micah's laughter starts as a low chuckle before he explodes into a full blown chortle. "That was amazing, kitten! You're a natural."

He grabs Catra’s hand as she helps him to his feet.

"You think so?" Catra says timidly. Fighting wasn’t something she’d considered her wheelhouse until now, usually she’d be devising battle plans for General Juliet, despite her mother’s protests, not engaging in hand-to-hand combat. She considers herself more of the tactician type of commander, less so the boots-on-the-ground type like Juliet.

"Yeah! No one has ever quite deflected me like that before. You've got it!" He grins, genuine pride showing across his face. A part of Catra wishes he’d stop looking at her like that, it will only make her feel worse when she eventually lets him down like that voice in the back of her head always tells her she will.

"King Micah!" As if summoned by the young princess’s thoughts, General Juliet runs onto the training grounds clutching a scroll in her hand. She looks a little worse for wear, like she hasn’t slept in a few days. Catra can’t imagine what it must be like to have her job. "There’s been sightings of the Horde amassing troops near the Whispering Woods."

"This is nothing new, General. The Woods will stop them." Micah raises an eyebrow inquisitively. Juliet isn’t stupid, which makes Catra suspicious as to why this time of all times she rushes to inform her father.

"Sir," Juliet gulps, her face seeming to break into a cold sweat. Catra doesn’t show it, but she’s taken aback by this display, having never seen Juliet so unnerved. "One of them is a magic-user." Micah seems to join the general in turning stone cold, his face going through a range of emotions Catra can’t gauge. He and Juliet begin to walk away, talking in hushed whispers as Catra watches.

A slight annoyance finds its way to her chest. "Wait. Dad! What about our training?" Catra calls, gesturing at the courtyard. Just moments ago Micah had seemed in the best mood he could be in, and now Catra thinks he’s seen a ghost.

Micah turns back, smiling softly and waving her off. "That's enough for one day, kitten. We'll get back to it tomorrow." Catra watches him exit the courtyard to the main stairway, not realizing that just hours later her father would leave her forever.

[---]

Shadow Weaver stares at her former apprentice coldly. She didn't care what he was there for, nor did she think he'd ever get his far. Truly, it was impressive, if not annoying. "You made quite a stir didn't you Micah?" Shadow Weaver chuckles, her finger touching his chin amusedly. "Unfortunately, your rebellion is dying, my former apprentice. The Horde will reign supreme." She chuckles, a sadistic undertone creeping in. She truly loves what she does, haunting these tortured souls like a revenant from the past.

"YOU-" His outburst surprises her and she involuntarily steps backwards. He coughs, spitting blood on the ground at her feet before glaring up at her from his chains. "You KIDNAPPED my DAUGHTER!" The sentence emerges from his mouth like venom from a snake. Shadow Weaver, however, knows this snake has no fangs.

"Truly, Micah, I've no idea what you mean. I told you the magicat wasn't useful to me and she stayed with you as I allowed." Shadow Weaver's unamused, deadpan tone drips with manipulative venom of her own. "Unless you mean-" She chuckles, pausing for dramatic emphasis. "Oh surely, you couldn't mean *Glimmer* ."

"You keep her name out your fucking mouth." Micah growls, trying his damndest to lunge at her despite the heavy chains keeping him in place. To her surprise, the unthinkable happens as the chain holding his right arm breaks free from the wall. She attempts to sidestep the hand rocketing toward her but is a second too late, her former apprentice's hand takes hold of part of her mask and pulls. It falls to the ground with a *crack* that all but signifies it's broken in two.

She looks up at Micah, her face twisted into a horrifyingly cold glare. Shadow Weaver approaches him quietly, stepping towards him so calmly she can almost *sense* the fear it creates in the sorcerer. Crackles of lightning begin in her hand, arcing between her fingers like lightning rods. She extends a hand out, charging the electrical attack to maximum power.

The bolt of lightning never comes. Micah uses the hand he'd freed to grab her by the wrist, a dark energy seeming to warp the space between them as he delves into the pool of forbidden magic he'd swore to never use again. Shadow Weaver chuckles, smiling evilly up at the man who she'd taught so well. “You never fail to keep me on my toes, young apprentice. Unfortunately, it will be your undoing.”

“Then I'll make sure we both die here, right now.” Micah growls. “You make one more wrong move and neither of us leave the room.” The calculating stare across his eyes hides Micah's true intentions. Shadow Weaver will never admit it, but the man currently held a dangerous advantage.

To her luck, their mutually assured destruction never comes. Two guards from outside the room come running to Shadow Weaver’s aid, having heard the struggle after Micah broke his chains. She only wishes they'd become aware sooner, but she supposes beggars can't be choosers. One of them angrily hits Micah over the head with his baton, breaking his concentration on the spell and freeing the dark sorceress from his grasp.

Shadow Weaver approaches Micah, staring right into the man’s eyes. "She’ll be the greatest Force Commander the Horde has ever known." She growls, repairing her mask with magic and affixing it back over her face. “Send him to Beast Island.” She calls back to the guards as she turns to leave. They quickly oblige her, and take the opportunity to begin beating him with their batons. Micah’s screams can be heard from nearly the edge of the prison wing, the sound of his torture bringing a sick joy to her heart.

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It’s late when the knock comes at Catra’s bedroom door. She sighs, hopping from her bed. “Bow, it’s like midnight. Shouldn’t you be asleep?” She kicks herself internally for sounding so much like her mother, a trait she’d been noticing about herself more and more recently.

The voice that comes is decidedly *not* Bow’s. “It’s me. We-” General Juliet hesitates. “We need you in the war room. Mom’s orders.” Catra’s fur stands on end at that last part. Her mother was not one to rouse a war council in the middle of the night, let alone one involving her daughter whom she strictly forbade from attending them. She quickly dresses, throwing on yesterday’s attire and opening the door to meet the other woman’s eye.

What she sees nearly stops her heart. Juliet looks like she’s been *crying,* and hard at that. The woman gives her a sad, somber look that creates in Catra a sense of dread she’s not felt before. Something is *very* wrong. The princess nods at Juliet, allowing her to lead the way towards the large, oval shaped room where the Alliance held meetings. When they arrive, the only others there are Angella and Bow. Catra can’t get a gauge on Angella’s feelings, her face a kind of stoic that she can only think is too extreme even for the Queen. Bow, on the other hand, is an open book. He looks like hell, like he’d been attacked by a pack of wolves that let him live only barely.

A realization begins to set in. She looks around the room frantically before finding her mother’s eyes. “Where’s Dad?” She asks, her voice dripping with urgency. Angella stares, seeming to see right through Catra as if she weren’t there. A jolt of sheer terror shoots down Catra’s spinal cord, as if she were holding a metal rod to the sky in an electrical storm. She practically sprints to Angella’s side and grabs her mother’s shoulders. “Where is he?”

“Catra-” Juliet places her hand on Catra’s arm. The sudden contact makes Catra hiss, her magicat instincts taking over. She watches Juliet’s expression, finding herself hoping for fear and

receiving instead one of despair. Nothing this woman was about to say could be true. They were all liars. All of them.

“Don’t fucking touch me.” She growls. “Liars! All of you! Big, fat, stupid liars! Any moment my dad is gonna step through that door and be fine and it’ll show all of you!” Hot, angry tears form at the corners of her eyes, threatening to reveal her true emotions like a dam breaking over an empty riverbed. The air around her turns to carbon dioxide, her breathing growing ragged and fast as the room seems to shrink around her. It’s too small and too claustrophobic. The pressure is building and she needs release now before her existence combusts.

Then, as if to oblige the screaming need for deliverance, the dam breaks. She later won’t remember when her fist first finds the table, only that it happens over and over while the trickle of tears becomes a waterfall. She growls angrily in pain at the repeated abuse, but Catra refuses to acknowledge the pain directly and continues the onslaught, stopping only when she feels the bones in the pinky side of her left hand fracture. She doesn’t even care enough to scream in pain, instead just sinking into the chair beside her mother and covering her face as if she were abhorrent to look at. She almost growls when she feels arms wrap around her, but the angry voice in her head decides to back off this time. She leans into her mother’s embrace and lets the tears flow freely.

Catra feels something inside her break in a way that might never heal.

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter I: Knives / Sorrow

Catra flops face down into her bed in sheer exhaustion. She'd just spent the last several hours counting weaponry in the armory for Juliet, something Catra knew her mother put the general up to just to keep her busy at home and away from the war. Catra finds ways around this, though, and she and Juliet have a mutual understanding that Catra will provide battle tactics to her in exchange for leniency from the general when she did snoop around outside the kingdom.

In this moment, though, she had to keep up appearances, and what better way than menial inventory? If she's being honest with herself, she just wants the world around her to quit existing, if only for a second so she can have a moment of solace from the tiring effort of being alive. Equal parts of her want to disappear forever and take on so much work she never has to be alone with her thoughts again. Every moment she doesn't have to think is a blessing.

Just when she's about to get up and return to the grind, she hears a whizzing sound fly past her and hit her wall with a hard *thwack* . Catra groans, jumping down from the hanging apparatus that holds the bed in the air and investigating the freshly placed arrow in her wall.

Not now, Bow. I'm busy. She thinks. Her relationship with the boy has strained under the pressure of Catra's duties as a princess and her need for constant distraction. Realistically, it'd been heading this direction since the death of her father, but recently she's especially felt closed off. The fear that if she stops moving she'll

collapse under her own weight practically controls her at this point, steering her like autopilot through life. She looks out her window down into the grass below to see her friend waving up at her.

She sighs. “Hey, Bow.” The question is more exasperated than she means it to be, and it earns a frown from the archer that Catra can't read as anything other than the one thing she despises most: pity. “ What's up?”

“Haven't seen you in a few days, wanted to make sure you were eating.” Bow says timidly. Catra almost scoffs at this, wondering when Bow became her surrogate mother to add on to her actual mother's overbearing worry. Instead, though, she takes a deep breath and lets it out in a deep, exhausted sigh.

“Barely.” She says quietly. “Just- just get up here before I change my mind.” Exhaustion drips in her tone like a dripping pipe. She knows Bow can see the burnout, that's why he's better off finding other friends. Why he continues the effort of being in her life is his funeral, she supposes, though he hasn’t given up yet. Honestly, that makes him a far more caring person than she is in her book.

The boy climbs through the window, heaving a bit from the effort. How he did that, Catra would never know. The window was at least twenty feet in the air and he wasn’t a cat person like her, yet he still did it all the time. He slides down below the side of the window in her room, sitting against it and grinning up at Catra with a dopey smile. “So, whatcha doing?” He says, as if he's actually interested or concerned for her wellbeing.

“Just, you know, the usual. Mom’s got me doing all this stupid tedious shit instead of out there helping like I could be.” She says, dropping down beside him with an arm on her knee. “I'm doing all I can but it's never enough.” That much was true, at least the point where it was never enough. She’d spent hours upon hours trying to distract herself from the gaping void in her chest, but recently it’d grown more and more intense.

“Catra, you're working yourself to death. If you keep this up you're gonna end up in an early grave from the stress.” Bow frowns, those brown eyes of his seeming to see right through her facade into her core. She scoffs, hating that he knows her so well. They’d known each other since they were probably 12, and neither of them has ever been afraid to call the other out on their bullshit.

“I don't know. Maybe that's for the best.” She mutters, not realizing she's said it aloud. The statement earns a swat from Bow in reprimand, the boy shaking his head at her in dismay. Her musings are true in her mind at least. She has to keep moving or she risks becoming a stationary weight on the paper of existence, losing all momentum entirely.

“Here, c’mon.” He rises to his feet, tugging Catra's arm to follow her. She resists at first before obliging him, standing beside him to look out the window that overlooked the Whispering Woods. They look the same as always, ever shifting and changing in their purpose as a barrier between Bright Moon and the Horde. She wonders if the woods were put there for that reason? How long has the Horde been here?

“It's the woods. Yay.” Catra yawns, her body protesting the advanced lack of sleep she's putting it through. “Looks the same as always.” The trees are so thick you can’t even see the ground from here, but she and Bow have been through them more than once at this point, knowing some of the key points of interest well enough to navigate.

“I detected a pretty hardcore piece of First One's tech out there somewhere. Didn't want to go alone.” He looks over at her, smiling softly. “That is, if you aren't too busy. I figure even if it's useless we can probably get *something* out of it. Might be a fun little side adventure.” Catra’s heart explodes in excitement for a second before the usual disdain takes over once again.

“Bow, I-” Catra’s surprised when the boy immediately quiets her with a hand gesture. He looks serious, like this is much more important than she realizes. Must be a pretty big signal for him to come all this way anyway, she supposes, not to mention the look she’s earning right now seems to say so.

“Stop.” Bow says somberly. “You’ve been avoiding me for weeks. I know it’s around when you’re-” He hesitates, shaking his head. “When your dad died. I know how hard you took it. You’ve really never been the same. You avoided me and treated me like I disgusted you. I know that isn’t you, it’s never been, but please let me distract you for a moment. Let me take your mind off the burden of everything for a second so I can see my friend again instead of the future Commander of the Alliance.” He smiles softly.

Catra sighs. She *does* need a distraction before all this work gives her a stroke at a young age such as hers. She stands up and climbs onto the window sill, staring at the woods below. Bow is right, no matter how much she hates to admit it. She needs to take her mind off her dad, off the war, and off herself. With a silent leap, she lands in the grass below and turns around. “Well, you coming?” She says with a tired smile, that mischievous twinkle that she fears she’s losing finding its home in her eyes.

Bow grins in return, climbing down and joining her. “Looks like I’ve still got it.” He chuckles, pulling his tracker pad from his hip and scrolling through the radar. He turns and tries to find the signal for a moment before finding the direction in the woods to trace. The unusual energy signature beeps on the piece of tech as they start to walk towards it.

“Unfortunately, your energy is infectious.” Catra says, playfully shoving him as they walk. “I can’t help but feel more like myself when you try to cheer me up. It’s almost like-” She gasps dramatically. “You’re a good person!” She cackles squeakily, earning a groan from Bow as they venture into the Whispering Woods. They’re dense from years of abuse by the Horde, as if they were muscle growing and strengthening over time. Bow is a decent navigator, this much Catra knows, but even then the

Woods have always sort of given her the creeps. She hasn't been back since she'd gotten lost, stranded for what felt like days and walking in endless circles until the Woods decided they were done with her.

That time she'd seen a large crystal-like building hidden deep within the Woods. She's not been back much since, but it never reappeared after that. She knows the magical forest has a sense of humor, and sometimes it only shows you what you need to see at any given moment, but she'd never quite understood what was so important about the building. The idea that a collection of trees like this could be sentient in such a way disturbs her a bit. She could never know what they were thinking or feeling, only where they choose to take her. Catra realizes it's been a bit since either of them have said anything: Bow had been concentrating on his tracker pad while she'd gotten lost in her thoughts.

They've been walking for what feels like two hours when Bow finally cracks. "I don't get it! We have *got* to be close. That signal is like, right on top of us!" He stuffs the pad into his pack and looks around for a moment, trying to find any sign of *any* First Ones tech or ruins that could be the source. After a beat, he groans and throws his hands in the air. "It's like I'm being toyed with!"

A sparkle catches Catra's eye, deep in the woods, likely only bright enough for her eyes to see. She nods her head in that direction. "Let's try that way. Something's glowing out there." The boy looks, squinting his eyes for a moment before looking at her with a perplexed expression.

"I don't see anything."

Catra turns, pointing up at her left eye with a grin. "Magicat eyes. I can see in the dark better than you can, and boy is this place dark." She grabs his arm, pulling him along towards the faint light. "C'mon, we don't have all night." The glow grows brighter as they trudge along, and soon enough Bow's tracker pad says the signal is right on top of them. They spend the better part of half an hour

searching exhaustively, before Catra collapses to a seat on a large tree root.

"Nothing about this makes sense. By all accounts, it should be right here. You saw that light before I did!" Bow says as he sits beside her, groaning. "Maybe the tracker pad needs some upgrades. For all we know the light could be completely-" Catra looks over at him as he trails off. Bow's face is locked in an expression of surprise and panic. She traces his gaze to the edge of the clearing the two are sitting in and what she sees makes her blood run cold. A tall Horde soldier with long blonde hair stands at the edge of the clearing, unaware of their presence. He seems to be looking for the light as well.

"Shit." Catra mutters. Bow looks as though he's about to speak, but Catra shakes her head and gestures at him to follow her. The pair sneak around the edge of the clearing to cut the soldier off. The magicat catches sight of the glowing light again now that she's much closer to the soldier's position, but instinct tells her the soldier hasn't caught on yet.

As she and Bow continue toward the light, Catra finally starts to see the source of it sitting nestled in some vines: a sword, glowing bright like a sun in the middle of the dark woods. The soldier's footsteps pick up, which means he must see it too. "C'mon, run for it!" Catra growls to Bow, the two picking up full sprint towards the sword. Catra isn't sure why a sword of all things is out here and why it's glowing like daylight, but if it's powerful enough to set off Bow's tracker pad at the *edge* of the Woods, she has to keep it away from the Horde. She reaches the sword first, grabbing it in her arms and turning to pass it to Bow. In her line of sight comes the Horde soldier running full sprint instead, as if he were about to body slam her. "Oh shit." Catra mutters under her breath. She fumbles with the sword as she tries to leap out the way, narrowly avoiding impaling herself on the blade as she jumps.

The soldier stops, glaring at her. Catra can see him up close now, and he looks disheveled. Long locks of ratty blonde hair fall all

around his face, hiding a pair of exhausted gray eyes. He's wearing a standard Horde uniform typical of cadets: a white shirt adorned with red lining tucked into gray cargo pants. The soldier's shirt is tight enough to show a toned musculature through, though he isn't ripped like some soldiers and looks more malnourished than fit.

“I don't want to hurt you.” The cadet says, his voice quiet and low. He steps slowly towards Catra with his arms raised. It doesn't give her much time to consider what her next move is, but without thinking twice she passes it to Bow. He backs off with it, Catra and the soldier entering a standoff for an excruciating few minutes. Finally, the Horde cadet lunges not for Catra, but for Bow. The boy sidesteps him, but is unable to keep the blonde from grabbing onto the handle of the large greatsword. The moment he touches it a light so bright it seems to set Catra's fur ablaze fills the trees. It lasts less than a second, but it feels as though the planet fell into the sun.

Catra blinks the spots out of her eyes to see the cadet in the grass, the sword lying beside him. He's unconscious, seemingly as a result of the flash of light. Without a word, Bow picks the sword up and passes it to Catra as he removes a bundle of rope from his pack. By the time the soldier rouses, he's tied up and leaning against a tree. Catra points the greatsword in his face.

“Wh-what happened?” He mumbles, still dazed. Whatever the sword had done to him, it had really knocked him off his feet. Catra scoffs, bringing the blade to his chin.

“You tell me. One moment we're tussling and the next I feel like I stepped onto the surface of the sun. What did you do?” She growls. The blade in her hand is heavy, far too cumbersome for her taste. She unsheathes the claw on her right hand, sword still pointed at him with her left. “I suggest you start talking before I do something we'll both regret.”

The intruder’s eyes narrow, giving Catra a glare. “You think you're the first person to threaten me, princess?” He smiles, his tone

dripping with a surprising venom. “If I knew what I did do you really think I'd have willingly knocked myself unconscious?” He shakes his head, laughing coldly as if Catra should know better.

Catra scowls. “How’d you get this far into the Whispering Woods? You should have gotten turned around like every other Horde member who wanders in. What kind of magic are you concealing?” She presses the blade against his throat slightly, as if to intimidate him.

The blonde raises an eyebrow. “I- I walked?” His tone reveals genuine confusion, which Catra thinks is odd. If he really claimed to be someone who'd been out in the field enough to be *threatened* before, how's he not know about the Woods? “And magic?! What makes you think I’m magical in *any* capacity? I saw you, you were following that light too! Are you saying I shouldn’t have been able to see it?”

“Why did the Woods want to bring us together?” Bow muses, half-answering the question. The boy is right, if the three of them were supposed to see the light after all, what motive did the mysterious forest have? “What could they possibly want with two high-ranking members of the Alliance and a Horde cadet?”

Catra shakes her head dismissively. “Doesn't matter right now. As far as I'm concerned you're our prisoner and a spy. You were here searching for an apparently powerful piece of First One's weaponry on the edge of Alliance territory for the Horde’s own evil gain.” She stands and helps the soldier to his feet, continuing to glare daggers at him. She gestures at Bow to follow, keeping a sharp eye on the cadet as they walk.

So the three of them walk, not talking very much at all. The woods seem to become even further of a labyrinth the deeper they go, causing that fear that they'll never make it out of here to come crawling back into Catra's mind. She shoves it down and represses, seeing no use for it over focusing on the journey home. Before long they come to a clearing where a sea of burned out buildings sit. It looks like an old pre-war village, likely put here

before the thicket enveloped it as a result of the Horde's incursions. Rage overtakes Catra at the sight, and before she realizes what she's doing she's got the blonde by the collar. "Alright, blondie, you see this?!" She kicks him to his knees before the destroyed village, growling angrily as she does so. "This is what you people do. You come, you take, you destroy."

The cadet's eyes widen in surprise. For someone who claimed to have been threatened before, he looks shocked, as if he'd never seen such abhorrent destruction. "No- No this wasn't us. The Horde doesn't do things like this, we- Hordak would never-" His voice is shaky, carrying a fear Catra isn't expecting.

The emotion he's displaying only deepens her anger: if Horde indoctrination is this heavy, then they really are monsters for making *anyone* believe they could be good. "Hordak *lied.* " Catra seethes, reaching the kind of calm rage her mother would be proud of. Though Angella was pragmatic, she had had her moments in the past and taught Catra that the best way to display anger was in a controlled way, saying it was more effective a tool than explosive rage. "This is what the Horde does, blondie. Have you ever seen another one of me anywhere? That's because the Horde *killed* them all."

With that, Catra scoffs, and walks into the woods. She hacks away at some overgrown vines and branches, venting her anger through the sword. How could someone be so delusional? So blind to what the Horde is? Not a day goes by where she doesn't think about her father, her *dead* father, and that's because of them! And that blonde *idiot* wants to pretend like they're- *thunk.* The sword hits a hard rock and nearly unravels from Catra's hand. She steps back, looking at the rock for a moment. If she didn't know better she'd say the boulder is almost *breathing* . When she's about to look away, she realizes she definitely doesn't know any better, because the rock opens all eight of its eyes and stares right back at her. The two stare at each other for a moment before the spider-like rock creature decides to rush her.

“FUCK!” Catra yells out in panic, turning on her heels and running back to the village where Bow and the soldier had been talking. As soon as he sees her Bow reacts quickly, attempting to use his arrows to lure it away from her to no avail. He curses when the arrows bounce off the large creature's armor uselessly. She almost reaches the two when a dip in the ground makes her lose her footing. She tumbles to the ground and loses her grip on the sword, which flies from her hand and lands a ways away. When she quickly climbs to her feet, she doesn’t have time to waste trying to find it. “Bow! Take the prisoner and-” Catra’s heart stops. The prisoner, where did the prisoner go? He’d been right here just moments ago. She begins to panic for a moment before remembering that he’s still tied up, so he couldn’t have gotten far. She instinctively looks around for the sword, but the wave of realization hits her too late. She turns back to where she’d fallen to see the prisoner cutting the ropes with the sword. “Wait!” She cries out to deaf ears, as the soldier suspiciously raises the blade into the air.

“For the Honor of Grayskull!” The cadet yells. A second blinding light blankets the area like freshly fallen snow, not carrying any heat as the original one did. Seconds go by where not even the rock-spider seems to move, and when Catra’s vision finally returns and the sea of white fades the Horde soldier is gone. In his place is something she had only heard of in legend. The She-Ra stands, in all her eight foot glory, between the magicat and the rock monster. Catra doesn't have time to gawk, as the creature begins rushing towards her, its pincers gnashing like teeth at her. She-Ra moves quickly, though, her blade sweeping up and across the stomach of the beast. The attack sends it reeling backwards in fear, rushing backwards into the Woods as if it realized who the She-Ra was.

As quickly as she came, the warrior woman leaves. The cadet crumbles to his knees and drops the Sword, transforming back into himself. His use of the power seems to have sapped the strength from him, as his breathing grows heavy and ragged and tears roll down like little rivers along his cheeks. Catra approaches the cadet slowly as he buries his face in his hands, a heavy sob

reaching from his core. The princess sighs, empathizing with the blonde soldier for the first time since they came here. She sits beside him in the grass, pulling her knees to her chest.

“You alright?” She mutters after a beat, earning a somber glare from the cadet. The look makes Catra chuckle sadly. She wonders if that’s what she’d looked like after she realized just what kind of world they lived in, the one that takes her sister and father from her for the sake of mindless chaos all over the planet. The Horde would stop at nothing until Etheria kneeled.

“No.” The blonde finally mutters in that same quiet voice he'd used just a few hours ago. “I'm in over my head here. That thing- that stupid *sword* led me out here just to show me all this? To show me the place I devoted my life to is a sham?” He covers his face with his hands a second time, choking back a sob. “What an idiot I've been all my life, to follow it so blindly.” He chuckles sourly, his eyes hiding a despondence that only comes when everything you know is wrong. “I suppose everyone else would have thought it was just like me. Just like poor Adam to believe all the lies so readily! What a *fucking* moron I was!” He laughs a bit manically, his eyes wide with suppressed anger.

“You know, I think I'm ready to believe you.” Catra sighs. “You could have run into the Woods with that sword and disappeared forever and instead you protected Bow and I. We're strangers, enemies on opposite sides of this war, and despite that, despite the evil the Horde does, you still did that.” She shakes her head as Bow sits beside her. Adam seems to calm after a moment, his breathing growing steadier. A beat passes before Catra stands and gestures for Bow and Adam to do the same. “Let's try to find a way out of these stupid Woods. When we get back to Bright Moon, we're gonna have to vouch pretty hard to get my mom to let you stay, but I think our little warrior princess might seal the deal.” Adam's cheeks turn pink.

Hours seem to pass before they finally see the edge of the Woods opposite of Bright Moon. Here a small, bustling village butts up against the Whispering Woods. Catra stops the group just before

they leave the woods and head into town. “Blondie.” She says, turning around and looking at Adam. “You didn't bring any other shirts I take it?”

“N-no? Why?” Adam raises an eyebrow worriedly, before the implication seems to hit him. “Shit,” His expression darkens. “I've got a giant symbol on my back that screams evil.” He groans, eyeing the sleeves of his Horde uniform. “If I get to stay in Bright Moon, I’m gonna need a new white shirt.”

Catra chuckles and rolls her eyes. “Bow, head into town ahead of us, find something, maybe a cloak or a coat, that Adam can wear over the white shirt.” She's glad she caught this before it blew up into watching the townspeople burn Adam at the stake. Catra hasn't had time to really process that she is sitting with the next She-Ra at all, but when Bow heads into the village, the insanity of it all begins to dawn on her.

When Adam takes a seat on the ground, Catra sits beside him and just looks at him for a moment. Eventually, he catches her staring and blushes crimson. “Is something the matter, your majesty?” He asks quietly, nervous tapping his finger on his knee. The use of the title surprises Catra, as it's not one that often is reserved for her and especially not from Horde cadets.

“I'm just- you're the She-Ra.” She says, unable to keep the awe out of her voice. “No one's seen her in a thousand years and I'm the lucky one to get to see her first?” She shakes her head in disbelief. “Seems like a fever dream to me. I mean even the circumstances are insane! She-Ra’s never been a man!”

Adam seems to tense at the usage of the word to describe him, but if he's bothered by it he doesn't let her know. He sighs, looking upward as if the sky was supposed to give him some kind of answer to an unvoiced question. Catra sits there for a while, just observing this person who couldn't be any older than she is yet acts in some ways like he’s lived a thousand years. She's not given much time to ponder it any further, though, as Bow quickly returns with a cloak in hand. He hands it to Adam, who slides it

on over his white shirt and looks positively enthralled with it. The hooded garment sits on his shoulders and hangs down just enough to cover his upper torso, including the symbol on his back. Catra chuckles at his wonder, as the cloak hides his shoulders and chest in a way that intrigues him. She'd say if he already looked a bit feminine, the cloak adds to it.

"C'mon," She says, climbing to her feet. "Let's go check this place out. We can find our way back to Bright Moon from here." Bow and Adam nod, following her into the quaint little town. The townspeople look like they're holding some kind of festival, with food and dancing and music all around. Adam seems almost overwhelmed, looking as though he's never seen such festivities before.

Bow laughs, putting his hand on the blonde's shoulder in a brotherly way. "You look like you've never seen a festival like this before!" Adam rubs his arm sheepishly, to which Bow gasps in surprise. Adam shakes his head in response, confused. The archer frowns, looking Adam squarely in the eye. "You know what a festival is, right? Like a big party? They *do* have parties in the Fright Zone, right?" To that, Catra glares at Bow for using the word when they're supposed to be keeping a low profile. All it does is earn a chuckle from the archer. "C'mon Catra, this is serious! Adam's never been to a party!"

So Catra ends up playing third-wheel to Bow and Adam enjoying the festivities (maybe more than she would like, considering the circumstances). Adam clearly has never seen much of anything outside of training drills and ration bars, so every moment of the celebration seems to be a shock to him. It actually sort of pains Catra a bit to see, because as the day goes on and he relaxes Adam looks less like a Horde soldier and more like a sheltered little kid. She can't help but see herself in the boy, getting to see the world for the first time. Why did she become so bitter?

Suddenly, she's reminded exactly why. The sounds of screaming townspeople fill the air, gunfire ringing in the distance. Adam stiffens at the sound as if it wasn't his first time hearing it. Catra

sees the panic in his eyes as he seems to click together pieces of a mental puzzle. Seconds go by that seem like hours before he grabs Catra by the shoulders, eyes wild with animalistic fear.

" *This* is Thaymore?!" He says in what can only be described as a low, panicked growl. "This isn't a fortress! They said it was a fortress!" He lets go of her, grabbing handfuls of his hair frantically.

"Adam, slow down. What are you talking about?" Catra says calmly, her voice wavering a bit as the gunfire draws closer. She's never been this close to a battle like this before. The sounds aren't pretty, reminding her how haunted her father once looked from the war.

"They said they were attacking a rebel fortress in Thaymore. This isn't a fortress! These are just innocent people!" His tone grows more angry and hopeless with every word before the emotions seem to boil into angry tears in his eyes. Catra watches him blink them back and turn. "I just need to talk to them. I'll fix this, I'll make them stop." With that he storms off towards the sounds of the Horde incursion.

"Adam, wait!" Catra calls out, but to her dismay he ignores her. She doesn't have time to process everything though, as Horde bots begin to pour over the hill into town. Instinct begins to take over and she unsheathes her mechanical claws, readying her stance. A force bumps against her back as Bow joins her with an arrow drawn. A second passes before she makes the first move, sinking claw after claw into their individual armor. The bots are made of harder metal than she expected, which makes her wince as she feels the damage it's doing to her precious weapons.

Guess I'll need to replace the blades again . She thinks. She'd never used them in this capacity, but training with them had over the years caused them to dull to where they'd need replacement tips for each finger. It took her a few tries to nail down how to make them on her own, the first attempts requiring help from Bow on more than one occasion. She makes a mental note for

Bow to help her find a better alternative to plain steel, if the bots were going to dull them this much.

“I won't lie to you Bow. I think we're dead in the water.” Catra drawls, picking another bot off. “This was a really bad idea and we're worse off for it. I shouldn't have insisted we stay in the Woods. I led us here to this fate and now they're whittling us away until we collapse. Mom was right, and I really hate to say that.” She groans as one gets a good shot at her leg.

“You say that like you're giving up! I'm no soldier, Catra, I'm a tinkerer! You've always thought I was so special but you- you were born to lead this fight! You're a brilliant tactician and leader, not to mention an even better friend. If we have to go out fighting side by side like this then you and I both know it won't be without damn well trying our best to stand our ground!” Bow dodges a blast aimed for him, before stabbing the robot it originated from in the eye and giving them a momentary reprieve. He grabs Catra's shoulders and pulls her into a hug she very much hates to admit she needed. When he lets her go, he grins at her cheerfully. “Now how are we gonna get out of this, Commander?”

The words of her best friend stab through like knives. He's right, she needs to think fast. It takes only seconds for Catra to realize she's still got the sword on her back, right where she left it after taking it from Adam during their encounter with the rock beast. She draws it, feeling its unfamiliar weight in her hands and looks to Bow decisively. “Adam needs this.”

“Can we trust him?” Bow asks, firing a volley of arrows at a bot approaching the pair. Catra looks at the sword, at the writing engraved on its side, and remembers that childlike wonder Adam had when seeing the festival. The way he got so angry he wept upon his first realizations that the Horde were evil, only hours ago. Every sight, sound, and taste were new revelations to him and it wasn't because he was evil, it was because he didn't know anything else. When you live your entire life with a blindfold

covering your eyes, removing it for the first time can seem like an impossible thing. Colors, shapes, and textures you were told were impossible suddenly become reality. Culture shock.

She gestures at Bow to follow her, nodding. “We can. You saw the way he looked at this place. He's not evil, not like them, he's just never known better.” The two run, sprinting to close the gap between them and Adam, who appears to be talking to a purple haired girl rather emphatically. It had only been about two hundred feet, but with Horde bots pouring from every direction it felt like miles.

When they reach him, the purple haired girl is shocking Adam with a baton, painfully. He’s groaning, crying out as electrical shocks course through his body. Bow reacts quickly and fires a net arrow at the purple haired girl. The arrow knocks her off of her feet, which gives the pair enough time to help Adam stand. He looks genuinely surprised to see them, looking back and forth between the two as if they shouldn't be here. “You came back for me.”

Catra thrusts the sword into his hands in response. “Don't let me down, Princess. The people of this village need their She-Ra. You want to be someone? Help people? Choose this.”

She watches Adam seem to panic, mulling it over for a moment before he shuts his eyes tight and raises it to the sky. Time is a blur when She-Ra makes her reappearance. She cuts down bots so quickly Catra thinks they must be made of paper. The magicat grabs Bow by the arm and leads him to the houses, where the two of them begin to evacuate the last of the people still hiding out in the town. There's about to be a mass exodus to Bright Moon, and Catra wants to make sure the She-Ra leads them there.

Before long, the trio have herded everyone to the path toward the kingdom, walking ahead of them in case of further danger. Adam is still in She-Ra form, using the warrior princess’s influence to lead the orphaned inhabitants of Thaymore towards the haven of

Bright Moon. Without She-Ra, Catra isn't sure they'd have made it. She had appeared and cut through so many bots in no time flat, giving the three of them their opening to lead the remaining people of Thaymore away. Finally, hours of walking later, they find themselves before Catra's mother, who could not be more unhappy.

"You went directly against my wishes and then you brought a Horde soldier into Bright Moon?!" Angela's brow furrows in clear frustration, letting out a huff that reminds Catra all too much of herself.

"Mom, I know how this looks-" Catra starts.

"No, Catra, clearly you don't! You've defied my wishes more than once! First you supply battle plans to Juliet without my approval and now you're sneaking off to battle? If you continue I will be forced to strip you of your title and command!" Angella continues to rant angrily, her words echoing all around the throne room. Catra's frustration bubbles just under the surface, at any moment threatening to boil over and begin an argument Catra knows will not end once it begins.

"MOM!" Catra yells loudly enough to make herself lightheaded. The explanation catches in her throat as she tries to give it. She realizes she hasn't quite grappled with the implications of it all yet. Her mother needed to understand Adam's importance first. "This isn't just any Horde soldier. This is-" She hesitates. "This is the She-Ra!"

Stunned silence follows, and Adam seems to hold himself in embarrassment. Catra can practically see the anxiety in the blonde's face, likely thinking it should be someone else. She resolves silently to talk to him later about it, should she get the chance.

Finally, Angella speaks. She's calm, but her voice drips with frustration. "I love you, Catra, but do you think I am a fool? I'm trying to keep you safe, child! I'm trying to keep the last vestige

of my family alive!” She slumps back into her throne, rubbing her forehead in exhaustion. “You're all I have, daughter. I can't lose you too, not after your father and Glimmer.”

Adam perks up at the mention of Glimmer. The intrigue on his face suggests a knowledge Catra can't guess at. “Miss Catra's mom, ma’am? If I may, who is Glimmer?” Catra eyes him carefully, not quite knowing where he's heading with this. He could strike a nerve just talking about it.

Angella tilts her head curiously. “She is- was my daughter. The Horde took her from me many many years ago now. Why might you ask?” A worried look flashes across her face, as if she's not certain the direction the conversation is taking.

“She wouldn't happen to have pink hair and the ability to teleport would she?”

A vacuum seems to open between Angella and the trio, big enough to swallow them all whole. The emotion in the room has been forcefully sucked from around them, replaced with an anxiety that could break even the strongest willed. The Queen stands, approaching Adam. "What?" Angella asks, quietly enough Catra isn't sure she actually heard it at first. “You- that can't be. How could you know that?” The queen seems on the verge of something Catra's only seen once before, after the death of her father: hysteria.”

“She’s the leader of the cadet squad I was part of in the Fright Zone. Practically the commander's protege, honestly. Everything Glimmer knows about magic has come from her up to this point. She- she was the only one who stood up for me there.” Adam says somberly, looking at his hands.

Angella doesn't say a word, her eyes seeming to glaze over as Catra watches her contemplate everything she's just said. Catra can't help but feel a hint of frustration that embellishes the numbing, deafening sadness lining her mood. She knows her mother is in shock. Hell, Catra wouldn't know how to respond

either, considering she just found out her sister is alive and is a Horde soldier and now apparently this thousand year old sword princess is going to save the world. So why does she feel so angered by it? Why does she want her mother to just say something already and break the silence?

A *thump* echoes throughout the room as Angella suddenly crumples to the ground gracelessly.

"Mom!"

Chapter End Notes

Thanks for reading! I've decided to adapt Adora's arc to represent my original vision much better. This chapter is very similar to the original but it's been polished and redone in many ways. As I adapt each chapter, there will likely be some parts I keep or change around to better fit the story I'm telling. In this instance I took the throne room scene from chapter 3 and added it to the end as a cliffhanger, which I felt was more appropriate than the scene break in the original after Angella faints.

The rewritten chapter 3 is finished as well! I just need to edit it and it'll be out sometime soo

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter II: The World Is A Vampire

Catra's footsteps through the hallway are heavy. She's been tasked with retrieving Adam from his makeshift cell in the spare room to meet with her mother, who fainted just the day before. Angella remains under observation after a minor panic episode. Adam's revelation about Glimmer was a hard hit for her, more than it could ever be for Catra. She'd never truly known the girl, which realistically meant she wasn't able to feel anything but concerned about Angella's well being.

She hates that she never got to know her, though. What was Glimmer like? Would they have gotten along? Catra doesn't think she's sisterly material by any means, but she supposes that's not something anybody is just born being. She definitely thinks she might've spent a lot less time being lonely after Micah's death at least.

When she arrives at the door, Catra knocks three times. A beat passes before she receives a loud *thump* in response, as if someone tumbled or knocked something over. It takes another moment or two before Adam opens the door, eyes panicked for a moment before he realizes it's her. "Everything ok in here?" Catra chuckles, looking up at Adam. The blonde looks tired, like he hasn't slept in weeks, and his hair is tousled and ratty, unkempt from a night spent without so much as a shower. "Heard something fall over."

He turns red, nodding his head in that stoic way of his. "Tripped over some stuff as I was coming to open the door. I've got the coordination of a newborn deer." He laughs, though it's tinged

with a melancholy embarrassment. Catra swears she sees something else going on behind his eyes every time she looks at him, something just under the surface she can't quite place, almost like he's a piece of the wrong puzzle shoved into the box. “What can I help you with, your majesty?”

Catra groans. “Please stop calling me that. Catra is fine.” She jerks her head behind her towards the hall. “Mom wants to ask you some questions. A lot of information has come to light all at once, after all.” Catra considers for a moment that statement. It wasn’t just a *lot* of information, it seemed to be *all* of it. Years of finally answered questions barreled into Bright Moon in the form of Adam and She-Ra, bringing with him more mysteries in their place.

“Not much of a cell is it? Not if I can leave when I want.” He mutters observantly. It was true that he was technically a prisoner in the spare room, but the magicat had decided that Adam had had plenty of moments to make a run for it and had yet to make that choice. The least she could do was offer him sanctuary in order to ease his transition into life after the Horde, especially if it was as difficult as he made it seem.

“Yeah well, you saved my ass out there and I have a feeling you’d do it again. Can’t say that doesn’t warrant some leniency.” Catra chuckles, nudging him in the arm. She sees Adam smile again, and though Catra had only known him a day and a half, she doubted he did that very much before Thaymore. After a passing moment they finally step through the infirmary doors. The chief healer in Bright Moon greets them warmly, shaking both Adam and Catra's hands. Angella sits up in bed behind him, smiling sadly at the pair as they step through the door.

“How are you feeling, ma’am?” Adam says with a small bow. “I hope the past day hasn't been too hard on you. I apologize if I was too forward with my information before.” Adam's words seem to relax Angella, who nods at him soberly. She gestures them into the chairs she's had the healers place beside her bed.

“It is not your fault, child. You had no idea of what she is to either of us. If it clears your conscience, I forgive you regardless.” She looks to Catra. “As for you, Catra, I owe you an apology. You are not a little girl anymore. What you've done here- it must be fated to have happened. She-Ra hasn't been seen in a thousand years, and if you are to be her guide, I must say she cannot have asked for a better one.” Catra fights the urge to cry, the woman’s recognition meaning much more than Angella could ever know.

“Uhm, sorry, ma’am.” Adam interrupts with a little wave. “I'm still not so sure how I feel about all this. Catra said She-Ra is a woman, and I mean, when I transform that's definitely true. But if Etheria chooses the She-Ra, why me? Why a troubled Fright Zone kid who, until yesterday, was going nowhere pretty fast? I mean-” He scoffs. “I’m no hero! I just hit stuff!”

“In due time, child, I am certain you will find the answers you seek. I have lived long enough to know that these things are fickle, but I have faith in you.” She grimaces and shakes her head. “As for the other looming issue: my darling Glimmer is alive. The revelation that you and she were close brings many questions to me.” Angella sighs. “The biggest of which is this: Does she know? That is, that she is kidnapped Bright Moon royalty?”

Adam shakes his head. “She assumes she was an orphan the Horde took in, same as most of us cadets. Our squad in training was made up of them.” He hesitates, taking a moment to ground himself. “Glimmer and I- we were closer to each other than the other squad members. Our caretaker was-” Catra notices his hands shaking as he seemingly tries to quell his anxiety on the subject. “She thought I was trying to outdo Glimmer, so she would use magic to p-punish me for it. Your daughter had to get between her and I many times.”

“This caretaker, who is she? A Horde Force Captain?” Angella asks gently, sensing Adam's discomfort at the subject. Catra can tell her mother has gathered something she hasn't yet, a piece of key information she's hoping Adam will directly confirm for her. If it’s

as dire as Angella's furrowed brow makes it seem, Catra worries what the answer will bring.

Adam shakes his head. "Not a captain, a commander. *The* commander. Shadow Weaver." Catra's blood runs cold at the revelation. *Shadow Weaver?* The same one who murdered her father? *That's* who has raised Glimmer all these years? She stands, kicking the chair away and walking to the opposite wall of the healing wing. She's facing away, but she knows Angella is giving her that worried motherly look she always gives when she's upset. Rage surges through her a moment too long and she cries out as her fist collides with the solid brick wall in front of her.

She hears Angella begin to cry softly. "I'm so very sorry, Adam. I'm sorry you were subjected to the whims of that evil woman. To think that the Horde has been kidnapping children to raise as soldiers. Why must it be them? Why must they be the ones to fight this war for us?" Her voice carries a hint of sorrow in it, something Catra has only heard once before: when her father died. Catra takes a deep breath, walking quietly back to her mother's bedside.

"You two are free to go." Angella says somberly, as if she's heard enough. "The healers say I can leave later today, Catra, if you could meet me in the throne room this afternoon?" Catra nods, gesturing at Adam to follow her. Neither of them say a word until they reach the spare room.

"Catra," Adam mutters, entering the makeshift cell that was his new bedroom. Catra follows close behind and sits on the unmade bed inside. The blonde just stands, staring for a moment at the princess before finding his nerve. "You mentioned your dad before. Did Shadow Weaver kill him too?" Her heart stops beating for a moment at the pointed question, before a conflicting set of emotions present Catra with a choice: lash out in rage as she did in the infirmary, or take a deep breath and be pragmatic.

She decides more anger isn't worth it, not today. "Yeah. Five years ago. He went out looking for Glimmer, actually, and he never

came back. Juliet- the general, she told us they were ambushed. She only made it out because my dad distracted the Horde." The words are difficult, coming out through futile attempts to remain calm. She never likes telling this story, not when it still hurts like this. Her aunt, Micah's sister, told her once that time healed wounds, but it seems now that they only keep getting bigger.

"I'm sorry." Adam says, taking a seat beside her. He looks at her with a gaze that screams of unnecessary guilt. "I looked up to the Horde so blindly and- and I should never have. I was the perfect impressionable young man, you know? Never questioned anything a day in his life." He scoffs, looking down sadly. "You know out there, when I tried to talk to her, she told me she knew the entire time?"

Catra's guts seem to twist into a knot at the insinuation. "What do you mean?" She asks, not willing to believe it for a second. Catra was just a baby her family happened to adopt but- Glimmer was their blood. She was supposed to be the best parts of Micah and Angella combined. The image of the person she'd never known- this betrayed that entirely.

"Glimmer knew. She knew the Horde was evil the entire time. Which-" He chokes back a sob, his face contorting into anger and pain. "Which means my best friend is willingly choosing to do evil." Catra sees his heart break in real time as the gravity sets in for him. She's not sure how to feel yet about it, having only that mental image of her sister to go off of, but what she does know for certain is that Adam is hurting badly.

"Do you need me to stay with you for a bit?" Catra asks, feeling awkward. She needs to get better at this whole feelings thing fast if this kind of thing is going to happen much more frequently. Adam is the first new person in her circle in years and she felt strangely protective of the boy after his whole world seemed to come down around him.

Adam sighs, shaking his head. "I'll be fine." Behind his long blonde locks hide eyes that look so tired Catra can hardly believe they've

lived only about as long as she has. It's really only this moment now that Catra gets a good look at the former cadet, at the way he seems to make himself smaller as if he's trying to hide away.

“You promise?” Catra says, looking at him intensely. “That you will? ‘Cause I want you to get me the first moment you aren't. I'm just down the hall and I don't mind just hanging for a bit if you need to ease your mind. Bow used to do that for me.” She smiles softly as she stands, neither of them saying much of anything for a moment.

“I promise.” Adam says, sounding sure. “I just need some time to process this alone, if that's alright your ma-” He hesitates, catching himself. “If that's alright Catra.” Catra doesn’t miss the formality Adam avoided using just now. The magicat has noticed he has an innate deference to authority, one that she fears could be used against them. If someone told this kid to dive into a lake of piranha, he might actually do it and then some. She didn’t want to see him do something he’d regret later just because someone in charge told him to.

She shuts the door behind her, remembering her mother's request to meet her in the throne room. It's only been an hour or so, but by now they should have finally let her leave the infirmary. Catra knows her mother hates to be cooped up, so the first chance to leave she definitely has taken.

She enters the throne room quietly. Her mother rubs at her temples furiously, as if she’s attempting to keep an incoming headache from occurring. The magicat stays subtle as she approaches Angella, worried she may interrupt the woman while she's deep in thought. She stands there for a moment before she works the nerve up to say something. “Mom?” She says softly, her mother briefly jumping in her seat before seeing her and smiling in that sad, soft way Catra has become so familiar with.

“Ah, I didn’t expect you to be so punctual, my daughter.” She teases. Catra burns bright red at the insinuation, but pushes it down and doesn’t say anything for now. Angella chuckles warmly

with an unfortunately infectious smile that soon spreads to Catra herself.

“Hey now, I’m not always late.” Catra retorts with a grin. “Sometimes I’m just- you know, on kitten time!” Her mother groans, stifling a laugh. ‘Kitten time’ was what her late father had called Catra’s constant oversleeping and missing important events. Though she wasn't nocturnal, she still had a biological clock that ran differently from those of most Etherians. She had loathed the joke at the time, but these days, she used it to tease her mother when the opportunity arose. A moment passes and Catra’s expression grows more serious. “You wanted to see me?”

Angella sighs, grasping the bridge of her nose. “Any other day I’d have given you some time off after what you went through just days ago but-” Angella looks up at Catra soberly. “Plumeria and Salineas have been blockaded. The Plumerians haven't had food for weeks and are only now calling for our aid.”

“Aren’t they just a bunch of like, non-violent flower people? What does the Horde want with them?” Catra inquires. The Horde usually went after strategic targets like Thaymore, which sat at the edge of the Whispering Woods that bordered Alliance territory. They’d usually leave less problematic peoples alone until they could assimilate them.

“That is what concerns me. The Plumerians are trying to avoid yet more conflict. I cannot say I blame, but at times like these we must be able to adapt. The Horde likely want something in particular if they're blockading Salineas as well, which only screams of bad news to me. Unless-” Angella frowns, her eyes suddenly filling with concern. “Unless they don't want something, but rather want to keep someone *away* .”

Catra catches on fast to what the queen is implying. “You're saying that they want to keep She-Ra away from them.” Her mother confirms her fear with a small nod. “Because She-Ra could bring together a new alliance.”

“She is a symbol as much as she is a warrior. She-Ra could convince even the most pacifistic of people they too can fight.“ Angella looks at Catra intensely. Behind her eyes is a passion the magicat’s never seen before. “I want you to show them that the fire of the Alliance is alive and well. Have Adam transform into the She-Ra and prove to them that Etheria's spirit prevails. I am not one for violence, Catra, but when the Horde threatens our people I cannot ignore it. Not anymore.” Angella shakes her head. “Walk with me to the war room. I've already had Juliet gather Bow and Adam.”

Catra follows her mother into the hallway. “Adam, uh- well he probably looks like hell. He kind of had a bit of a breakdown after we left the infirmary this morning.” The magicat avoids mentioning directly why. The details aren't important, and the information Adam had divulged to her was damning enough to send Angella into another fainting spell.

Angella nods. “He is just beginning to unlearn all of what the Horde taught him. It is likely extremely taxing on him.” She shakes her head as she holds the door for Catra to enter the large room. She doesn't like this room very much, as the worst memory of her life happened just twenty feet away from where she stands. Her hand aches just remembering the way she attacked that solid wood table.

The queen takes a seat at the front of the room, waiting patiently for the trio to shuffle inside and take a seat. Beside her is Juliet, who looks tired as always. Catra wonders if the general gets any sleep ever. She doesn't get much time to ponder that idea, though, because as soon as the three have taken their seats Angella begins.

“I'm sure you're wondering why I've brought you all together this afternoon. Especially so soon after some of us have already spoken just hours ago.” Angella chuckles, looking at Adam and Catra. Her eyes turn serious. “Truthfully, it pains me to do this, but I'm beginning to sense a new chapter in Etheria’s history unfolding and I can no longer tarnish my husband's name by

refusing to take part in it. War is once again at our doorstep, and it has brought me the She-Ra as an opportunity for change. Juliet, please prepare the declaration."

Catra furrows her brow, confused. "What are you getting at here, mom?" The woman's formality comes as a surprise. When matters involved her and Bow in the past, she'd never heard her speak so directly and firmly about things. Angella passes a paper to Catra, one that immediately answers one question and opens another.

PROCLAMATION OF A NEW COALITION OF ETHERIAN PRINCESSES

"It is my intention, Catra, to form a new Princess Alliance. I sense a dark cloud on the horizon, my daughter, and my instincts are unfortunately rarely wrong." Angella shakes her head. Catra is inclined to agree with her about that, she'd never seen the woman's gut steer them wrong in the past. "Here and now, on the foundations of the coming conflict, I ask you three to indulge the Plumerians in their request for assistance in the face of their blockade." She turns to Adam, who looks away nervously. "Adam, child, you will be a key element here. The people need to see that She-Ra has returned, so I urge you to utilize her to your advantage. If the Plumerians need help, do not hesitate." Her gaze is intense and Catra can see Adam nearly crumble under it for a moment before he finally nods.

She then turns to Bow. "Bow, you are an asset in the field of machinery and technology. I ask that you work to improve our weaponry and armor as much as you can. For you I am creating the position of Tech Master. Utilize everything we have to combat the Horde's invasive and exploitative technology." Bows eyes light up with a grin. Catra stifles a chuckle at the boy's excitement over the job. She's happy to see it.

"And finally, my daughter, Catra. Please kneel down." Confusion sweeps Catra's body, but she does as she is told, getting out of her chair and kneeling before her mother like many of the soldiers do. Her mother taps her shoulders one at a time, softly. "It is with

great honor and pride that I name my daughter, Princess Catra of Bright Moon, the first Commander of the newest incarnation of the Alliance of Princesses. You will lead our efforts as your father did, and I know for a fact you will make him proud."

Catra fights the urge to burst into tears. Instead she stands straight up and salutes her mother, brow furrowed with determination. "I won't let you down, your majesty." She hears Bow and Adam clap quietly behind her, and as she returns to her seat the boys give her excited smiles.

Angella smiles. "Now then, what shall we call our band of freedom fighters? Surely we're no alliance, not yet, and I'd rather not use the name of the last one. We'd best distance ourselves from the mistakes my husband and I made in the past during the Rebellion." She looks around the room, awaiting an answer from the group before Adam raises his hand to give a suggestion.

"In the Horde, we don't call you Rebellion *or* Alliance, ma'am. We have another word for you. In Hordespeak, I mean. *Ztensopír:* It means 'counterforce', or in more plain terms, 'resistance.'" The room seems to stop at Adam's use of the language. Catra's never heard of the Horde speaking a different language entirely from Etherian. She supposes she can hear traces of an accent in Adam's voice, but it must not be very commonly used if he doesn't have much of one.

"Well then," Angella starts, unphased. "I like it. It has a sharpness to it that speaks for itself. The Resistance, it is." Catra notices something in her voice that she hasn't heard in some time, and for once, she thinks she and her mother might be on the same page. "Get some rest and prepare for your journey ahead. Dismissed."

Rather than leave the room, though, Catra waits for everyone to file out so she can talk to her mother privately. "You've got that twinkle in your eye. The one I haven't seen since before dad died." Catra says somberly. "You feel it too, then?" The magicat

senses Angella knows what she's talking about, and her suspicions are confirmed when the woman smiles sadly and looks away.

"I lost my way when your father passed. I hadn't known how far it had left me until you brought me Adam. To think, in my lifetime the She-Ra could return. It is as if Etheria itself wants to remind me who I really am and I can no longer choose to ignore it." She turns back to Catra. "If I am once again being called to fight for our future, for the sake of Etheria, then I am also going to fight for the past. For everyone we lost, including him." Angella smiles softly. "Though I must ask that you try to stay out of trouble?"

Catra nods. "Of course. Violence is never the first resort, no matter how inevitable it seems." She remembers her father's lessons well and hopes wherever he is he's proud of her at least.

"Get some rest, my daughter. You have a lot to do tomorrow." Angella smiles, a glint in her eye that Catra doesn't quite recognize.

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The trio reaches the edge of Plumeria just after sunrise. It isn't a large place, only host to a large area of farmland and the little town beside it, if you could even call it that. The buildings weren't really buildings but rather large tents, lining along a dirt road all in a row. The people here have chosen pacifism because they have always been simple farmers, but now a great evil threatens their very existence.

Catra feels like death, she hasn't gotten this little sleep in years practically, but she fights it for the sake of the mission ahead. She stops just before the reach town, gesturing at Adam and Bow behind her. "Adam. Turn into She-Ra. These people haven't had a steady supply of food in weeks. They're likely exhausted and demoralized. She-Ra will raise that morale." Adam nods,

transforming into the warrior. The Princess of Power looks down at herself in awe and Catra swears she sees a sparkle in her eye that Adam lacked a moment before, truly taking in what she is and can do in this form. Catra then turns to Bow. “I need you to scout ahead. Intel says the crops are poisoned. If the Horde’s presence is more than just a simple blockade, we need to know. I have my trackerpad, report in regularly so I don’t have to worry you’ve been caught.”

Bow grins. “As if! I’m not that clumsy!” Catra shoves him, shaking her head fondly. It wasn’t Bow’s first run in with the Horde, but she certainly didn’t want to make it his last. Through thick and thin he’s been her best friend for much longer than she’s ever felt she deserved.

“She-Ra!” A voice calls and Catra nearly groans out loud. She’d been hoping to go into town so they could get their bearings, but She-Ra herself is about as subtle as a machine gun. Thankfully, the person who's seen them looks as if she’s Plumerian royalty, wearing a long pink dress with a green robe draped over her arms behind it. Atop her head sits a flower-adorned green tiara that seems to be keeping her long, blonde hair out of her face. “It's really you!” The blonde woman approaches, smiling warmly.

She-Ra looks nervous, chuckling. “Y-yes! It's me, here to help!” She seems to stammer at the sound of her voice, as if she’s surprised that the voice that escapes her sounds so unlike that of Adam’s. Catra can’t say she blames her, if her signature rasp was suddenly replaced with someone else’s voice entirely every so often, it would throw her for a loop practically every time.

The newcomer grabs Catra's gloves hand and shakes it with a grin. “You must be Princess Catra. I've heard a lot about you.” Thunder claps overhead and a brief look of irritation clouds the woman's gaze before resolving back to her smile. The magicat is not bad at reading subtlety, if only thanks to Angella, and can sense a deeper frustration behind the brief glare at the sky the woman gives. “Let's get to the village shall we? We can talk inside!” The robed woman leads her and She-Ra to a large tent-

like building at the end of the road that seems to represent the head of the small farming village.

Inside, it's much more building-like than Catra expects, despite mostly still being a tent. The foyer of the small royal building is adorned with flowers, a wreath hanging off an adjacent support beam while potted plants sit in practically every corner. The floors are still dirt but rugs seem to distract from that in every room. As they walk Catra sees small rooms of every kind, one that seems to be a shelter room filled with cots, one with a workbench and tools sitting on top of it, and the room that the woman is leading the magicat towards: a large meeting room with a wooden table in the center.

A nagging memory begins to bother Catra as she leads the pair in. There hadn't been any word of a princess here in Plumeria. Her mother had mentioned a Prince, but she had yet to see any other Plumerians at all. "You must be Princess…" Catra probes, suspicion setting in as she takes a seat across from the woman.

"Perfuma. Welcome to Plumeria. We've been told you were coming to end the blockade." Perfuma nods, smiling again with looks between both She-Ra and Catra. A confused look crosses her face. "Though, I was told there'd be three of you."

"Bow is scouting the Horde's fortifications." Catra says plainly. "We wanted to make sure we had all our bases covered. The Horde is more than capable of surprises." Catra shakes her head as Perfuma nods in agreement. In the corner of her vision she sees She-Ra nervously tapping her finger on the table.

"Unfortunately true. When this blockade began we'd still been able to trade with Seaworthy, but they've since been blockaded even worse than we have. With this and our crops dying, it's been quite tiring." She sighs, looking down at the table. "I just hope She-Ra can heal them with her powers." The woman's gaze seems genuine, but Catra can't help the sinking feeling she's beginning to feel in the back of her mind. Where are all the Plumerians?

“I can?” She-Ra says in surprise. “I- I mean, of course I can! I can totally do that!” She side-eyes Catra so aggressively the magicat thinks they might roll out of her head. They’d only had a couple of days to get some training in with She-Ra, certainly not enough for her to learn to do anything massively important like heal things.

As if by some saving grace, a soaking wet Bow quietly lets himself into the room. He looks worried, taking a seat beside them and sighing. “Horde's got much more than a camp just north of here. Small fortification guarding a piece of machinery. Couldn't get inside to see what it was but if I had to guess that's probably where the pollution is coming from.” He groans, covering his hands with his face. Catra had sent him a ping to tell him they’d be in the largest building, but between the wind and rain she had been worried he wouldn’t get it.

Catra nods. “We'll need some time to strategize. Do you have people who can assist us, princess?” The magicat uses the question to prod Perfuma about the townspeople. Plumeria might seem quaint, but it still is a fairly sized farming village with a decent population. There’s no way she wouldn’t have seen *someone* on the way in here.

A look of worry overcomes Perfuma's face, one that signals another crack in the facade she’s desperately trying to hold onto. “Plumerians are not fighters, Commander.” She doesn’t meet Catra’s eyes, instead looking at her open palms as if they held a secret she was waiting to learn.

“They'll have to be, we can't do this alone.” Catra fires back, taking the chance to drive the blade of her words into that weak spot. “Plumerian’s might not have been warriors before, but evil is on their doorstep. Are you telling me they would not stand up to defend their home? In fact, why don’t we run a poll and ask them ourselves?”

“Catra- I-”

“Where are the townspeople, Perfuma?” Catra growls, growing angrier by the second at the woman's dismissive nature. “I haven’t seen a single person since we arrived, except for you. What has the Horde done with them? What has the Horde done with the Plumerian Prince?”

“The- the prince?” Perfuma tilts her head. “There's no prince here.” The woman doesn't seem like she's lying, rather very confused about the question.

Catra raises an eyebrow. “Of course there is. About my age, blonde like you, I'd assumed you were related in some way. You don't even know who he is, do you?” Her words come through gritted teeth.

A realization seems to dawn on Perfuma, and a cackle escapes her that eases the tension in the room just a hair. “No, no, Catra. *I* am your-” She does air quotes with her fingers. “ *Prince.* Though I was born that way, I realized I preferred myself as a princess much more.” Perfuma chuckles, sighing in resignation as she is backed into a corner. “They left. All of them. The lack of food threatened to kill our young, so many of them took the children and left for Seaworthy.”

Catra slumps back in her chair. “So it's up to us then.” She'd been afraid of the possibility since they came to Plumeria, but the acknowledgement of her fears means they have to go for broke. She has to break the promise she made to her mother. “Just us four against the Horde.”

Perfuma shakes her head. “I am no soldier, it will be up to you three. To She-Ra’s ability to heal this place.” The words are sharp and final. Perfuma has no intention of aiding them in the fight.

Catra stands, gesturing at her companions to do the same. “I hope you have a place we can sleep, we'll need to rest and prepare before we take on the Horde.” She's doing her best to keep calm in the face of this woman's blatant disregard for them.

Perfuma nods. “The first door on the right in the hall, we passed it on our way in.” Catra turns, She-Ra and Bow right behind her. The room with the cots is moderately sized and seemingly made to shelter travelers weary from the road. They set themselves up in the corner of the room and take a breather. It was only about noon but Adam was passed out nearly as quickly as he had laid down. Catra supposes she should do the same if they're to attempt this at nightfall, but her brain is too restless for her to really sleep, instead forcing her to drift in and out of consciousness only briefly as she keeps ruminating on the situation.

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She isn't sure when exactly she finally fell asleep for real, but she knows that what wakes her is Adam’s quiet muttering at Bow.

“I don't know how to heal anyone. I barely know how to control these powers!” Adam mutters frantically. “I can't even stop being She-Ra for a second because what will she say when she sees me? See a broken Horde kid with no fucking idea what he's doing?!”

“Adam, breathe.” Bow puts his arm on the boy's shoulder. Catra sits up, rubbing her eyes and focusing on the two’s conversation for a moment. “There's a learning curve for everything, don't forget. The stories do say you have healing powers. If you can tap into-”

“The *stories* also say I had a magic horse!! You aren’t helping, Bow!” Adam is growing visibly panicked, his hands shaking in anxiety at the insinuation that he has to learn something so important in literal hours.

She shakes her head, standing and pacing the room. A beat passes while Bow and Adam converse amongst themselves. That

same rumination comes crawling back. They’re backed into a corner here, with no healing powers, no Plumerian militia, and a princess that seems to be indifferent to the coming battle. The room grows quiet as Adam and Bow’s voices stop, and she looks up to see them staring at her.

“I don't know how we're gonna spin this one.” Catra mutters. “Adam's done nothing wrong, but She-Ra's been gone for long enough that Perfuma is expecting him to immediately match the legends. If he can't learn to heal fast, then we’ll be screwed. Not to say we already aren't halfway there in not having any kind of support here.”

“And I wouldn't even know where to start.” Adam seethes. “It's like learning to fire a gun without knowing where the trigger is!” While that's not quite the metaphor Catra expected, he has a point. He's barely come to blows with his transformation, not to mention learning to wield the sword. “Believe me, I tried earlier! I can't heal anything yet!”

“Where is She-Ra?” Perfuma's voice rings like a cathedral bell through the room, quieting the three's argument near instantly. Catra hears Adam curse under his breath, beginning to ready the sword form transforming before she raises her hand to stop him. “Who are you?”

“Perfuma. This is Adam, the non-magical form of She-Ra.” Catra offers, standing up and gesturing for Adam to do the same. He nervously smooths out his white shirt, standing with an anxious posture that screams to Catra that he believes he's made a horrifying mistake.

“She-Ra is a *man?”* Perfuma's words cause Adam to flinch near instantly. He clearly wasn't comfortable with the forceful, slightly taken aback way she phrased it. It seems to get under his skin, his expression growing frustrated and despondent.

“Her human form is.” Catra moves to do damage control. She stands to meet Perfuma's eye. “But-”

“Stop.” Perfuma cuts her off angrily, her words surprisingly forceful. Catra senses that deep rage bubbling up within her, stepping backwards just once to give her space. “Stop lying to me. I heard you outside, that She-Ra can't heal anyone yet. You've got a lot of nerve to lie to me. You almost gave me *hope!”* Tears form at the edges of her eyes. “Now you've brought this *boy* who probably doesn't know the first thing about loss to come play hero?!”

“You think I don't know anything about loss?” Adam starts, his eyes seeming to glaze over at the insinuation.

“Adam-”

“Stop, Catra.” Adam says through clenched teeth, before turning his attention back to Perfuma. “You think I don't know what it's like to feel hopeless? To feel like I was about to lose *everything?* You wouldn't know the first thing about it, Princess. To have your best friend openly admit she's going to keep helping a faction of pure evil and *then* to top it off you find out that the person who was supposed to raise you murdered thousands in addition to her constant horrifying treatment of you?!” He seethes, clenching his fists. “Not to mention, every waking moment I wake up *wondering* if I deserve to still be alive, if I'm even *capable* of being a savior, if this suffering is my punishment from some cruel force gathered all around me!” He sighs, the fight seeming to drain out of him. “Perfuma, I can't-”

“Will you shut up?!” Perfuma growls at the boy, getting in his face. Adam steps backwards in surprise. “My people are *gone.* I'm what’s left of Plumeria and I won't let you force Bright Moon propaganda down my throat to tell me we still have a fighting chance. I want to save my *home.* You want me to join your Alliance? Your-” She puts air quotes around the next word. “ *Resistance* ?! Then perhaps you should have thought about that before promising my people- before promising *me* salvation! Don't fucking tell me I don't know anything about it when it's happening all around me this very moment!” With that, she turns and exits the guest room. Catra’s sure if this room had had a proper door

and not a tent flap, Perfuma would have slammed it. Her words seem to stir Adam to action: he reaches down to tighten the laces on his boots before looking around for the sword.

“What are you doing?” Catra eyes him suspiciously, noticing he’s no longer shaking. A pain haunts his eyes, one that Catra had only seen before during that first time they met. He looks between her and Bow contemplatively, before his gaze seems to turn to steel.

“If we can’t save Plumeria, then at the very least we’re going to avenge it.”

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The approach to the encampment is less stealthy than Catra prefers, but in that regard it’s no wonder Adam was chosen to be She-Ra, as the ‘punch first ask questions later’ approach seems to be his style with or without the sword. He’s counting on a shift change that supposedly comes around this time, replacing the morning crew with the midday one. As soon as it begins, he plans to rush the building.

“How much longer do we have?” Catra asks, growing restless. She knows the waiting game is necessary, but every minute is a minute the Plumerians don’t have. That Perfuma doesn't have.

“About ten minutes. Those guards will step away to report to the new ones and in that time we’ll sneak in and play saboteur.”

Bow looks at him, that concerned mom look ever present in his gaze as Adam speaks. “Adam, how long were you out last night?” The blonde scoffs at Bow’s words, not taking his eyes off the guards posted by the encampment door. He hasn’t slept very much in the last day, having spent all night training in the woods after his argument with Perfuma.

“Doesn’t matter. I made sure I’m ready to deal with this.” He says vaguely. Catra and Bow exchange a wordless look, but before either of them can say anything Adam speaks up again. “There it is. Let’s do this.”

The three silently sneak through the encampment door. Catra’s not sure what’s waiting for them beyond it, but she knows with a Horde base this large it can’t be anything good. Beyond the gate lies a mostly empty room save for a large, needle-like machine filled with a sickly green fluid. The point at the end pierces an enormous tree root along the ground, draining the substance into it. She curses under her breath, approaching the apparatus and looking for a shutoff valve of some kind.

“C’mon! This must be what’s polluting the crops. If we can just-” Her words are cut off by shouting from the doorway. The shift change hadn’t given them enough time to do anything but reconnaissance, being only roughly five minutes of time. Catra hears Adam curse in that strange Horde language he’d mentioned at the briefing, his hands wrapping the sword near instinctively.

“Hey! You can’t be in here without clearance!” One of the guards runs through, activating their stun baton and pointing it at them. Adam quickly rambles off a Horde clearance code, clearly hoping it will be enough to please the soldier and give them an opening to get away. Instead, the guard furrows his brow and swings the baton at him. “That code was phased out a month ago! Who are you?!” A dozen more soldiers pour in behind him at the commotion and in seconds, a brawl breaks out inside the chamber.

Catra unsheathes her claws, jumping from soldier to soldier and slashing through each one’s armor. She gets through four before one of them grabs her wrist and twists her arm behind her back painfully. “Adam!” She cries out, trying to get his attention through the sounds of screeching metal and painful yelling. Catra’s hopes are dashed when she sees Bow and Adam being

forced to the ground, the sword ripped from Adam’s hip and with it her hopes for him to use She-Ra. She too, is forced to the ground by the soldier still twisting her arm, her vision swimming as the person slams her face into the dirt and places a boot on her back.

The magicat cries out as the soldier stuns her with the baton. The first one is only a light zap and the second a slightly sharper bite, but the guard finds their setting in the third. Over and over again Catra screams as the person holding her to the ground shocks her with what feels like millions of volts of electricity every few seconds. The only reprieve she gets is the baton needing to prime again after draining all its energy into her body. Her vision goes from swimming in a kiddie pool to drowning in the ocean, her eyes struggling to stay open as consciousness tries to leave her.

Then, as if the ground is coming alive and seeking revenge, vines erupt all around Catra. They pick each Horde soldier up and fling them every which way, their bodies like ragdolls being thrown against the harsh concrete walls of the building. She feels the weight ease off her back as the one holding her down meets the same fate as the others. By the time she finds the strength to stand, she sees Princess Perfuma approaching with a sober expression. The flower princess looks at the source of the polluted crops and Catra swears she sees a flash of hatred in her eyes. She raises a hand and forces plants of every size and kind through any and all of the cracks, crevices, and gaps in the encampment. They tear it down brick by brick, annihilating the Horde base from inside out. It's nothing if not terrifying to see such skillful control over her abilities, and Catra finds herself relieved that Perfuma is on their side.

Perfuma growls as more vines take hold of the machine, grasping it so tightly it begins to crack and cave. “No more. I will not be the ruler the Plumerians are desecrated under. The Horde will not drive my people away and take advantage of our home any longer or ever again!” She screams, a guttural cry seeming to escape from the most broken part of Perfuma's heart. Vines surge from the ground and pick the machine up, ripping it from the wires and

beams holding it in place. One swift motion sends it crashing to the ground so hard Catra's ears ring, then again, and again, leaving only a useless hunk of metal in its place. Perfuma takes a deep breath, reaching a hand out to help Catra from where she is kneeling. "Are you alright?" The woman's caring, thoughtful tone returns to her voice.

Catra groans as she climbs to her feet. Her whole body is on fire, the electrical zaps seeming to have messed with a nerve or two. "Yeah, I'm shaky but I'll live. Are you?"

Perfuma laughs, surprising Catra. "I think now I am. I held such hatred for the Horde for so long, saving face because my people traditionally are not warriors." She shakes her head sadly. "I suppose the time to adapt is now. We can't sit idly by while Etheria burns, that is no better than helping the Horde willingly." She meets Catra's eyes, a determination igniting behind them. "Plumeria will join your Resistance, if not to see the Horde annihilated then to protect our home. Please, come with me to Seaworthy and help me deliver the good news. Celebrate with us, you three."

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The night comes and goes quickly, Catra imagines, for most. She doesn't drink, though, not after a brief moment where she found she was spiraling shortly following the death of her father. She'd broken into the storeroom and stolen wine constantly for what felt like months, though Angella told her it'd only been a week. She'd found out after discovering a black-out drunk Catra asleep in the courtyard, bottle in hand. The magicat had been so inebriated her hangover had lasted for days.

The festivities are almost overwhelmingly intense. Loud music that hurts her sensitive hearing mixes with a crowd of three hundred

crammed into a Seaworthy tavern that could have maybe accommodated half of them and Catra is right in the center of it, being thanked by everyone of them practically for bringing She-Ra to them. Their princess had not been short of praise either, with Perfuma getting cheers and whoops upon both her arrival and proclamation of Plumeria's survival. Catra's proud of the flowery woman, for having stood up for her kingdom and been the protector they didn't know they had all along. It was an inspiring tale: the story of a princess who cast aside expectations that her people were helpless and chose to prove them strong.

What worries her now is the amount Adam is currently drinking. She'd planned for them to stay only a day in Plumeria, but between the planning required for the attack on the base and the travel to Seaworthy itself it's been nearly four, and Adam is celebrating hard enough to make it five. It reminds her all too well of that method of hiding the pain she'd so quickly taken to at only sixteen, one she'd vowed never to repeat.

"Adam." She taps the blonde on the shoulder. He whips around, long messy locks floating all around as that dopey smile of his comes into view. He seems to be struggling to maintain his balance, drunk enough to make him stumble around like a toddler who just learned to walk.

"Catraaaaaaa!" He slurs, wobbling for a moment before embracing her in a drunken hug. She yelps as he squeezes her tight, the contact making her uncomfortable. The interaction is strange, as Adam doesn't really touch people without asking. "I missed you! You were gone too long."

"I've been here the whole time, Adam." Catra chuckles and manages to pull herself away from the hug. "Where've you been?"

"Adam?" He moans. "You haven't called me that in so long!" He's all shaky now, threatening to fall over. Tears form in his eyes, seemingly at the use of his own name. He loses his balance finally, collapsing and falling flat on his backside. A full blown sob

heaves in his chest. “Please don't call me that. That's not my name.”

“I'm sorry. What name do you want me to call you?” Catra tilts her head, looking down at the blonde. Her stomach drops as she watches him try to hold back tears, as if she’d said something that really hurt him at his core. Catra wished she knew more about the boy, but she's starting to believe she and him are on the same level, like he's still not sure himself on who he is.

“...’Dora.”

“What?” Catra gets closer, kneeling beside him. “What was that? I didn't catch it.”

“Adora.” He cries, his body shaking. He hides his face in his palms as he sobs. Catra finds the amount concerning. He's crying a lot for it to just be a sore spot. This seems more like an open wound. She realizes she has two choices, and she's not sure she likes one of them: point out that that's not Adam's name *or* oblige him for the drunken moment he's having.

“Ok, Adora.” She decides to humor him out of curiosity. The boy breaks into what aren't so much sobs as heaving attempts to rid his body of every evil fluid still left inside it. The crying doesn't stop for a second until Adam crawls to his knees and retches, throwing up onto the ground part of the horrid substance creating the emotional outburst.

It's at this point Catra's seen enough, pulling him to his feet and carrying him against her shoulder. He's much lighter than she expects, especially for someone who trains so heavily and so frequently. She limps him into his assigned room in the tavern/inn, all the while trying to keep him from soaking her in tears and vomit. When she stands to go to her own room, the blonde grabs her by the arm. She turns around to see him staring at her with a pleading look.

“Stay.” He looks down sheepishly. She sighs, sitting upright on the bed beside him. The behavior was definitely worrying her, she'd never seen someone so out of tune with himself and so alone inside. A while passes where neither of them say anything, before Adam finally speaks. “Sorry. You shouldn't have seen that.”

“I didn't see anything. You had a drunken lapse, it's not that uncommon.” Catra says pragmatically. “If I thought you meant anything you said in there, you'd know.” She smiles, nudging his shoulder with her hand lightly.

Adam smiles tiredly as he flops back onto his cot. It's quiet as he thinks for a moment, closing his eyes seemingly to try to hold his focus. “I think I hate her.” He says after a beat, his eyes remaining shut. The boy seems to sense Catra's confusion at the question. “Glimmer, I mean. I thought I knew her and I-” He scoffs.

“Really couldn't at all.” Catra finishes. He'd been avoiding the subject since he told her about the encounter at Thaymore two days ago. The pink-haired girl who Shadow Weaver shamelessly stole from Catra's parents was the only subject *everyone* was a bit sore on, especially after Adam had informed them of her presence. “Do you think she really knew you?”

Adam shakes his head. “If she had, she'd have known about the gaping void inside my head that swallows everything. The way I look at people and can't connect at all, like I'm watching through a screen. The fact that I seem to have boundless energy when really if I stop moving I die. She expected someone who wasn't broken.”

“Someone who was dedicated to the cause, not just going through the motions.” Her statement earns a nod from Adam, whose eyes remain closed as he lays quietly on the bed. After a beat, curiosity finally gets the best of her. “Who is Adora?” Catra asks, and at first Adam seems taken aback at the question, opening his eyes and grumbling. He seems to have forgotten his ramblings just over a half-hour ago, and in response huffs and looks away from her.

“I don't know.” He finally says, a tired tone coming through in his voice. “Sometimes I have dreams about her, or ones where I am her. I see a lot of things: flames, torture, people I love dying, but always it's her. I'm disembodied nearby or I'm watching through her eyes.” He stares blankly at the ceiling for a second, sighing. “My most recent one involved her being tortured by Shadow Weaver in a sterile room. I've seen others too, ever since I first picked up the sword. Adora, drowning in an icy sea after a big battle, a ship in a desert wasteland, stuff like that. The plot never makes much sense, but I'm always seeing it happen to her, never myself.”

“That explains the screaming.” Catra chuckles, earning a confused look from the blonde. “The night before we attacked the outpost you woke up screaming about something in your sleep. I couldn't make any sense of it, part of it was in your Horde language and what was in Etherian was fragments of sentences. Your connection to the sword must run so much deeper than it seems, if it's sending you dreams like that. Maybe she was the last She-Ra?” She provides. Adam sits up, curiosity piqued by the suggestion.

“It’s like the sword is trying to tell me something. Like trying to make sense of a book by only receiving a few pages at a time. Except, some of them are my memories, and I can't quite make sense of what the sword is saying if I'm her in them.” He shakes his head, grinning drunkly. “Maybe when I'm asleep my brain forgets which one I am, if it’s just constantly sending it signals, and I guess drinking just did the same thing while I'm awake. I- I wonder if it remembers every one of them or if it's just her.” The grin fades, his expression replaced with a thoughtful look around the room. “You know, when I was in the woods, before you found me, I saw a big castle that looked like it was made out of, like, gemstones. The door wouldn't open for me, but I wonder if it would open for She-Ra.”

Catra raises an eyebrow. “I’ve seen it too, once before when I was lost in the woods. Has to be important somehow. If you want Bow and I to go out there with you we can.” The blonde nods

sheepishly. Catra's not sure he's ever had someone care so deeply for him before. He talks about Glimmer like she did, but also like she couldn't do everything, and even more so like she was a liar all along. For a moment, though, Catra feels like things are gonna be alright. Like maybe her mother was right, and that she was destined to mentor the She-Ra. A sense of purpose wells in her chest as she looks at this boy who's only just learning how he fits into this larger world he's stepped into, and Catra decides here and now that she'll do everything to help him become the person their people need.

Even if it kills her.

Chapter End Notes

> Thanks so much for reading. The next one is going to be a new chapter that I skipped in the original version, so it may take me longer. Please enjoy!

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter III: An Ocean In My Soul

Flashes, as if a memory recollected. One memory, brief: She-Ra fighting Glimmer before a large magical gate. A second, subtle: An old woman, insisting Adora stay for pie. And finally, a third, painful: The feeling of freezing water surrounding Adora's body and seeming to seep into every pore. Every muscle spasms and aches as her body struggles to adapt to the temperature. She starts to panic, her heart beating faster and faster as the feeling of intense cold sending surges of adrenaline through her core. Adora nearly begins to cry, the pain so sudden and overwhelming she can't hold in her agony.

Then, the pain fades, replaced by a numbness. The panic rises in her more, as she desperately looks around in the darkness for something above the water to escape to. She struggles to swim, to stay afloat amidst the feeling of her limbs freezing from the inside out. The feeling gives way to an unholy flame as every nerve collapses in its attempt to keep her warm. Her vision grows dim, and she finds that she can't move her arms as much as she could. She's fading.

Her stomach lurches, her mind finally letting the fear take control. Tears freeze as soon as they hit her cheeks, as her very blood seems to freeze. Her vision turns to black, only coming in brief glimpses as she finally succumbs to the icy depths below the waves. Blackness surrounds her, her head hurting too much to even think about anything as the piercing pain in her lungs becomes too much.

Then, as quickly as it happened, it ends. She wakes in a desolate sea of snow, nothing around to guide her but a blinking red light in the distance. She's a ghost in the snow, a cold sun beginning to set below the horizon as she walks. Adora thinks there's only one place this could be, to have sent her here in an icy wasteland and expect her to walk after such pain just moments ago:

Hell.

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Adam awakens with a violent scream. His heart beats so fast it's practically trying to escape his ribcage. His eyes struggle in the darkness of his room in the Seaworthy inn as he tries to blink the sleep out of his eyes. He finds himself hoping they'll get home soon, so they can find that crystal building and get some answers. Something that bothers him about the dreams is just how *similar* he and Adora look, which makes him wonder if she's some kind of ancestor of his. His hand reaches to the nightstand, searching for the lamp desperately before he instead knocks both it and the book he'd been tracking his dreams in off the little table with a *thud* .

He hasn't told Catra about the book, not wanting her to see quite yet all these visceral things he's been seeing at night. He reaches down to pick the lamp up, his hand brushing against something else he'd knocked off the nightstand: a leather glove, fingerless and covered in metal parts. It's her's, one of her weapons she's grown so protective of. She said her father made these for her, once, a long time ago. Adam can't help but hold it in awe, feeling the weightiness of the metal in his hands.

"No, mom, five more minutes." A raspy voice makes Adam nearly jump out of the bed. Why is Catra in his room? He searches the ground for the fallen lamp, picking it up and placing it back on the nightstand. He flicks the switch, and instantly he's hit with the worst headache he's ever felt. Like clockwork an intense wave of nausea washes over him, bright light invading his corneas. The magicat is passed out on the floor, curled up in a way that he

can't quite imagine his spine being flexible enough to match. His attempts to carefully step around her are futile, as the pleasures of the previous night force him to practically run for the attached bathroom in the little inn bedroom. His companion must have woken when his footsteps picked up, because between bouts of vomiting he hears rustling in the bedroom behind him. A small *thump* seems to imply she's sat herself against the bathroom door, not wanting to intrude on Adam's regrets.

"Adam, are you alright?" Catra says softly. For someone who can be so brash and rough more often than not, the magicat displays a certain gentleness that still surprises someone like Adam, who'd never known anything other than the harshness of Shadow Weaver.

"Y-yeah. Hungover." He mutters back, earning a squeaky little chuckle from the other side of the door. There's no teeth in it, the humor seeming to be more out of compassion than mockery. Adam doesn't remember enough of the previous night to say what exactly got them up here, but he can't imagine it must have been fun for Catra to corral him into the bedroom if he was drunk enough to forget.

"First time, huh?" She drawls. "I had a problem once. Didn't last long but- I remember the hangover. Felt like my guts were trying to escape my body. Mom found me passed out drunk after like a week or two and started locking the castle's wine cellar. She never really had to, though, I kinda learned my lesson after that."

"I can see why." Adam groans, heaving once more. He and Catra felt close, but she is still a mystery to him in many ways. While Bow is straightforward and made sense to him, the magicat makes Adam feel all sorts of strange inside. Emotions he's not sure he even wants to acknowledge.

"Sorry, by the way." Catra begins with a sigh. "I know we decided on a day for Plumeria but- well, here we are in Seaworthy, not even thinking about going home until we figure out the situation here too. Perfuma says it's worse. I'm afraid to find out how."

Adam thinks for a moment, remembering the things Glimmer was briefed on when she was promoted. “The leader of the operation is Force Captain Octavia. She's ruthless, being chosen for dozens of sea missions for her prowess on the water. My guess is-” He enters a fit of coughs for a moment. “They’re between Seaworthy and Salineas, because this is the only trade port for them. We'll have to find someone who can maneuver between or around them.” He hears rustling from the other side of the door.

After a moment, the door cracks open for Adam to see Catra smiling softly over him. She looks tired as usual, probably more so from a night spent sleeping on the floor than stress this time, he hopes. Those mismatched eyes hide so much, Adam has learned. The pain of losing her father has run deep to her core and yet there she stands, moving forward as always and not afraid to walk this world alone. She reaches a hand out to help the blonde to his feet.

“What, no snarky comment, your majesty?” Adam reaches out a hand for Catra to help pull him to his feet. The magicat rolls her eyes as he wobbly stands upright, the world spinning for a moment as he struggles to regain any balance he could in his hungover state.

“You know I hate that, dumbass.” She drawls unamusedly.

“Yeah, but that's why I do it.” His words seem to surprise the magicat for a moment, before she breaks into signature creaky laughter.

“My own games turned against me!” She grins, grabbing Adam by the hand. “C'mon, we should get downstairs in order to make a proper plan for this maneuvering business. Can't be doing it from a tiny inn bathroom you spent the last twenty minutes emptying your guts in.”

A moment's walk and they reach the tavern bar. It's empty save for the employees cleaning up from yesterday's celebration, as well as a lone patron sitting in the corner. Chairs and tables lay on

sides or upside, the stench of wine reeking through the air, seemingly the result of a few knocked over bottles of the stuff that have yet to be cleaned. It nearly makes Adam gag, the taste of the previous night's beverages in his mouth still after this morning's extrication.

The pair sit at the tavern bar itself, the tender not paying them any attention as he continues to clean dishware. Catra waves Bow over to them, who looks like he's been awake for a bit now already. Adam had Bow pinned as a morning person the first day they met, honestly. He was too cheery this early to not be.

“Got any ideas, Catra?” He smiles, sitting on her other side. Catra retrieves her trackerpad from Bow’s pack, having stashed it in there before the excursion to the Horde fort days prior. Adam knew she took special care of it, and didn't really have a place to put the piece of tech when she wasn't holding onto it.

“We’ve got to find someone both crazy and skilled enough at sailing to weave us in and around the boats without being blown up.” She groans. “Hate risking our lives like this, but I don't see any other way.”

“I can take you there!” A tall man with a mustache grins as he approaches. He's dressed like a sailor, but not enough to flag him as one off the bat. “I know a back route the Horde isn't guarding! I'm the only one who can navigate it! What do you say?”

Adam and Catra look between each other skeptically. It takes a moment before finally their concern is broken by Bow’s voice tentatively cutting through the tension. “Do we have another choice?”

They did not. Adam stands, stepping forward and shaking the sea captain’s hand. “You say you know an unguarded route?” He asks skeptically. “If it's unguarded, that means it's dangerous. You're sure you can navigate that?”

“Of course! I've done it before! Come!” The sailor gestures at the trio to follow him out the tavern door. The light outside sears into Adam’s corneas, a direct result of the hangover he was trying to avoid thinking about. The captain walks down a set of stairs to a pier, along which a boat is docked.

“This is the Dragon's Daughter V!” He says proudly. “And I am her captain, Sea Hawk! She's the fastest and sturdiest ship on the ocean!” Sea Hawk says proudly, not taking his eyes away from the helm for a second.

“If it's so sturdy, than how come it's number five?” Adam asks, eyeing the plain looking boat with a heavily critical gaze.

“I was forced to set them aflame!” If Sea Hawk is ashamed of this fact, he doesn't show it whatsoever, instead waving them aboard the little sloop.

“You burned them?!” Catra says. She looks like she's about to be sick, as if the very notion of sailing threatens to give her a panic attack. Adam eyes her closely, noticing how uneasy she seems about the entire idea.

“It was necessary!”

“Why?” Adam says. “Sounds like you wanted to.” He sees the sea captain's expression falter for a moment before he finds his mental footing again. The statement must have struck a nerve, Adam thinks, if he's suddenly uneasy. The sea captain never answers the question, though, as before long the trio is aboard and speeding along the waves.

“I hope you know what you're doing!” Catra shouts over the sound of the intense wind at sea. Sea Hawk begins to full-speed weave between the sharp rocks that line the south side of Salineas. The magicat herself looks like she's about to jump out of her fur, holding onto the mast of the ship as if she’s about to be thrown overboard any moment as the ship hastily speeds through the natural barricade on the backside of the island. Though

they’ve only been on the water for maybe twenty minutes, Sea Hawk’s reckless sailing has made it feel like weeks. By the time the shore comes into view, Adam can see Catra practically running to get off the boat as they tie it off.

She hops onto the pier and begins to quickly walk away, he follows. “What's the matter?” Though Adam attempts a gentle tone, it still seems to bother her. Catra kicks the sand below her feet with a groan, her fists balled up so tightly Adam was worried she might break her claws. A staircase comes into view as they walk, leading up and along the side of the large cliff that towers over the beach. Catra stops and looks at it tensely, before finally turning back to Adam.

A doubt hints at itself behind her heterochromatic eyes, chest heaving in distraught vulnerability that Adam doesn’t quite expect from the princess. “I'm afraid of water.” She mutters it just loudly enough for the blonde to hear, as if any louder and the world would split in two. Adam doesn’t say so, but he had already guessed that back on the pier. She’d been looking at Sea Hawk’s boat like it was going to attack her.

“I'm sorry. Hopefully the blockade will be gone and we can sail home normally on a much less…rickety and terrifying boat.” Adam flashes a grin, which gets Catra to smirk. Good, he thinks, at least she's smiling. A funny feeling flashes across his chest, one he instinctively pushes down into the depths with the rest of his emotions. He’s not quite sure exactly what it was before he locked it away. Admiration? Envy? Concern? Adam dismisses it entirely, looking up at the set of stairs ahead of them. Before long Sea Hawk and Bow have caught up with the pair, and the four of them begin the long trek up towards the city. Salineas should be at the top, granted it still exists and hasn’t been utterly destroyed. The Horde isn’t one for immediate annihilation, rarely if ever using reckless tactics to wipe out an enemy. No, they usually sieged, starving out the population until all that remained were the precious resources housed in their territory.

Adam’s suspicions are proven correct as they reach the top. The kingdom still exists, but it looks like hell in the aftermath of the blockade. They make their way from the small side street the stairs led to, eventually rounding a corner to what Adam imagines is the main road. He looks around, the place is basically carved into this cliff, every building and structure a part of the mountain-like rock sitting alone in the sea. There are a few people lining the streets, who instantly regard the newcomers with suspicion. The group doesn’t get very far when they’re stopped by a guard.

“You there. Where have you come from? Why are you here?” The man growls, his brow furrowing. Adam notices the way he struggles with his grip on the trident, his arms seeming to struggle to hold the heavy weapon up. The guard looks weak, as if he’s not eaten in days, which he likely hasn't given the situation at hand. He looks around at the other townspeople, who regard them fearfully. Some of them point and whisper at each other, while others outright throw angry glares as if they were envoys of the Horde. It's disconcerting, Adam thinks, to see such distrust.

Catra steps forward to greet him. “Princess Catra of Bright Moon. We’re here to discuss ending the blockade with Princess Mermista.” She purses her lips grimly in a gesture that reminds Adam of Queen Angella. The more time Adam spends with her, the more similar he thinks the two are, and despite only knowing them for just a little over a week or so, he knows well enough that Catra would dislike the comparison.

“Mermista isn’t taking visitors. How’d you get here? The blockade isn’t letting anyone in or out!” The guard shoves the trident in Catra's face, who makes a point to not even flinch as the point nears her eyes.

“That would be me!” Sea Hawk grins with a theatrical bow. “I took them between the rocks!” The sea captain's jovial tone contrasts directly with the guard's reaction. His eye twitches, a scornful look creeping across his face as he processes the events.

“Sea Hawk. You took the Princess of Bright Moon through the *rocks* ?!” He growls, causing Sea Hawk to wince at the sudden shift in volume.

“I- Yes, I did. But we're all in one piece!” He smiles cautiously, earning a groan from the armed Salinean.

“Fine. Follow me. We'll go see the Princess and sort this out.” The group begins to follow the man, only making it a short distance before he stops. He turns around, pointing the trident at Sea Hawk. “You. Stay.”

“But I-”

The guard glares, and Sea Hawk backs off, taking a seat on a nearby set of stairs carved beside a shop. The group continues on without him, making their way along the road and over a small bridge to the palace. Unlike Plumeria's large tent, this place seems to be an actual castle, large and decorative as if to be the centerpiece of Salineas itself.

The throne room of the castle isn’t so much a room as it is an overlook. The entire city sits below it, situated as the base for the large building. On the outskirts of that base lies a large wall that seems to shimmer with powerful magical energy. Even further, a hundred Horde ships float in the water beyond, annihilating anyone that dares try to race past them. It's a contrast that seeks to fully demonstrate the universal truth at hand: this is war.

“I thought I told you no guests.” An unamused drawl comes from the back of the overlook. A dark skinned woman with blue hair is seated in a throne seemingly carved from the rock below it. All around her are sea shells and fossils that line the walls and floor, undiscovered for hundreds of thousands of years until the founders of Salineas unearthed them in their excavation. The throne itself is covered in such fossils, decorated naturally by the rock below as it was created.

“My apologies, Princess Mermista.” Catra says as she, Bow, and Adam approach the throne. The trio kneels, earning an irritated scoff from the woman. The sound surprises Adam, who isn’t used to a monarch so unconcerned with posterity. “We’ve come here from Bright Moon to end the blockade.”

Mermista raises an eyebrow at this. She gestures for the three to stand, furrowing her brow and looking directly at Catra. “How’d you get past the Horde? No one’s been able to do that in more than two weeks and the asshole that did it never came back.”

“A sailor named Sea Hawk weaved us through the sharp rocks and took us up the back way.” Catra offers, and Adam sees the way the man’s name shifts the water princess’s eyes from bewildered to livid. She stands up and steps uncomfortably close to the magicat, glaring as if she'd personally slighted her.

“He did *what* ?!” Mermista growls. “I send him to get help and he disappears off the fucking face of Etheria only to turn back up with you three in tow?! Let me guess, he just *waited* at the tavern in Seaworthy for someone to show up, didn't he?!” She heaves, her breath ragged with anger.

“That’s pretty much exactly what happened, your majesty.” Adam says. Mermista sighs and slumps back into her chair, groaning loudly at the revelation.

“He's lucky he's a damn good sailor otherwise I would've jailed his stupid ass just to keep him from giving us all away.” She sighs, standing and pointing out beyond Salineas. “You see that barrier? The one out there beyond the city? That keeps us safe from the Horde, or it has been. It's collapsing, and it won't be long before the whole damn thing breaks and they rush us while we're weak.” She scoffs, rolling her eyes. “Figures I’d inherit a kingdom that’s falling apart, but it’s totally fine. I’ve been handling it.”

“Why is it collapsing?” Catra asks worriedly.

“I mean, who knows? I guess it’s probably from all the attacks since the blockade started.” She turns back to the trio. “I’m no idiot. You want to rebuild the Alliance. You think it’ll work this time, don't you?” Mermista’s voice develops an angry tone that defies the unamused drawl she had just moments ago. “You’re wrong. Bright Moon’s never helped us before. Why now? I mean, how do I even know you’re actually them? Sea Hawk’s an idiot, he could have picked up any old Horde spy.”

“Those are mistakes I'm trying to fix-”

“Fix how?! Catra, in case you haven't noticed, you can't wave a hand and have everything be peachy keen! Bright Moon keeps bringing its war to Salineas and abandoning us when we need them most! How do I know you won't do the same thing you're mother did to my father?!” Mermista's indignant tone seems to get a rise out of Catra, glares angrily back at the water princess.

Catra and Mermista spar vocally for a few more minutes about the role of Bright Moon during the second Alliance. d

During this time Adam’s gaze wanders around the room, and he begins to notice the writing on the walls. They’re strange symbols, almost like letters that seem to connect together. He wanders toward a particular wall, approaching it slowly and reading what’s inscribed.

Connection to the powerful Salineas runestone required for the gate to function. Proper maintenance of barrier-stone link is necessary.

“Huh. It’s probably losing connection with the runestone.” Adam hears Mermista and Catra stop cold, a pair of footsteps approaching him to his left. He turns to face the three, receiving confused stares in response.“What?”

“Adam, you can read First One’s writing?” Bow asks slowly as he reaches Adam's side. He stares up at the writing, intrigued by the unusual symbols. “No one's been able to decipher it. My- my dads

are researchers who have spent *years* trying.” A sad undertone mixes with Bow’s excitement, one Adam can't place entirely.

“Ok, who is he again?” Mermista drawls from across the room tiredly.

“His name is Adam. In which case, Adam, could you please show Princess Mermista our secret weapon?” Catra says formally, gesturing at him to Mermista.

Adam nods, raising the sword and transforming into She-Ra. Mermista seeps captivated by the warrior woman, nearly dropping the uninterested facade for a moment before regaining her composure. “She-Ra isn't an end-all to our problems, though.”

“Actually, I believe the Sword can be used to strengthen the gate’s connection to the runestone if I've read this right.” She-Ra says, looking the runes up and down. Bow stands in visible awe beside her, the wonder of the blonde reading a millenia old language seeming to wow him. Mermista stares for a moment, groaning in defeat.

“Fine. If this works we'll consider joining your little resistance. Just don't get your hopes up.” She says, standing from her throne and gesturing to the doorway. The water princess leads them down through the streets, arriving at the hundreds of feet tall archway.

Before long, She-Ra looks up at the magical barrier in all it’s glory. She’s standing on a platform situated right at the center of the gate, with Catra, Bow, and Mermista beside her. On first glance, the gate is obviously failing, with small holes in the magical protection randomly placed throughout the entire thing. Right in front of the platform on the magical wall itself is a First One’s rune, seemingly some kind of input for She-Ra’s sword.

“Alright. Stand back.” She mutters, raising the sword and pointing it at the rune. After a moment, nothing happens and she groans. “I wish there was a manual on how to use this thing!” She-Ra mutters, looking back at the control rune. Unlike the writing in the

throne room, this seems to be a technological symbol, one that doesn't actually mean anything on its own.

She shakes her head, pointing the sword at the rune once more. This time, she closes her eyes and focuses on sending a surge of magical energy into the barrier. When she opens them again, the sword is emitting a beam that is directly interacting with the gate. It takes all of her willpower not to get excited and lose her focus.

Then, an ache begins in her side, one that seems to spread from there to her right arm, and soon over her entire torso. She opens her eyes and sees the way that her veins seem to surge sickeningly with the sword's energy. Then, the ache turns to a shock, her body seeming to not be able to cope with the high amount of magic surging through it. She tries to ground herself, but all she can hear is screaming. Screaming? She's not screaming is she? She instinctively closes her mouth, her vocal cords burning in pain as dark patches begin to blot her vision. She's losing the connection fast, she needs to put more energy into it, more concentration, more-

A gloved hand touches her forearm, just long enough for She-Ra to lose every bit of focus. She turns to look angrily at her companion, but never reaches her, instead being overcome with an intense pain in her chest. She collapses to one knee, the dark patches becoming big enough that she can no longer see directly ahead of her. Then she feels her body hit something hard as the blackness takes over.

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When Adam wakes, he's back in the throne room with no recollection of how he arrived there. He sits up, the room immediately beginning to spin as his body attempts to recalibrate. A fuzzy arm is in his peripheral vision. Catra! Catra is here, he likes her. He shakily turns to look at her, a look of concern covering her face.

“Adam.” He thinks he can hear her say. Adam! That was his name right? Or was it Adora? The dreams keep telling him different things. The fuzzy woman, Catra, his friend, she's shaking him. He feels dizzy, like his brains have been rattled around in his skull. A sound like the loudest clap of thunder echoes outside the room, seeming to shake it below the blonde.

The sensation seems to snap him into his senses. He looks over, beyond Catra, at the gate he was attempting to repair what felt like only minutes ago. Shell after shell of artillery fire slam into it, assaulting the barrier with a ferocity that could only mean it was close to collapse. Adam stands wobbily, struggling to keep the room from spinning as he approaches the overlook.

“How long?” He mutters, another boom nearly masking it entirely.

“Two hours.” Catra says somberly. “The Horde started bombarding it not long after you collapsed. There's no way we'll fix the gate while they're attacking it like this.” Adam looks back at her, grimacing for a moment at the words. “What happened? You looked- you were in pain. Serious pain.”

“It was like every inch of my body was on fire. The magic- my body couldn't handle how much of it surged through me in one moment. I need to do it even faster, try to fix it before my body gives out. I can do it, I just-”

“Adora.” The name stops him dead in his tracks, Adam turning to look at the magicat. She’s staring beyond him at the fleet of Horde ships, not meeting his eyes for a moment. “You can't. It'll kill you. We'll have to go slow.”

“What did you just call me?” He asks, looking at her confusedly. The princess returns the gaze, tilting her head as if not quite understanding his words.

“I called you Adam. Why?” Catra raises her eyebrow, her ears folding down in concern as she looks on. Was Adam going crazy?

Did he actually hear the past She-Ra's name? He decides it doesn't matter, shaking his head.

"Not important. I need a distraction if I'm going to do it slowly. Think you can provide?" He stands, the magicat following suit as they walk to the edge of the overlook.

"Which one is the flagship?" Catra points to the fleet. "We're going to the backup plan. I'm going to hijack a gunship and use it on the main one, see if I can't take it out. I'll have Mermista and Sea Hawk cover me while I get aboard a boat.

"Are you insane? You could die!" Adam stares. The woman chuckles a little coldly, looking at him with a hint of that pain she hides just below the surface at all times.

"You just offered to nearly kill yourself trying to repair the gate, dummy. You could too. So could the Salineans. It's the only chance we have. You worry about your magic She-Ra stuff, I'll find Sea Hawk and make him take me out there." She thinks for a moment, a smirk coming over her face. "I have an idea."

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Catra takes the next hour to assemble a disguise with Adam's guidance, using his knowledge of standard garb for non-humans to craft a Force Captain uniform complete with badge. It's a red sleeveless top and tight maroon pants that give her a full range of motion for fighting. A brown belt compliments the middle of the uniform where the faux badge hangs from. Finally, hidden below a gauntlet-like set of matching gloves hide her precious makeshift claws.

"Don't worry about Hordespeak. It's so rarely used outside of training exercises or official documents that most are pretty rusty at speaking it anyway. The people who know it fluently are mostly the people in Hordak's circle or whose unit used it more frequently, like mine." Adam nods. "Remember, the Horde is

vicious. Don't be afraid to knock some heads if someone calls your bluff.”

Catra grins cheekily. “Wouldn't dream of doing anything else. Are you going to be ok here?”

Adam chuckles darkly. “As long as they don’t fire a shot directly at me up there, I’ll manage.” Catra’s grin fades, the comment sending a cascade of bleak images careening through her mind’s eye. She looks at Adam seriously, the boy seeming to stop for a moment at the change in tone from the magicat.

“If you sense something going wrong, you run.” She knits her brow. “You’re a lot more important than the stupid gate. We can regain ground, but not you.” She places a hand on his shoulder, smilingly sadly at the slightly taller blonde. “If I find out you died out here, I'll kill you myself.”

Adam chuckles. “I’ll keep that in mind. Hopefully it won’t come to that.” He smiles softly at her, and for a moment Catra thinks she can see the person hiding in the shell, the one who so desperately needs to break free. A fleeting second passes and that person is gone, replaced by the furrowed glare Catra has come to know means business from the former cadet. He transforms into She-Ra, nodding at her before heading out for the platform.

Now, it’s on her to find Sea Hawk. She starts by heading down to the beach where they docked the boat, walking through the twisting and turning hallways and paths out of the city before reaching the staircase they climbed initially. Thunder claps in the distance, signaling a coming storm. They'll need to work quickly. She spies him down there, desperately trying to un-beach the *Dragon’s Daughter V* to no avail. He’s trying to run away, like Mermista said he had before. The very sight sends Catra's blood into a boil and she finds herself rushing down the stairs.

“What the hell are you doing? Were you planning to just *leave* us here? Like you left the first time?!” She glares at Sea Hawk, stomping towards him aggressively as he tries to push the boat

into the ocean. He seems surprised that she came, as if he'd expected no one to notice when he disappeared.

“Catra! I- no, this isn’t what it looks like, I-” He starts, stumbling over her words in panic.

“Can it. Why bother bringing us out here if you were just going to abandon Salineas again?!” She points a finger at him, practically growling in rage at the man’s lies. “Some hawk you are, more like a fucking chicken!” Her insult seems to strike Sea Hawk deeply. He sits in the sand, leaning his body against the side of his boat and laughs bitterly.

“I wasn’t always like this, you know. I actually cared about the thrill of the adventure once. I had dreams- no, aspirations! But then Mermista- she took over for her father. It was like overnight she got cold. I keep thinking if I come to her with a new plan, a kind of new exciting way out, I might finally see her smile again. Yet here I am, abandoning her again, too afraid to fight the monsters causing her so much pain. All I have proven is that I’m a fool.”

Catra sighs, letting go of the rage she held moments ago. She seats herself beside Sea Hawk, looking out at the ocean with him. The sharp, jagged rocks they had weaved between jut into the sky like daggers into heaven. “I get it. That person that you want to prove yourself to just doesn’t seem to see how hard you’re trying. It’s like- like acting in a play where everyone else knows the script but you. Where the steps are all there to make yourself known and you can’t seem to put them together.” She chuckles. “But running away isn’t the answer. Never has been. That’s just avoiding the problem. You want others to stand up for you but you can't stand up for them, like you don't owe them support in return. You want to help Mermista smile again, Sea Hawk? Help me get out there to one of the gunships. Prove to her you can stand up for Salineas.”

Sea Hawk nods, climbing to his feet and beginning to push the boat again. “You know, I misjudged you. I took you for a bitter

princess on the warpath, but it's more than that isn't it? It's about protecting the people you love as much as it is avenging those who've died. Perhaps I could learn a thing or two from you.” He struggles for a moment before looking down at a bemused Catra. “Can I get a little help?”

Catra stands, helping him get the boat into the water and hopping in. She struggles to push the seasickness down, the waves seeming to crash all around her at every angle as if they were coming for her personally. She needs to finish this fast.

Sea Hawk zooms them along between the rocks, giddily speeding towards one of the two gunships flanking the large flagship in the center. They don't seem to get eyes on them by the time that Catra's climbing over the railing on a seemingly empty part of the ship. She looks over the edge to the captain.

“Go back for help while I get control of the guns! When I give the signal, do your thing!” She calls down. Sea Hawk flashes a thumbs up, taking off in his boat away from the gunship for now.

“Hey! You don’t look familiar. Who the hell are you?” Catra freezes, turning around to the source of the voice. The pink haired girl from Thaymore stands behind her. Not just any girl though, the one who’s supposed to be her sister. The woman who was kidnapped at birth from Catra's parents and forced to grow up a Horde cadet. She puts on a false grin reflexively and salutes.

“Force Captain Catra, ma’am. Transfer in from the Reach. Spent most of my days up north!” She chuckles. “I must say, it’s mighty hot down here, can’t say I’m used to it.” Catra tries not to oversell it, but she hopes the friendly and outgoing route will be easier to accept.

Glimmer’s eye twitches for a moment as she stares at Catra. She scoffs. “Great, another talker. You and Scorpia will get along *great.* ” She gestures at a large woman with white hair. She sports pincers instead of hands, and a scorpion tail to boot. Honestly, at first glance, the woman is terrifying. “Go see her to get assigned.

I have to do more planning.” Glimmer grumbles, stomping away. She seems peachy, Catra thinks, as she approaches the white haired Force Captain. Might as well keep up appearances while she figures out how to gain access to the weaponry.

“Hey there! I don’t see you on the list. Are you new?” Scorpia grins, holding a clipboard. Catra can’t help but wonder how she’s able to write if her hands are claws, but she pushes the thought away as she nods.

“Field promotion, ma’am, hasn’t been made official yet.” Catra nods assuredly, hoping to belay Scorpia’s suspicions. The woman squints her eyes for a moment, as if she’s onto the magicat, before shrugging and returning to her jovial state.

“Too much paperwork, am I right?” Scorpia chuckles, and Catra forces herself to join her. Great, she *is* a talker. Glimmer wasn’t kidding. The woman eyes her for a moment, seemingly intrigued by Catra's appearance. “I’ve never seen one of your kind before! So fluffy!”

Uh oh.

“Wait, wait!” Catra protests as Scorpia picks her up in a bear hug. She feels like all her bones and organs are being squeezed in a vice, the scorpion woman’s arms strong enough to crush every one of them if she wanted. All the air in her lungs escapes her like a rapidly deflating balloon for what feels like ten minutes before she's set down again, a wide smile covering Scorpia’s face.

“Sorry, I’m a hugger.” She chuckles and picks her clipboard back up. Catra struggles to catch her breath for a moment as the scorpion woman looks at the work assignments. “Are you good with weaponry? You can do maintenance on the guns.” She points to a doorway, seemingly leading to the hold of the ship. Catra salutes, happily heading down. The only two below deck are a thin, blonde human and a large lizard-like man who seems to be his close friend.

“Hey there!” The blonde freezes, eyeing Catra with an almost primal fear. He seems to loosen up some when the lizard guy says something Catra doesn't quite understand. “I just got assigned maintenance. Can you show me around down here?”

“They assigned a Force Captain to *custodial* work?” The blonde mutters in disbelief, earning a jab from the lizard’s elbow. He looks up at his friend in surprise, the lizard cadet shaking his head disapprovingly. The kid looks away forlornly, muttering a quick ‘sorry’ under his breath before pointing at a doorway in the corner by the stairs. “Cleaning tools are stored in the corner there. Basically, you open the chamber, make sure there's no jammed ammunition in it, and brush it clean of debris. Pretty simple.” He extends a hand out. “I'm Kyle, that's Rogelio. Feel free to tell us if you need help with anything.”

Catra shakes Kyle’s hand in response. “Catra.” She nods before turning to the cleaning supplies. The ship suddenly sways, nearly knocking her off her feet and sending a wave of nausea through her body. Right, she's on a boat. A boat in the ocean. She no longer felt the high from before, her stomach lurching as she struggles to regain her sea legs. A chuckle rings out behind her, making her blood run cold for a moment.

“First time at sea?” Scorpia’s voice comes. She turns, giving a look to the woman that screams *help* , earning another laugh. “I remember my first time too. Guess they had you on outpost duty up in the Reach, huh? Must've been boring.”

Catra swallows. “Y-yeah, lots of reporting to the Fright Zone about a whole lot of nothing going on.” The statement makes Scorpia grin sympathetically. Catra almost likes the woman suddenly, finding it very difficult to justify what she’s about to do, the sabotage she’s about to perform.

“Well, I just came down here to talk to Kyle. You'll be alright, wildcat. One step at a time.” With that, she turns and walks to the pair of cadets on the opposite side of the boat. *Wildcat?* Catra thinks, wondering how she earned a nickname from the woman

so fast. Scorpia seems like a very trusting person, which contrasts her scary looks pretty harshly. The magicat can’t help but wonder how she became a Force Captain. She turns, forcing the wave of nausea down and taking the supplies for the guns. She needs to do it and do it fast. Her footsteps pick up as she reaches the first gun, opening the chamber and looking inside. Clean as a whistle, meaning it's unused, but it's also not pointed the way she's hoping. The angle is all wrong, she would miss the flagship.

She feigns cleaning it out anyway, waiting for a moment where Scorpia is looking away to adjust the heavy artillery weapon so it will graze at least part of the flagship. She then loads it before moving onto the next one. The second cannon is filthy, as if it's been heavily used. A few moments pass and it's clean like the first, but also pointed wrong. She won't be able to fire it at the flagship at all. Then, as if hearing her thoughts, a small boat picks up fast past the outside of the ship. The *Dragon's Daughter V* . Sea Hawk thought ahead, using his boat as a distraction to get them to reorient. He's smarter than Catra gave him credit for. The sky above claps with thunder, a bolt of lightning nearly slamming into Sea Hawk's ship as he careens around the gunboat.

“All hands, get ready to fire on that sloop! No one gets in or out of Salineas!” Glimmer's voice comes pounding out of the loudspeaker. She's angry, speaking as though she has a personal vendetta against the sea people. Catra moves quickly, orienting the third gun up and over Sea Hawk's boat and waiting for Glimmer's signal as the gunship turns towards the flagship.

“FIRE!” She screams, the rounds firing out of the cannons with a deafening boom. One slams into the stern of the flagship, sending bits of shrapnel spewing into the water. The second finds a spot below the deck, exploding and punching a hole the size of a small boulder in it. The third misses entirely, zooming past the flagship and into the water.

Catra watches as the flagship fires back, narrowly missing the gunship. She races to the deck, eager to get off the boat before someone suspects her deception. She freezes when she hears

Glimmer’s angry voice on the deck, barking into a walkie-talkie. “Why would I *intentionally* fire two rounds into the flagship?! Do you think I'm crazy? I'm trying to stop that stupid sea captain from slipping through again!”

“Don't move a fucking muscle. I'm coming over there.” The voice on the other end growls. Catra sees Sea Hawk's ship turning towards the flagship and a surge of panic shoots through her. What the hell is he doing? Is he insane?! Then, in some sort of symbolic fashion, the *Dragon’s Daughter V* bursts into flames, speeding towards the flagship faster than anyone would be able to stop. Catra watches Sea Hawk dive into the ocean as his boat pummels into the side of the large Horde vessel. Water pours into the flagship, invited by Sea Hawk’s sacrifice of the little sloop.

“You see what you just let happen?!” A gravelly yell comes from the edge of the ship. Octavia must swim fast, having closed the gap in minutes. When she climbs aboard she's instantly recognizable for her octopus-like appearance. She's muscular, sporting a Horde uniform not unlike Catra's own with it's sleeveless design. Her hair isn't really hair at all, instead being made up of tentacles that seem to move on their own. She glares at Glimmer before finally eyeing Catra.

Catra's heart stops when she sees her. She knows instantly that Octavia has seen right through her, the woman's suspicious expression only all that much more telling. “Who the hell are you? This ship isn't assigned any more Force Captains.” She squints at Catra, before snatching the clipboard from Scorpia as she steps back onto the deck.

“She said she was a field promotion.” Scorpia says innocently, raising her hands in mock surrender as Octavia glares at her. The aquatic woman’s blood seems to boil as she angrily tosses the clipboard to the ground and points an accusatory finger at Scorpia. Her response is much more calm than Catra expects.

“We don't *do* field promotions.” Glimmer seems to wither for a moment under Octavia’s angry glare, before she steels herself and

teleports to Catra’s right. Octavia throws a punch at the magicat, who narrowly dodges it. She unsheathes her claws and swipes at the woman's arm as she leaps backwards. Glimmer swings her staff at Catra’s face, the edge of it grazing her face as she ducks out of its way. A swift kick backwards sends Glimmer tumbling to the ground, sliding on the wet surface towards the railing as a clap of thunder rings out like a starting gun, heavy rain beginning to pour down over the four of them.

Four of them.

Catra forgets about Scorpia, who swings her tail once, then twice at her. Her reflexes are fast, but nearly not enough to dodge the second jab of the woman's stinger. She’d hate to find out if Scorpia holds any poison in that thing, being mindful of it as she dodges another fist from Octavia on her left. She sees now why Scorpia is a Force Captain, the loyal and angry gaze the white haired woman is giving her telling Catra all she needs to know. She's overwhelmed, almost too much so, when finally her backup arrives. Sea Hawk and Mermista climb aboard the gunship, quickly entering into one on one fights with Octavia and Scorpia, while Catra takes on Glimmer.

“Just who the hell are you?” Glimmer teleports again, but Catra catches the shimmer of where her destination is fast enough to make a swipe at her. The pink haired girl grabs her by the wrist and *bends.* Catra crumples to her knees, watching as black electricity arcs from the girl’s fingertips. Her right hand finds Catra’s side, electrical energy shooting through the magicat and seeming to cause every muscle in her body to spasm in pain as she’s forced to the ground. She has to think fast before she’s completely incapacitated.

Like that, she finds her opening. Glimmer forces her to a knee, and Catra takes the opportunity to fight the pain and send a swift kick to the pink-haired girl’s shin. The Force Captain cries out in pain, her staff tumbling from her hand in a moment just long enough for Catra to kick it across the deck. The magicat stands

over her sister, claws extended, and growls. “Catra, Princess of Bright Moon. Surprised you didn't recognize family.”

Glimmer's eyes widen before she takes on a hardened gaze. “Bullshit. My family is dead. The only person I had is gone.” She teleports to her staff, picking it up and hitting Catra in the side with it. “Bright Moon? Are you kidding me? Do I look like royalty?”

Catra cackles. “Do I?” She swipes at Glimmer's good arm, her claws slashing along the girl's right bicep and exposing the flesh beneath her uniform.

“Catra!” She hears Mermista call. The magicat turns, seeing her duel with Octavia beginning to overwhelm her. Catra bounds toward them, preparing a strike at the woman's face. She swipes, her claw digging deep into Octavia’s face and scratching into her left eyeball. The woman *shrieks* in pain, crumpling to her knees and clutching her face. She glares at Catra with one hand covering her wounded eye.

“You *bitch* ! You've blinded me!” Octavia growls through the yells of pain. A *boom* sounds out over the bay as the flagship’s engine explodes in flame, quickening the boat’s sinking. Glimmer and Scorpia stop to watch it for a moment, panicked looks exchanged between them. The rain only seems to pick up even heavier as Sea Hawk and Mermista join Catra’s side, looking over the three women.

“I think we've done enough, guys.” Catra chuckles, grinning down at the injured fish woman. “Now, how's about you go running back to Shadow Weaver, and make sure she knows that the ‘kitten’ whose father she killed is running the show now.” She eyes Sea Hawk. “How are we getting out of here without the boat?” The question makes Sea Hawk grin as he points to the side he and Mermista climbed aboard from.

“Easy. Your friend Bow is a quick learner.” Catra raises an eyebrow, looking in the direction of his gesture to see a brand

new sloop piloted by the archer. The *Dragon's Daughter VI.* The sight makes her cackle. She begins to follow them over onto the new ship before hearing an angry yell from behind her. Catra turns to see Glimmer teleport away. The trio climb aboard the shiny new boat, Sea Hawk grinning in pride at Bow's helmsmanship. The four of them watch as the remaining boats begin to retreat, not realizing another danger has just stepped onto the platform with She-Ra.

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"You fuck everything up. You know that?!" Glimmer growls, throwing the first punch at She-Ra. The warrior narrowly dodges it while keeping the sword pointed at the gate. "You just had to go find that stupid sword in the woods, didn't you? I told you to leave it be, that it would only paint a target on you, and look at what you did! How's your fancy new life and fancy new friends, huh?!" Her next swing collides with She-Ra's stomach, this time too much for her to remain in place. She stumbles backwards, the sword tumbling from her hand as she transforms back into Adam.

"People were in danger!" Adam says, clutching his stomach at the pain point. He dodges a second and third punch from Glimmer before a fourth finds his face as she climbs on top of him and swings relentlessly. He angrily pushes upwards just hard enough to push her off of him and finds an opening to knock her off her feet, sweeping her legs with his ankle. Adam rolls to his feet and he grabs his sword. Looming over her with the tip of the blade pressed into her throat, he looks down at her scornfully. "I suggest you leave, Glimmer, before the others get back."

Glimmer snorts. "What, your new little girlfriend? You know what she tried to tell me out there, Adam? That we're *family.* That she and I were meant to be siblings." Glimmer's eyes widen for a moment when he nods affirmatively before furrowing back into a glare. "Shoulda known you were a fucking liar too." Glimmer growls, before grabbing Adam's hand and bending his arm behind him in a grapple, sword still in his right hand. "Just like everyone, always the lying type, huh? You know what, Adam? I never

wanted to be her little magical heir. Her perfect little princess of darkness. But-”

She's cut off as Adam twists out of her grip, elbowing her in the stomach. “But what, Glim? You can still leave. We can fight her together.” Adam says, pleadingly.

Glimmer stares at him for a moment before bursting into a cackle. The girl looks at him darkly, her eyes seeming to convey a hatred he’s never seen before in her. “You're doomed.” She says, teleporting away. Catra and the others climb to the platform just in time to see Adam tumble to a knee in pain.

“Adam!” Catra rushes to his side, helping him stand. “You alright, blondie?”

“I'll be fine. Let's fix this gate so we can go home.” Adam says somberly, transforming into She-Ra. It takes several hours of concentration, but eventually Adam repairs the gate completely. The Horde boats are long gone by this time, having been replaced by trading ships and envoys from Bright Moon. The blockade is over, but the war is only just beginning. Adam can't help but think of Glimmer when they finally get back home. In another life, he imagines she might have liked it here. All he can think about is the darkness with which her final words to him clawed their way from her mouth. He was beginning to lose hope for her. But that was war. The real war, the turning of friends and enemies on themselves just as much as each other. Adam chose his side, and she's chosen hers.

Now it's up to them to make their next move.

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M/A/R/A ONLINE

ERROR: SWORD OF PROTECTION NO LONGER MISSING A WIELDER.

TERMINATE IDLE MODE?

Chapter End Notes

I want to apologize for all the vomiting and nausea stuff between this chapter and the last. It's in my nature to be kind of graphic with these things and depicting how gross being blackout drunk and hungover can be is part of what adds that sort of viscerality to my writing. It's going to be better moving forward. This is the first chapter I've not had a template for so I've been getting my bearings with writing in my new style this way.

Anyhow, thanks so much for reading! The next few chapters should be faster because they'll follow the events of the originals, but expect some time as I get them written! I'm also currently outlining the chapters for the next act, so hopefully they should come faster too!

Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter IV: Put Me On A Pedestal And I'll Only Disappoint You

Rain pounds against the side of the castle in Bright Moon. It's poured every day in the week since Adam and Catra ended the blockade at Salineas. Mermista officially joined less than a day later, saying that if only a small group of them could do something so meaningful then who knows what every princess combined could. Things are looking up for the resistance and the alliance as a whole. Even then, thoughts of the platform still haunt him. Glimmer had been ruthless, sending punch after punch at him without any regard for anything other than causing him pain. It was chilling to think his friend could be so wrathful, so ready to kill the past they shared together. Every day seems to push them further apart as Adam's loyalty to Bright Moon grows.

Now, he sits in his room. It's no longer the spare room, it's officially *his* now. He'd never had his own space in the Horde, and now a room the size of three barracks combined belongs to him. It makes him uneasy, if he's being honest, to have such a place to go where no one could follow, as if just spending time on his own was a crime. He still remembers how Shadow Weaver looked at him, tortured him for being different in any way.

"Adam-" Shadow Weaver's cold, uncaring voice comes crashing through the fog. "Just what do you think you're doing?" He stands up straight, grinning nervously. The woman towers over him, seeming to glower down at him through her mask. He fights the urge to shake uncontrollably as she looks him over. Shadow Weaver seems to quickly catch on to what he and Glimmer had been doing: sparring without permission, seeking to improve their

*skills before the Force Captain exam would finally rip them apart. "You think you can help Glimmer **cheat** and get away with it?"*

"No! No! I didn't know it was cheating! I was just-" What comes next is the feeling of electrical energy coursing through his body, a sensation by this point Adam should be familiar with. Every nerve in him seems to fire all at once, causing his muscles to tense and spasm as he collapses to the ground, writhing in pain. "I- I'm sorry, Sh- Shadow Weaver." He manages through gritted teeth.

"Never again, Adam. You and Glimmer are to be split up. No more of your-" Shadow Weaver scoffs. "Interfering." The blonde starts to say something, a single syllable exits his mouth before the woman cuts him off. More black lightning, dark magic that seeks only to cause him unholy pain. "Silence! Not one more word, boy, or you will suffer the consequences!" She booms, a foot kicking him while he's down just for good measure. Another electrical shock, more powerful than the first, finds its way through Adam's body, It only seems to further in intensity as he convulses in agony, beginning to scream at the top of his lungs.

He snaps out of it, his heart beating at a thousand beats per minute as he looks around in terror. Now isn't the time for a flashback, but it doesn't seem like he gets to decide that. He has to find something, *anything* that can help him stop the onslaught of anxiety, because if he starts to scream everyone in the castle will know and he *cannot* let that be the case. His eyes search the room, attempting to find an object to solidify his focus on before he's sent back to that terrible place. Eventually, he gives into instinct and runs.

Before he knows it he's outside the castle, walking into the Whispering Woods alone. They always take him where he needs to go, but today he isn't so sure where that will be or why. He needs to wander aimlessly a bit and clear his head, despite the rain and thunder. Catra and Bow will probably come looking for him after a while, but for now, he walks, his feet trudging along for an hour, then two, then three, letting himself be lost in the twisting depths of the woods. The rain pounds hard against the

treetops, the woods offering him a natural barrier against the elements.

Finally, after an eternity, Adam decides to give up. He sits down against a log and begins to cry, tears lashing down his cheeks violently as sobs into his knees. He doesn't want this. He never wanted this. He feels like he's going insane with the way everything is going, feels like his life is flipped upside down. Glimmer attacked him in cold blood on that platform in Salineas, as if their friendship meant nothing to her. Maybe it didn’t. He's so tired, all he wants to do is lie down and disappear. The only thing stopping him is the rustling in the foliage ahead.

He jumps up, drawing the sword and pointing in the direction of the sounds, hands shaking fiercely as if the sword threatens to leap from his hand. More rustling comes, and Adam steps towards the moving bush. He swears he sees a person moving beyond it, and his suspicions are proven correct a moment later when an old woman pops out at him. She’s hunched over, wearing robes of assorted, cobbled together pieces of cloth and a pair of glasses that seem to make her eyes look enormous. Foliage and branches are caught in her long, messy white hair. He yelps, nearly dropping the sword before leaping backwards. She just smiles at him sympathetically, no hint of malice in her gaze as she continues to pick berries from the shrub.

“Ah! Hope! I thought that was you!” She says. Adam looks around confusedly. There's no one else here, and the name doesn't ring any bells. Has she mistaken him for someone else? The old woman chuckles. “It's been too long dear. Come! Come! Let's make a pie!”

Pie? Adam thinks. He knows better than to follow this complete stranger into the woods. He knows better than to trust her at all with who he is, yet the old woman seems to just *know* something about She-Ra. He can feel it in his bones as she leads him into a little hut in the woods, obscured and secluded away from all forms of civilization. She insists he sit, and he's brimming with so many questions he can't seem to find one to start with.

“I'm sorry, who is Hope?” It’s spacious for being built out of the side of a little hill like it is. Adam takes a seat at her table, looking at her with equal parts intrigue and suspicion. She turns and grins at him as if he’s told the greatest joke she’s ever heard.

“You are dearie! Have you forgotten your own name?” She cackles. “Or is old Razz growing senile?” Adam is inclined to agree with the second option as he watches the woman put the pie into what looks like a small brick oven on the far side of the kitchen. She turns, shuffling over and sitting across from him expectantly. “She was such a wonderful She-Ra. She'd be so proud of you, Adora.” Razz says, smiling. “It's a shame your lovely wife couldn't come.” The statement makes Adam choke on air. Adora? Wife? Who the hell does she think he is?

“Ma’am? I think you have me mixed up with someone else. I'm not Adora or Hope.” He says. The woman doesn't seem to register it, staring into space for a moment before standing once again to attend to the pie. “I’m the She-Ra. The current one. Were they-were they also She-Ra? In the past?” He asks, a nervous feeling growing in his chest as the woman breathes a heavy sigh.

“You’ll learn all that in time, Adam.” She says. Adam’s blood freezes at the statement. He doesn’t like it here anymore, if he ever did. Panic surges through his blood as he stands, picking up into a full sprint out of the hut and away from the crazy old woman and her pie. He just keeps running, trying to escape this burden as quickly as possible. Eventually, his foot catches on a large marble stone in the ground, nearly sending him to the ground. The stone is part of the staircase to a large, crystal-like structure. This must be the one Catra found.

He looks around for an entrance, seeing only a large, sealed door. He's not sure what the pang in the back of his mind is, but he feels like he *knows* the passcode. Without a second thought he speaks a single word: ‘Eternia.’ The door *whooshes* open, and when he steps inside he's met with advanced darkness. A single tiny pinprick of a light blinks across the room, seemingly beckoning to him through the pitch black. He steps forward, a

panel giving way beneath him, seemingly a foot switch of some kind. In seconds, blinding white light floods the building, causing Adam to bring an arm to his face as his eyes adjust.

The room is covered in white hexagonal floor panels that almost hurt his eyes to look at. The entire room in fact is adorned in white and gold colors, not unlike those of She-Ra's outfit. In front of him is a console not unlike those of Horde command centers, except this one is covered in the same strange glyphs Bow had said were the language of the First Ones. Adam steps over to it, looking around the vast and empty room as he does. His eyes scan the walls, where images of ancient battles cover the building extensively. He spots one in particular above where the console stands, of a tall blonde warrior and a cat-like woman facing off against a purple-haired woman and an army of robots behind her. The woman in purple wears a pair of welding goggles atop her head, long hair pulled back into pig-tails that extend to the ground. She's dressed in torn overalls, a Horde Force Captain badge adorning the front of them. On either side of her in the mural are a scorpion woman and a Force Captain with pink hair.

Adam's blood runs below freezing. Though he cannot place the mechanic, he definitely recognizes the other Force Captains as Scorpia and Glimmer. Why did the First Ones have a mural *like this*? He looks down at the console, a sickness creeping over him as he places his hands on it. The console lights up with a *whir*, sending him stumbling backwards.

"What is your query?" A voice behind him comes, calm and robotic. He turns to see a hologram of a woman staring at him, hands folded as if awaiting his answer. She glows a fiery orange, her outfit seeming to suggest she is some kind of soldier. Her stare is blank and emotionless, seeming to pierce right into Adam's soul as she awaits his answer.

"What is this place? Who are you?" Adam's voice comes out anxious. Between the mural and Razz things are getting freakier and freakier. The hologram glitches, buffering for a moment before disappearing and reappearing to Adam's right. The thing, if

he’s being honest, gives him the creeps, but he shoves that down for now.

“This is the Crystal Castle, She-Ra’s home base. I am its administrator, M/A/R/A.” The woman’s voice doesn’t come out of her holographic lips half the time she’s speaking, as if the program’s visual element is glitched. “Welcome, newest She-Ra. The First Ones welcome you.”

“Newest?” Adam says, stepping towards M/A/R/A tentatively. “Does that mean there are more?” He’d suspected as much, having heard Adora’s name in his dreams. It was as if the sword was reaching out and waiting for him to reach back. The hologram freezes for a moment, seeming to process his question before formulating its response.

“The power of the She-Ra has been passed from individual to individual for generations.” A screen flashes to life above the console as M/A/R/A appears beside it, as if she is teaching a class regarding the subject. Adam turns, eyeing both the hologram and the screen with suspicious intrigue. Mara continues. “In every incarnation she is our protector, our defender of hope and peace across Etheria.” An image of a She-Ra with a longsword and shield stands between a group of civilians and alien soldiers. “Our harbinger of love and prosperity across the stars.” Another image, of another She-Ra with their partner and child. “The First Ones have relied on her for eons as a symbol of our strength in the face of adversity.” Finally, the screen flickers a sickening green, a final image of a third She-Ra glowing gold amongst thousands of white and viridian clad soldiers, her sword raised to the sky.

As the screen fades, Adam retrieves the sword from its place on his back. He stares at it, the reflection of an angry, barely-past-his-teens boy staring back at him. “Why me?” He mutters, looking up at the hologram with a newfound frustration. It stares back unemotionally at him, sending a pang of anger through Adam’s body. “WHY ME?!” He yells again, throwing the sword through M/A/R/A’s incorporeal form. She flickers as it passes through her,

unfazed as Adam walks towards her with just rage. “Where are the First Ones now? Why was I chosen when they're all dead?!”

“She-Ra Hope, your predecessor, went rogue and plunged our world into a pocket dimension. Until now, there was no worthy successor.” M/A/R/A says, as if it's a known fact. Adam falters for a moment, staring at the hologram woman in confusion. Worthy successor? He was anything but. And Hope is his predecessor? The same Hope Razz mentioned?

“What did you say her name was?” He asks, forcing his hands to stop shaking as he waits patiently for the answer. If Adam didn't know better, he'd say M/A/R/A looked sad. The moment is fleeting, though, as she returns to her previous neutral state. “Hope?” Adam swallows, sweat dripping down his face. “Then-then who is Adora?”

M/A/R/A flickers, seemingly processing the query. “She-Ra Adora is said to be the She-Ra of the First One’s final prophecy. She will bring an end to our war against the Galactic Horde and with it newfound freedom amongst all in the stars.”

The statement sends a new spark of anxious thought through Adam. What does that mean for their fight? Is all of this pointless, then? He curses in Hordespeak, kicking at nothing. Of course it was all foretold, which means until Adora arrives another eon from now he and Catra will be fighting a pointless war. “Why even bother making me the She-Ra then? What good can I do?”

“You will help bring peace to the planet.” M/A/R/A says simply, as if it was the most obvious answer ever. A latent frustration grows in Adam’s chest. These aren't answers, they're just more questions. He walks over and picks up the sword, pointing it at the woman.

“You see this? It isn't even my fighting type. I fight with two weapons, agile and dodgy. Have since I started learning when I was in the Horde. Your system for selecting a She-Ra is flawed, if it's picked me. We can't wait around and let more die because

Adora hasn't gotten here yet and might never because of that other She-Ra.” He eyes the woman, whose expression seems to shift for the briefest of moments before she speaks. “I mean, really, how do you expect her to get here if we’re all in a pocket dimension like you say? It’s all ridiculous. I'm just some Horde kid who got sucked into all this. The sword picked wrong, I'm what's left. I need to know how to use it properly.”

M/A/R/A nods affirmatively. She flickers back to the console, a thin slot in the center lighting up. It's wide enough to slide the sword into, and after a moment's hesitation Adam obliges it, causing the console to hum with magical energy. The entire building seems to rumble as the sword registers its new owner. On the screen above, a single two words flash across the display.

Welcome, She-Ra.

The rest of the room lights up, a hexagonal floorpiece rising out of the center behind him. It seems to open, revealing another glyph that Adam understands to mean ‘forge.’ He looks at M/A/R/A, whose form has stopped glitching and become much more solid. Instead of flickering to the apparatus, she walks, gesturing at it. “It is a rite of passage for every She-Ra to come here and adapt the sword anew to their strengths. Your predecessor, Hope, did this just as you are about to, to create the incarnation of the Sword Of Power you hold in your hand. Her uniform breathed with her life, woven by the magic of Etheria to suit her as protector of our world. Now, Adam, it is your turn. Please place the sword inside the forge, and we shall begin your training.”

He thinks back to finding the sword, the first moments he turned into She-Ra flashing behind his eyes. The joy he felt, the immediate wonder at being a princess before it was replaced with Horde-instilled disgust. How every moment he turns into She-Ra hurts him because he knows it's a fantasy and he'll go back to being Adam when he's done. Perfuma crosses his mind, quite literally a self-made woman, and the jealousy he feels is almost too much to bear. He realizes in this moment now that he’s *disappointed* that he’s not Adora. He knows who she is, has seen

her in his dreams, and somehow he can’t help but wish that was his life instead of this one.

A different memory surfaces. The first real torture he'd endured at Shadow Weaver’s hand had occurred when he and Glimmer had been fooling around while on custodian duty. They'd found a closet of old uniforms and other junk that the Horde had probably forgotten about. Inside was a beautiful red jacket Adam had immediately taken a liking to, amongst the other assorted pieces of clothing. He had slipped it on, showing it off to the squad before being caught by Shadow Weaver. She'd called him a pervert for putting on the old jacket, saying it was a female Force Captain who'd died serving the Horde’s. He’d never pursued a train of thought like that again.

His spiral is interrupted by the sound of the forge finishing its work. As it emerges from the ground it opens to reveal two smaller swords of protection, one longsword and one shortsword. Adam pulls them from the machine and swings them around, feeling how balanced they are for him. An instinct comes to him, and without much concentration he changes them into bracers on each hand.

“Shit! I don't have to carry them around anymore!” He says excitedly, changing them back and forth from their wearable form. The hologram giggles at him, causing him to stop and stare at her. “What?”

“You remind me of her. She was…she was colder, more abrasive. But her spirit was in the right place. She-” The hologram flickers, fading for a moment before coming back dimly. M/A/R/A’s form seems to have stopped, stuttering for a moment before resetting. “The swords have more functionality than just two blades.” She says, much more robotically than a moment ago. “Combining them turns them into a large zweihander, capable of large sweeping attacks, as well as the possibility to transform one or both into a shield when needed.”

Adam looks at M/A/R/A, slightly suspicious at the woman's change in demeanor. He looks at the bracers around his hands, noticing the way they hug them and seem to just belong there. A vision flashes across Adam's eyes, automatically sending him into high alert. He sees Catra, held up in chains and being interrogated in the Fright Zone prison. When he snaps out of it he falls to one knee, breathing heavily. "What-" He heaves. "What the fuck was that?"

"The sword is known to contain powers individual to each She-Ra." M/A/R/A says plainly. "Some gained powers of strength or endurance, and others were more powerful on the mental and spiritual planes." Spiritual planes? What the hell does that mean?

Adam looks angrily up at her. "So what's my power then? Seeing visions of my loved ones in pain? Doesn't seem like much of a power, more like a fucking *curse*." He transforms the right sword into its blade form, pointing the longsword at the artificial hologram.

"I am holographic, your threats do not intimidate me." M/A/R/A flickers. "These visions indicate possible clairvoyance. That is an incredibly rare ability only the most powerful of She-Ras could have. No doubt, Adam, you are to be one of our best." But not *the* best. Another cog in the machine working towards an end prophecy. What was that mural about? What does it all mean? So many questions without answers and Adam finds himself *angry.*

He eyes M/A/R/A irritably. The woman seemed so warm and human moments ago. Adam decides he's had enough of the bullshit for one day. "Forget it. I'm out of here." He mutters, stomping towards the door and stepping out of the large mechanical passage into the rainy forest once again. He has no idea how he arrived here, but the woods haven't steered him wrong yet. He starts away from the Crystal Castle.

"Adora!" The voice of Madame Razz calls to him. He's tempted to ignore her, but curiosity seeps through his frustration. He's only walked a few hundred feet, but as he turns around he notices that

the castle is gone. The woods have hidden it from him again. Razz grins at him, handing him what he assumes is a pie (He's never seen one before, he doesn't think). “Let's get you out of the rain, deary!” And like that, he's back in Razz’s hut, questioning the choices that led him here. She's cleaning her little kitchen area and rambling about something Adam doesn't quite catch. He nearly zones out until a name comes from her lips that he recognizes.

“When is Catra coming by again?” She asks innocently. He sits up, nearly gawking at her before he manages to calm himself. A million questions are running through his head, though none of them ask the one at large. He stares at Razz incredulously, that familiar fear running in his veins like ice.

“How do you know Catra?” Adam asks, his voice shaky. He's creeped out by all this business of people knowing who he and his friends are. They should know nothing about him or those he loves and yet they seem to know everything. More than he does. It makes him angry. He wants to be somebody important so badly and yet no matter how much he fights he’s always just told how he’ll be nothing in the grand scheme of things.

Razz cackles. “Are you as mad as old Razz now? Do you not remember your wife?” Adam’s heart stops beating. He doesn’t understand what that means. A feeling in his guts he’s refused to give a name takes over him, his breathing quickening as the throes of panic set in. He’s so tired of everything. This has been the shittiest, most worthless outing he could have made. What will Catra herself even say when he tells her all this? What is he supposed to say? An old woman in the woods thinks she and some mystery She-Ra will be married after Adam apparently *dies*?

“What?” The question is all he can muster, bouncing his leg with such ferocity it might come off at the hip. Razz doesn't say anything, sitting beside him and gently holding his hand while stroking it with her thumb. Adam chuckles, the tears of the breakdown beginning to fester in his eyes. He feels sorrow for who he is, for the way he’s treated this old woman. She’s trying

her best to be helpful and he can’t even be grateful for that. “I'm sorry for running.”

“Razz never holds grudges, dear.” She says fondly. “Even if she's a crazy old hag after all these years. The visions make it difficult to remember!” Razz cackles. “It grows late, Hope! You should get home!”

Adam nods, standing. He's about to turn and leave when he feels Madame Razz pull on his arm. She spreads her arms, gesturing to him for a hug that he begrudgingly obliges.

“Never forget, Adora, that nothing in your life is fated. You make your own destiny.” She whispers before pulling away with a cackle. He can’t help but feel like that Razz is speaking to him when she says this, wondering exactly who Adora must be in whatever future the old woman sees. When he steps back into the woods, it's growing dark and raining down upon the treetops still. He must've been out all day. He starts walking in the direction he came from originally, hoping to coax the woods into taking him home. Another hour and a half passes before he hears familiar voices from a clearing ahead.

“Adam!” Catra's raspy yell comes. The sound forces what Razz said earlier back into Adam’s head, feelings he doesn't want taking their place. He shoves them down like usual, running into the clearing and waving his arms. The two seem to spot him quickly, Bow picking up running first with Catra in hot pursuit. Adam feels sorry for worrying them, but he hopes the night will prove productive in the long run. Though he might need to leave some details out.

“Where’ve you been?” Bow asks. “You didn't leave a note or anything!”

“I uh-” Adam chuckles nervously. “I took a walk into the woods. Found that building Catra mentioned. It's a First One’s base specifically for She-Ra.” He shakes his head. “I learned a lot about her.” A lot is an understatement. He’s not even sure where he can

begin to explain the days events to them. He steps backwards, transforming the bracers into his new swords. “It adapted the sword for my fighting style.” Bow's eyes light up with wonder at the sight of the magic.

Catra scoffs affectionately. “You would, blondie.” She pulls him into a surprising hug, something she's never done for Adam before. She’s adamant about not being a hugger. Catra breaks it after a moment. “Don't ever just wander in here without letting us know again. You could have died!” The worry festers a new feeling in Adam’s chest, a relieved one. They had been worried about him.

Adam laughs. “You sound like your mom!” The statement makes Catra's face go bright red, her fur standing on end. He and Bow chuckle at the magicat’s outburst.

“I do not!” She growls, shoving him. Adam laughs as he falls backwards, grinning at his friend. She huffs angrily down at him before seeming to soften with an embarrassed smile. She grabs his hand and helps him back to his feet. “So-” She starts. “My mom’s sending us to Dryl.”

“Dryl?” The name doesn't ring a bell. “Where's that?”

“The mountains. It's basically uninhabited except for the princess there. She's a genius but also a bit of a recluse.” A light up ahead denotes the edge of the woods. “Bow's basically obsessed with her though.” Catra laughs.

“No!” Bow says indignantly, before deflating and seeming to change his mind. “No, yeah, maybe a little. She's one of the greatest engineers who's ever lived. I want to learn everything I can from her, so I can be a better tech master.” He grins, nodding in affirmation. Adam realizes he admires Bow for being able to wear his heart on his sleeve. It must not be easy to be so vulnerable all the time with people. He’s not sure he could ever achieve that.

“All the better to recruit more people into the Alliance.” Adam says. “The more people we have against the Horde, the better. We need different thinking, different ways of seeing things. Sounds like this princess might be our ticket to that.” His mind wanders back to the mural above that console. If that kind of war was on the horizon, they’d need somebody on their side with technical prowess matching that.. He didn’t recognize the woman between Scorpia and Glimmer, but something tells him she's dangerous.

Little does he know, he's about to see first hand why.

Chapter End Notes

> Shorter chapter this time! Wanted to change the first meeting of Razz and M/A/R/A to be between Salineas and Dryl so I can rewrite the original chapter more organically. Hope you all enjoy! Next chapter is gonna be a doozy! Stay tuned!

Chapter 6

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter V: I Walk From My Machine

“Log 107.” Entrapta begins, speaking into her tape recorder. “The chip I recovered from the crash site in the southern wasteland has yielded a plethora of data about First One's design, but I have yet to figure out how to power it. I've made several modifications to the lab in order to power it directly from Dryl’s geothermal plant in the sublevels below me.” She chuckles. “I am going to turn it on, but not before getting a good meal. Science works best on a diet of tiny food and no matter how much the world demands I go big or go home I refuse. Refuse!!” She clears her throat embarrassedly. “Anyway, I will update the log after I've activated it.”

She clicks the tape recorder button, sighing in frustration at herself for her little tangent. Her adoration for engineering is stifled by her constant inability to stay focused, a trait she's found others to find as undesirable as she does. She'd love to share in the scientific inquiry with a lab partner, but she's sure they'd just find her annoying and leave anyway. It's better for her if she just works alone, no rejection that way. She looks around the laboratory, lined with screens and workbenches meant for monitoring and designing the many robots and mechanical systems Dryl contains. The place needs a good tidying up, but with the recent events of finding the artifact she's been too engrossed to program a new robot to do it for her. Honestly, she wonders why she still doesn't have a cleaning bot.

A sharp *bang* against the metal door of the lab knocks her thoughts loose. She yelps in surprise, looking back at the metal

door with panic. “Who's there? I didn't send for anyone today!” She says, searching her memories for an engagement she might have forgotten about. Is today the meeting with Bright Moon? Shit! It is! She hastily scrambles to the door, pushing the button to open it. “I'm sorry, Catra, I forgot all about our-”

She stops. The people in front of her are decidedly not Catra and Bow. A tall, scorpion-like woman with white hair stands menacingly besides a short, angry looking girl. They're wearing uniforms with colors of maroon and brown, signifying allegiance to the Horde. Entrapta yelps, backing up and raising her hands in surrender. The short haired girl chuckles. “Are we that scary, Scorpia?” Entrapta sees the white haired woman grin down at her companion in response.

“I mean, we did come here to capture her, stormbird.” The statement seems to get a rise out of the short girl, who glares.

“Don't tell her what we're about to do!” She says scornfully. Scorpia sheepishly nods before beginning to approach Entrapta slowly. Shit, she needs to get out of here and buy time for the princesses. The only thing she can think of in this moment is the fucking First One’s chip. Come on brain, stop focusing on that!

Entrapta backs up fearfully, tripping over a loose wire in the process. Damn her for not making that cleaning robot! As she falls, she reaches a hand out in panic, finding a lever and grabbing it to prevent herself from hitting the ground. The lever gives way, a noise like a generator kicking on as it reaches the ‘on’ position. The chip begins to glow a sickening green. Entrapta watches every robot in the room kick online at once, eyes glowing the same color as they suddenly lunge for the two Horde Captains. She can't help but turn on her tape recorder. “Edit to log. The chip has activated, and seems to be having an effect on my robots. All of them have attacked a pair of intruders in my laboratory and-” Her voice causes a few of them to look at her. “Shit, now they've seen me too. I am now going to run.”

And run she does, using her hair to climb into the ventilation shaft above the laboratory. She hears the scuffle below of the two intruders fighting off her deranged bots, a silent wave of relief overcoming her at the timing. They were here to capture her? She's not worth their time unless- They want the First Ones tech! That has to be it. They're at war after all, what better way to win it than with new, unheard of technology? It's so simple Entrapta nearly laughs, nearly flattered the Horde seems to need her contributions that badly. She climbs along the shafts, taking every turn she can remember to get topside.

She thinks she's close when she hears voices below. A man and a woman. She recognizes Catra's voice, having met her at the year's previous Princess Prom, but she doesn't recognize the other. It's not deep enough to be Bow, and carries a hint of melancholy that Entrapta finds herself unable to avoid sympathizing with. She takes the opportunity to drop out of the vent in front of them, causing the two to ready themselves in surprise. Catra looks the same as she did a year ago, but her companion is unfamiliar, a blonde wearing a white shirt and beige combat pants. She notices immediately the relief on Catra's face when she recognizes her, the feeling a surprisingly positive one in the sea of negative emotions she's been feeling. On the other hand, the blonde is glaring at her fearfully.

"Entrapta!" Catra says. "We were just coming to find you. Your robots attacked us outside and we got separated from Bow. Are you ok?" She asks, her brow furrowing in concern.

"I was working on a piece of First One's tech when things got a teensy bit deadly. It activated and the robots went haywire. Can't complain really, though, got me away from those two Horde people." She cackles, noting the way Catra looks at her with a newfound surprise. Right, they might not have realized the Horde had intercepted her. It's only been about an hour and a half since the pair attacked Entrapta in the lab. Catra is about to say something when a loud screech reaches the trio, signaling that one of the construction bots she'd built for expanding the kingdom's storage is careening towards them.

“Sounds like one of them is coming, stand back.” The blonde says, pushing in front of her and Catra. He transforms the bracelets on his arms into swords in a fascinating display of magic, raising the longer one high into the air and yelling some kind of command. In moments, Entrapta watches as he's transformed from the sheepish looking blonde boy into a seven-foot tall warrior woman that just *oozes* confidence. The engineer can't help but be enthralled with how it works.

“Wow!” She says excitedly, measuring the warrior and taking notes of her appearance. She's dressed in a sleeveless, purple cloak that is complete with hood and mask. Below the waist is a pair of matching combat pants and boots. Adorning the outfit all over are various elements of gold and lavender. Entrapta stops to take another measurement when the warrior suddenly swings her right sword at Entrapta.

She yelps, jumping away in panic. Catra steps forward in front of Entrapta angrily, glaring up at the woman. “What the hell are you doing?!” The woman stares coldly down at the pair, eyeing Entrapta in particular as if the purple-haired princess has committed great evil. A sinking feeling of doubt creeps into Entrapta’s heart, forcing all of the interest in the warrior out and replacing it with a loathing she was never too long without. The warrior doesn’t say a word, instead lunging again at Entrapta, who barely uses her pigtails to jump out of the way. She grabs Catra quickly and yanks her into the same ceiling vent she’d emerged from not fifteen minutes earlier.

“What the fuck just happened?” Catra mutters, leaning against the side of the ventilation shaft and taking a deep breath. “Adam’s never attacked anyone like that. It’s like he was normal and then he just snapped.” The sounds of She-Ra attacking the construction bot ring out as the two go toe-to-toe.

Entrapta goes over the last three minutes in her head. Adam's anger was clearly caused by his transformation into She-Ra, which means the two are likely connected. But why would- “Shiiiiit.”

Entrapta curses, looking around the vents and trying to get an idea of what direction they should head.

“What? What is it?” Catra's prickly tone jabs a familiar needle into Entrapta's being. The spiral in her head begins, the feeling of inferiority forcing a second wave of self-loathing into the engineer’s mind. Phobias of rejection and making mistakes flash in her mind, and she doesn't realize she's breathing so heavily until Catra puts her hand on her shoulder. “Hey, you ok?” The princess says in sharp contrast to her earlier tone. She must have caught on that she was a bit too abrasive. Entrapta silently kicks herself for caring so much.

“Yeah. I'm fine.” Entrapta says, shaking the feelings off. Now isn't the time for her to panic about how other people feel about her. She came to Dryl and closed herself off to avoid that fear and she's just going to have to deal today. If she joins the Alliance, she hopes Catra won't mind her spending most of her time here instead of Bright Moon. Her mind turns back to Adam and the sword, putting the pieces together once again and eyeing Catra curiously. “Is She-Ra’s weaponry First Ones tech?”

Catra blinks. “I have- I have no idea. Why?”

“Because Adam only became enraged after his transformation. If the swords are related to the First Ones, then it's possible the chip that's causing the bots to go crazy is also causing She-Ra to.” Entrapta nods, gesturing at Catra to follow her as she crawls through the vents. “We need to get back to my lab and shut it down.”

“What about the Horde? They were still in your lab when you escaped, right?” Catra says from behind the purple-haired princess. Entrapta hadn’t considered it, but she supposes by now the bots have driven them out.

“Right, but the chip turned on and they were attacked by my bots. If they were still back there, they'd have stolen the artifact by now and removed it from the power source.”

“So they must've been chased off.” Catra surmises. “Good. Might mean we can get an important piece of tech out of this too.”

Entrapta hums affirmatively.

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Scorpia groans as She-Ra hits her squarely in the back with the pommel of one of her swords. She wasn't sure how the warrior had found her and Glimmer, but she knows now that she's not anything to underestimate. After the duo had retreated from the laboratory they'd gotten turned around in the labyrinth of Dryl. Glimmer had said the chip was their top priority, but it seems their plans were going to have a wrench or two thrown into them.

“Scorpia!” Glimmer yells, swinging her staff and hitting She-Ra square in the jaw. The woman growls fiercely, rushing at Glimmer with a ferocity that Scorpia hadn't ever seen Adam portray before. Granted, she hasn't known him very well, but Glimmer had and she looks just as surprised. The warrior princess topples to the ground as Glimmer teleports out of her way, and Scorpia seizes the opportunity to sting her in the back and knock her unconscious.

“What the fuck just happened?” Scorpia heaves, staring down at She-Ra as she transforms back into Adam. “He's never been that-that aggressive, right?”

Glimmer shakes her head. “He’s learned some new tricks while he's been gone.” She crouches down and picks up his swords, eyeing them both. “These are new. Last time I saw She-Ra she had one of them. Looks like she got an upgrade.”

“All the better to keep those then.” Scorpia looks around at the sprawling blackness. It's imposing, reminding her a little too much of Shadow Weaver in a way. She shudders, looking back at her companion. “What now?”

“We gotta get into that room with that artifact.” Glimmer says with a nod. “If this is what it does to She-Ra, who knows what else it

can do. Hordak'll probably squeal like a little girl." She steps over Adam, careful not to disturb him as she passes.

"Should we tie him up?" Scorpia inquires, looking down at the blonde. She's not sure how long he'll be out. It had taken everything she had to knock She-Ra out, and if she could survive that kind of stinging there's no telling how long they have before Adam wakes up.

"Nah. Leave him there. It'll hurt him more to realize his precious swords are gone." Glimmer snickers coldly. Scorpia only had an arms length idea of their relationship, but Glimmer makes it sound as though Adam was a manipulative know-it-all who took the first chance he got to be showered in attention. She doesn't like him very much at all for it.

The duo turn another corner to see a large construction robot with sawblade arms coming towards them. Scorpia nearly yelps in surprise before Glimmer grabs her and teleports them both out and away. Except, she's certain Glimmer doesn't know where away is, because when they reappear they both are falling through a metal shaft.

"Shit!" Glimmer curses, still holding onto Scorpia's arm. Despite their predicament, the action is enough to make Scorpia blush a little in the dark. A second passes and Glimmer attempts to teleport them again. This time they end up on the roof of the building, the wind howling all around the tower they both precariously stand on.

"I guess this is an improvement!" Scorpia shouts over the scream of the air around them. "Wanna try one more time?!"

Glimmer nods, grabbing her arm once more and using the teleportation magic a third time. A second later the two are standing in a large, deserted cafeteria. Tables and chairs are strewn about loosely, as if they haven't been used in so long it stopped mattering whether they were tidy. A growl comes from

the right of the pair, and Scorpia turns to see a very angry archer boy pointing an arrow between the two of them.

“What are you doing here? Where are Adam and Catra?” He growls, pointing the weapon between them.

“Whoa, whoa. Calm down, arrow.” Glimmer says, voice thick with snark. She takes a slow step in the archer’s direction. “I don't know what you're talking about buddy.” She grins condescendingly. The boy glares at her, his aim never wavering. If Scorpia didn't know better she'd say Glimmer was nervous at the sight.

Arrow seems to notice the swords shoddily holstered on Glimmer's belt and steps forward with fiery intensity. “Those aren't yours. They belong to Adam!” Scorpia senses a panic in the boy's voice. He's not angry, he's scared. He doesn't have his guard dogs here to keep him safe right now and he's not sure he can take the both of them, which she's sure he definitely couldn't.

“Hey, hey, this is all just a big misunderstanding, ok?” Scorpia smiles, putting her hands up in surrender. “Those robots out there'll kill us all if we don't work together on this one. You saw it too, the big robot with the sawblade hands? None of us will make it out of her in one piece with that thing barreling around.” The boy stands firmly for a moment, seeming to mull it over before pointing his bow at the ground but keeping it readied.

The archer sighs, his eyes piercing into Scorpia’s. “What then, you're suggesting we call a truce? Shut it off? How do I know you won't stab me in the back?” His voice is low, almost a growl as he switches his gaze between the two Force Captains.

“Puh-lease, Arrow. If we wanted that, we'd have already taken the chance while you're outnumbered.” Glimmer chuckles. “We just wanna get out of here.” He warily eyes the two of them. Scorpia has to give him props: he has serious guts. More than she gave credit to the Alliance for. A beat passes before he relents,

gesturing at the two to follow him through a door at the back side of the kitchen.

“I have no idea why the bots are attacking us. My guess is whatever Entrapta had been working on turned volatile and sent a kill code to them.” He stops to peer around a corner, checking for hostiles before continuing. “They attacked us in the courtyard and separated me from Adam and Catra.” He pauses for a moment, eyeing the swords on Glimmer's hip with cautious curiosity. “Why *do* you have his swords?”

“He attacked us as She-Ra and nearly took my head off with one of them.” Glimmer grumbles. “Never seen him like that before. Must be She-Ra messing with his br-” Without a chance to react, a fist flies into Glimmer's jaw, the regular form of the former Horde cadet barreling into her like a bullet.

“Adam!” The archer grabs him by the shoulders, struggling to pull him off of the girl. Scorpia quickly follows suit, picking him up and holding him tight as he kicks and screams in rage. Arrow-kid looks the blonde up and down with a healthy dose of concern, gasping when he comes to the blonde’s face. “What the hell happened to his eyes?!”

“Let me go!” Adam kicks, struggling against Scorpia's grip. “I have to get my swords back or everyone is gonna fucking die!” He wiggles, nearly forcing his way out of Scorpia's grip before she finds a new hold on him. He suddenly settles down, breathing heavily and practically glaring daggers into the archer kid's soul.

“What's happening, Adam? Why are we gonna die?” Arrow frowns, genuine concern plastered across his face with no amount of irony. Scorpia respects that, wearing your heart on your sleeve. It's something she prides herself on.

“Stop fucking-” He groans, looking down at his body in surprise for a moment. “What the *fuck*?” Bow and Glimmer exchange a look of confusion before Glimmer looks up at Scorpia with a marked lack of amusement at the situation.

“Sting him again.”

“I can't.” Scorpia mutters. “I used everything I had on She-Ra. She's a hell of a body to dose.” She eyes Arrow pleadingly, hoping the boy has some kind of backup plan in that pack of his. He seems to understand, taking it off his shoulder and grinning.

“Always come prepared!” The boy's jovial response forces an eye-roll out of Glimmer. Scorpia has to stifle a bemused laugh at the girl's disdain. He sets his pack down and begins to tightly bind Adam's wrists and legs together. When he's done, Scorpia picks the blonde up and tosses him over her shoulder.

“Put me down! Bow! Why are you working with them!?” Adam growls. Scorpia can swear she hears the boy speaking differently, almost with a lilt in his voice that wasn't there before that she knows of.

“Adam. What's gotten into you? You're acting nuts, dude!” Bow says, stepping behind Scorpia to meet Adam's gaze over her shoulder. Scorpia can feel the boy lift his head up to glare at the archer. He’s absolutely *pissed*, something she can tell almost entirely by his heavy, ragged breathing.

“Stop calling me that! What the hell man?!” He groans. “My name is not Adam!” Scorpia exchanges a glance with Glimmer, who shrugs, clearly as confused as she is.

“Then what is it?” Bow asks.

“It's Adora! Jeez Bow!” Adora? That’s not a name Scorpia is familiar with. She looks at Glimmer again, who seems just as befuddled as she is. Adam’s not just acting bizarrely, he’s not acting like, well, *Adam* at all. The sheer strangeness of the situation makes Scorpia’s head hurt.

“Huh.” Bow says plainly. That can't be good. “Whatever's causing his freakout must be related to the bots going off the fritz too.” He says it like it's obvious, as if Scorpia or Glimmer would have any

idea what that means. Glimmer cackles coldly from beside Scorpia, seeming irked by the very notion the boy's providing.

"So, what, Adam's a robot?" Glimmer wipes a tear from her eye. "You Resistance people are *nuts*. I swear if the robots weren't trying to kill us I'd have fucking knocked you out and taken you to Shadow Weaver as a trophy."

Bow grimaces, as if he's remembered who he's called a truce with. "Right. Let's find Entrapta. She probably knows how we can fix this." As he begins walking down the labyrinthine halls. Glimmer begrudgingly gestures at Scorpia to follow him.

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Entrapta and Catra near the engineer Princess's laboratory. Entrapta's certain cutting the power to the chip will stop the frenzy, but what she's really concerned about is where those two Horde soldiers and She-Ra have gone. If they're loose in the building they could be messing with loads of sensitive equipment that will take her hours to calibrate again. The very thought is almost more chilling than their current situation.

"We have to be close, right?" Catra mutters. Entrapta's lucky the magicat can see in the dark, because she only has the one pair of goggles with night vision and they're hers. "Feels like I've been in here for days."

"Hypothetically speaking, that might be true." Entrapta jabs, cackling when she sees Catra's mortified expression. "I'm kidding, it's only been about four hours." The magicat grumbles before giving her a light jab in the arm for it. The interaction is *almost* pleasant for Entrapta, besides the knot in her stomach telling her she was far too mean with that one. As they round the corner, they come up to a large mechanical door with a biosecurity pad beside it. This is it, the entrance to the place she'd spent countless grueling hours experimenting with machinery of every type. Entrapta removes the glove on her right hand and places it

on the scanner. It whirs for a second before turning green, signifying access being granted.

The door opens with a loud *clank*, the eyes of a dozen or more frenzied bots suddenly looking at she and Catra with fury. “Get ready for a fight.” She mutters to the magicat, readying her two magical pigtails like fists against them. A standoff begins, the robots staring for what feels like forever, before the sound of twenty-four robotic feet stampeding towards the two echoes out like the sound of war drums.

Entrapta swings, nailing one robot in the head and ripping another's off with the other pigtail. She spots Catra slicing into a pair just beside her, kicking them both down with a *thud.* The other robots seem to catch on, joining the assault in tandem. It isn't long before the two begin to become overwhelmed, the robots using their advantage in numbers as a shield. The engineer crouches, curling into a ball and taking her pigtails out of their ties. She has a plan, but she doesn't have time to let Catra know about it. The woman shouts at her over the screech of metal limbs, panicked and confused. Entrapta feels the robots begin to pile up on top of her and finally takes the chance. With a single, monstrous blow in every direction, she sends her hair out in a powerfully explosive punch, sending the bots flying in all directions as she stands back up. When the dust settles, she sees that more than one of them have had their heads, legs, or other assortment of appendages blown off.

“Holy shit.” Catra says in awe, watching Entrapta re-secure her pigtails. “That was incredible, ‘Trapta.” The genius princess just grins, a feeling of worth building up in her stomach. It's unfamiliar and almost sickening, transforming with immediacy into a much more familiar feeling of distrust. She eyes the large array of monitors situated above the glowing green chip, stepping over to them and carefully looking around for the control pad.

“So this is your crazy piece of tech.” Catra says with an uneasy tone. “How'd one little piece of metal cause a hundred of your guys to lose it?” The magicat looks at the housing for the glowing

green chip. Entrapta waits for the question to come, one that she’s surprised hasn’t been asked yet. “Why can’t we just take it out?”

“If we take it out, we risk losing the tech.” Entrapta says, spying the little tablet that allows her full control of Dryl’s multiple utility systems. In the ensuing fight it had been thrown beneath one of her workbenches. “The sudden power disruption could short out the circuitry.” She thinks for a moment. “It also runs extremely hot, and if we try to take it out we could risk hurting ourselves.”

“How's that factor in She-Ra?” Catra says, not moving as Entrapta grabs the pad. “Her swords are probably First Ones related but they certainly don't have any kind of comms relay in them.” The engineer grabs the datapad and stands back up, turning to her companion.

“Let me put it this way.” Entrapta says, dusting off the tablet. “The She-Ra you saw back there was pretty different from a few weeks ago, right?” Entrapta watches Catra nod affirmatively. “So, then, when your friend had his little upgrade, the swords themselves had to communicate with something to *receive* that info. Even if it's not a proper relay, it can still download data, and this chip-” She gestures at the artifact. “Is sending data.”

Entrapta looks down at the pad, tapping a few buttons to force the power off. A few checks appear to make sure she's actually doing what she wants to be doing, and she presses a button to switch off the mains power in the generator below. The remaining lights go out immediately, leaving only the sickening green glow in the room. A moment passes where nothing happens before the auxiliary lights kick on, brightly lighting every corner of the lab in horrifying white light.

“What the hell?” Entrapta says, looking at the chip. “The chip is still online.” She curses under her breath. “The modifications. I couldn't power it without directly routing it from the generator, which I can't turn off from here.”

“So we're gonna have to go down there?” Catra says with a grumble. “How come these lights weren’t on before?”

“They only power on when there’s an outage. I don’t- there’s not really a need for them usually anyhow because I have my goggles, so I just keep them off unless things get really hairy.” A pang of distress crosses Entrapta’s heart at having to do this the hard way. “Unfortunately, we’re going to have to do a lot more walking.” The engineer snorts when Catra groans in frustration.

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Scorpia is blinded when the halls suddenly fill with bright, sterile light. She looks around, squinting the spots out of her eyes for a moment before seeing that Bow has stopped.

“What now, Arrow?” Glimmer says, rubbing her eyes.

“Those must be the backup lights. Catra and Entrapta must have already tried to cut the power to the chip.”

“Which means…?” Scorpia looks at the boy warily.

“Which means the chip must be running on everything Dryl has to keep it online.” He grimaces.

“So, what, why not just, like, remove it?” Glimmer says, tilting her head curiously.

“If it's using this much power it's probably too hot to just grab. It might have even welded itself to whatever it's plugged into. Removal might not be an option at this point.” Bow huffs.

“So, what, we just wait for those two buffoons to go down there?” Glimmer says grouchily.

“Either that, or we-”

“Or we what?” Scorpia says, not realizing that the weight on her shoulder has suddenly lifted. She doubles over in pain as Adam

kicks her in the back, having chewed through the ropes around his hands before tearing off the ones at his feet. Scorpia rolls, watching as Glimmer steps over her and meets Adam's swinging punch with her staff. Bow fires an arrow that attempts to wrap Adam's body in a net. The blonde kicks it off course, sending it flying into Glimmer, who is knocked to the ground. Adam's still-red eyes are filled with hot, blinding rage, making the boy seem almost inhuman, his fury seeming to take on a life of its own.

"Bow. What's going on? Start talking." Adam says in that same strange cadence as before, the one that almost sounds as if someone else is piloting his body. Bow looks at him confusedly, never taking his eyes off of Adam as he aggressively walks toward him.

"What do you mean? We're in Dryl. We came here for Entrapta." The words seem to irritate Adam more, and he angrily closes the gap between him and the archer. Bow steps back as Adam approaches, allowing enough space for Scorpia to quietly stand and knock Adam over the head with a pincer. He groans in pain, crumbling to the ground.

"Without shutting that chip down, he's gonna be like this for a while, I take it?" Glimmer says, dusting herself off as Scorpia undoes the net wrapped around her.

"It's like he's possessed. I've never seen him so angry and confused." Bow says. "We'll just have to wait until they shut the power off, then we can remove the chip and get it back to Bright Moon." Bow immediately cringes as he realizes he shouldn't have said that out loud. Scorpia and Glimmer exchange glances, nodding at each other before simultaneously jumping at the boy. He protests as the pair hold him down, using the same ropes he'd held Adam with to tie him up. Now they'd just have to wait for Catra to shut down the chip, and she'd walk right into their trap.

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Getting the generators off was simple enough, it just required flipping a few switches and they'd be shut down. Getting back to the lab through dark hallways with a dying pair of goggles was a different story. Entrapta had practically had to hold onto Catra rather embarrassingly the entire time in order to properly make it back to the laboratory in one piece.

Prying the door open was a pain. Because all of the doors were designed with lockdown latches that engaged during a power failure, Catra had had to cut through them one by one with the most ear-piercing screech that Entrapta had ever heard. By the time they've pulled it open, she's overstimulated, tired, and ready to be done with all of this.

Then comes the first punch. Catra gets whacked in the face with a flying fist, the near-total darkness doing her no favors to see her attacker. Entrapta feels a heavy foot step on her hair and yelps, instinctively swinging the other pigtail in the direction of her assailant. The pair fight their attackers in the dark for only minutes, but to Entrapta time has slowed to a painful crawl. Before long, a punch swings from the side Entrapta's not defending on, knocking her to the ground.

“Catra!” She yelps, the foot of the large person holding her in place. She sees arcs of black lightning shoot out across the dark lab, lighting the face of the pink-haired girl menacingly. A momentary cry echoes as it reaches Catra, and she hits the ground with a sickening *thud.*

“Take the rest of Arrow’s rope and tie her up. We've got what we came for.” The pink-haired girl’s cold voice comes in the darkness. “Take Adam's swords, too. Can't let She-Ra keep being a problem.”

Entrapta takes the moment to grab the leg of the person above her with her hair and yank. The form lets out a gruff yelp as she crumbles to the ground. She can't let the Horde get that chip. The engineer stands, running towards what she hopes is the machine

holding the component before slamming into something very person-like.

The pink haired girl makes a *tsk* noise. “Sorry, nerd princess. Too late.” She says sardonically, before Entrapta feels the end of the girl's staff slam into her face. With all this hitting today, she's gonna have a black eye. She falls to one knee, growling in pain as the girl chuckles sadistically. It's cut short by the sound of another person knocking into the Force Captain.

“Glimmer, leave her alone!” Adam growls. He seems to have regained his senses as he dodges a hit from the staff.

“Adam! So nice of you to join us. Unfortunately, it's time for us to go.” Glimmer says, shuffling towards the door. “Ah, ah” She chuckles and points at the magicat in the scorpion woman's arms, “Make one more move and the cat princess gets a full blast of lightning.” She arcs some black lightning between her fingers for emphasis.

Entrapta can hear them shuffle away, the sound fading into the distance. A beat passes before finally she hears Adam fall to his knees and begin to cry. Despite all of their best efforts, they'd failed. She can't help but feel like this was her doing, like she'd caused all of this. And worst of all? Entrapta wonders if they deserved to. Maybe this was punishment for her failures. She hears rustling as Adam climbs to his feet and steps toward her.

“Who the fuck are you?” He says, growling at her with an angry sob. Entrapta isn't sure what the question means, and her lack of response only seems to anger him more. “Well? How do I know you aren't working with the Horde?!”

The knot in her stomach returns. “I- I'm not. I've never been affiliated with anyone until you extended the offer to me.” She says, her voice practically shrinking to a whisper as she begins to cry. “I'm not- I'm not like that. I'm not bad.”

The statement seems to stab Adam in the right place, because he sighs and walks away to untie Bow. His words rattle around in her head like a marble in a glass bowl. She wasn't evil. How could he think such a thing? It must be all her fault. It's always Entrapta's fault for trying to be friends with people.

Now she'd have to help clean up her mess.

Chapter End Notes

> This is probably the weakest chapter I've written in the new version, which says something because it was the strongest in the original Act 1. I have pretty much all of the writing done for the rest of the act, I just need to tweak it to match the vision I'm working towards with Adam and Entrapta's arcs. I must say too, Entrapta's personality has been modified a bit to reflect my own autism and social anxiety somewhat. I feel I can do the character much better justice with how I've written this version than canon because autism is different for everybody and I want to be able to express accurately how she experiences it.
>
> Anyhow, thanks so much for reading! Act 1 should be complete before the year's end, and then we'll be moving onto Act 2! Take care!

Chapter 7

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter VI: I Can't Let This Kill Me

"I never should have let her leave this castle." Angella's tone is somber, almost despondent, as she gazes down at the war room table, never meeting Adam's eyes. "And now, I'm faced with an impossible choice. To give myself up to the Horde would be an end to our cause, and yet, I'm tempted merely for the sake of saving my daughter." She sighs, finally looking up at the blonde. "If we had She-Ra we might have a chance, but without your blades we-"

"There has to be another way." Adam says. He clenches his hands into fists and feels the way his nails dig into the skin of his palms. "We can't just give up. I can rescue them. I know the Fright Zone better than anyone here. I don't know how but- but I'll get them back."

"How, Adam?" Angella shakes her head. "I won't let you go running off on a suicide mission. I forbid it." Adam looks in her eyes and sees the despair, the way she feels so certain that he will fail. It stabs at him just to see she thinks so lowly of him.

"So you're just going to give up!?" Adam growls, stepping forward with a fury that seems to surprise Angella.

"No. I am biding my time. Another solution will find its way to us." Angella says firmly, furrowing her brow at the boy. The words send a prickle of rage up Adam's spine, one that he'd been pushing down since Dryl. The chip had done something to him, changed him in some way he can't describe. They all see it: that

way his eyes shine a crimson red instead of their original gray. He turns and storms out of the room with a scoff.

Then, a moment later, he finds himself in his bed and staring at the ceiling of his room with intense dissonance. Static seems to fill his brain, flooding in with a forcefulness he can't fight. He doesn't know how long he's been staring at the ceiling, but it feels like it might be hours, maybe even days. He doesn't care, letting the static continue to cloud his thoughts like a thunderstorm.

Adam. The small, concerned voice that suddenly cuts through the white noise is not one he recognizes. A pang of dread jolts through him as he bolts upright, looking around for the source only to be met with an empty bedroom.

"Great. I'm losing my mind." He grumbles. "First I lose Catra, then my mind. What's next?" Adam buries his face in his hands, sudden despair washing over him with raging intensity. "Why me?" He mutters between sobs. "Why did I have to be She-Ra when anyone else would have been better?" He breaks into full heaving sobs. "I never wanted this!"

No. You didn't. The voice comes. It's almost soothing to hear some form of validation for his struggle. He'd be more comfortable with it were that voice not seemingly in his head. The voice seems to chuckle at his thoughts. *You aren't going crazy. Just relax.* He almost laughs at how much she sounds like Catra in that moment. He misses his friend terribly, the thought of what Shadow Weaver could be doing to her sending another forceful sob into his throat. He can't do this, it's too much.

It's not too much.

"Then what do you want me to do!?" He yells at the voice. "Who are you?!" He receives no response. His gaze finds the mirror situated across from his bed, the one he tends to keep covered. They cleaned his room while he'd been away in Dryl, so right now the mirror is pristine, reflecting back a pair of angry, vengeful red

eyes. He barely recognizes himself when he isn't She-Ra anymore. It's like he becomes another person.

Unfortunately, the voice that seems to signify his descent into madness has a point. If Catra's to make it out of this, he needs to assemble a rescue team whether Angella likes it or not. He stands, brushing himself off and straightening his shirt. He doesn't like to look at himself, to *see* who Adam is beneath the She-Ra, but right now he was all they had.

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"Princess Catra of Bright Moon." Shadow Weaver chuckles coldly, coming close to Catra's face. She hangs from her hands against a concrete wall, watching as the witch steps through it and comes face to face with the commander. "Pleasure to finally meet you once again."

"Shadow Weaver." Catra deadpans. "Is your idea of pleasure hanging me from metal chains?"

Shadow Weaver cackles. "You know, I'd pinned you for being more like your father but no-" Despite the mask covering her face, Catra can almost *see* the woman's expression darken. "You turned out like that vile woman instead. Queen *Angella* with her morals and her stuck-up attitude." A finger strokes Catra's cheek, one that the magicat is tempted to bite off in anger.

"Like you'd know anything about morals." Catra growls. "You're a ruthless monster."

"Oh ho! Ruthless, I quite like that." She undoes Catra's chains, letting her fall to the floor. "But ruthlessness takes many forms. You and I are not as different as you think." The Horde cadets poke and prod Catra along as they descend to the bottom of the prison block, passing scum and enemies of the Horde alike. When they finally reach the bottom, a large metal door sits before them.

"Where are you taking me?" Catra says, trying not to let the hint of fear creeping in her voice show.

“To show you something, dear.” Shadow Weaver says in that sickeningly sweet voice. The door opens and the cadets aggressively drag the princess to a large metal chair situated in the center of the seemingly empty room.

“What the fuck are you doing?!” She struggles against them, groaning in pain as the butt of a rifle slams against her face. When she finally snaps out of the daze, she’s been situated just in front of a closed viewfinder, strapped and secured in the chair with no way of escape. Then, bright light floods into the room as the viewfinder opens. When her eyes finally adjust, she’s horrified at what she sees: chained within the room on the other side lies a beaten and bloodied Juliet. She screams and yells for them to let the woman go to no avail.

“Now Catra.” Shadow Weaver says coldly. “Normally, I'd kill Resistance fighters on the spot, but I'm feeling generous today. Give me the current location of Mystacor and I'll allow her to live.”

Catra’s heart leaps into her throat. What does Shadow Weaver want with Mystacor? “Like I’d ever tell you.” She spits, glaring at the witch with intensity. The woman just chuckles evilly in response, as if her reaction was an expected one. Shadow Weaver nods at the guards, who enter the room and begin beating the woman with stun batons.

“Wait! Don't hurt her! Wait!” Catra's yells turn into sobs as she watches the pair of Horde soldiers senselessly and ruthlessly beat Juliet. She can’t tell them where Mystacor is, but raw emotion tempts her as she watches the general try uselessly to fight back. The woman’s fighting grows more and more tired before finally she stops moving, sending a sharp, guilty sob clawing out of Catra's throat.

“As expected.” Shadow Weaver leans down to Catra’s ear. “The empathy still needs weeding out, but I'd say I'm almost *pleased* with your display. We are all ruthless in some way, princess, and you’ve just allowed them to kill someone to save your precious

resistance.” Shadow Weaver chuckles, looking back through the window at Juliet. The pair of Horde cadets lead her through the door back to her cell in silence.

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“Adam.”

Adam punches the dummy with a fierce, angry right hook. He barely registers the deadpan voice that calls his name from the sidelines as he swings and swings, taking out some much needed rage on it.

“Adam!” He finally turns to glare at Mermista. A light drizzle trickles over the courtyard. The water princess looks at him unamusedly, crossing her arms as if expecting him to stop for her. He rolls his eyes and takes off the wrappings on his hands.

“What is it, Mermista?” He's miffed that she interrupted his training session, but shoves it down after a moment. This could be important and he needs to remember the stakes; Catra's still in the Fright Zone. Adam watches as Perfuma joins her side. The flower princess’s hand brushes Mermista's arm lightly. Were-? No, nevermind. Not any of Adam's business.

“Perfuma and I came out here to check on you. You look like shit dude.” Mermista smirks and Adam rolls his eyes. “When was the last time you ate?”

“Doesn't matter.” He mutters.

“It does though. Bow's worried about you too.” The name of his friend sends a chill down Adam's spine. Bow must hate him by now for losing Catra. Mermista shifts and meets Adam's eyes. “Besides, ‘Fuma heard your little conversation with our beloved leader yesterday and she and I think it's bullshit.”

“Yeah, well, wouldn't anyone else?” Adam sighs. “Angella won't risk losing me, she'd never authorize a suicide mission.”

“So what if she doesn't?” Perfuma grins. “What if we just did it anyway?” He's almost taken aback at the woman's forwardness.

Adam eyes the two of them suspiciously. “What you're asking is treason.” The Horde taught strictly that treason is punishable by torture or even death. The very concept of disobeying the orders of the queen repulses Adam.

“Well, call it light disobeying.” The flower princess grins. “Besides, if we pull this off, it might prove to her that we can handle ourselves.” The woman practically glows in the cloudy gray light, a stark contrast from the rage Adam witnessed weeks prior. He hates to admit that she's right. They both are. Despite how repulsed he is, Angella wouldn't have him murdered for trying to fix his mistakes in Dryl. At worst he'd be removed from the Resistance, something that he can handle if it means getting his friend back.

“Why are you helping me? You don't have to do this.” His voice is low and wracked with nerves. He doesn't want to drag the entire group into the Fright Zone and risk them all.

“We're an *alliance, remember*?” Mermista scoffs. “We have each other's backs. Besides, you and Catra stuck your necks out for us both. Least we could do is repay you.”

Adam looks between the pair, realizing silently that this must be what actually being cared about is like. He thinks back to the voice from the day before. He hasn't heard the woman since, as if she'd only been his imagination trying to encourage him to break his Horde way of mind.

“Alright. Let's do it.”

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Adam nervously looks over the assembled members of the Princess Alliance. Their mission now was a simple breakout, but it would require careful and extensive planning to do it correctly. He eyes each of them individually to gauge their emotions. Bow looks

as though he's far away, clearly struggling with losing Catra as much as Adam is. Entrapta seems to be nervous and keeps looking at the others as if waiting for their approval. He feels a pang of regret for the way he acted toward her at Dryl. She's just as freaked out as the rest of them and that mural of the prophecy got under Adam's skin in a bad way. Mermista's usually deadpan and unemotional stare actually carries a small, reassuring smirk and beside her is Perfuma, who is smiling in support as Adam lays down a map of the Fright Zone on the War Room table.

"So listen up." He says, making sure all eyes are on him before continuing. "If we're going to do this, we need to do it fast and with precision. We're guerilla fighters, we don't have the numbers like the Horde, so we cannot afford to get sidetracked or lose a single person." The group, save for Bow, nods. Adam points to the east side of the map. "The prison wing is in this sector here and it's heavily guarded. Since there's only five of us we're going to need to split up."

"Oh yeah, cause that worked in Dryl." Bow says with a glare. "I thought you didn't want to lose anyone, Adam. You're asking us to set up for failure!"

"Ok, ok. Let me finish. The prison wing has a sewer system that leads directly to the hills on the other side of this wall." Adam points to the eastern barricade. "Mermista and Entrapta will enter through it and use it to make it up inside."

"Why me?" Entrapta points at herself anxiously. "I'm not that u-useful in a fight, Adam. And don't forget how I fucked everything up back home." She rubs her arm. "I mean we never would have gotten into this mess if it weren't for my experiments on that damn chip."

"You couldn't have known what the chip would do, Entrapta." Adam says reassuringly. He hears Bow scoff in response and eyes the archer, searching those wrathful eyes for something more than anger. "Is something amusing, Bow?"

“Just that you’re only half-right. She couldn't have known. But you could have controlled yourself. You didn't *have* to transform into She-Ra, but you just gotta show off for every princess we meet! And how can we even trust you *now*? Your eyes never changed back! That's not reassuring!”

“I transformed into She-Ra to defend myself and Catra.” Adam says calmly as he tries to bite back anger at the accusations.

“So, what, Adam is just useless when she's not around? Just admit you like being her better at this point! You take every chance you get to transform anyway!” Bow growls. Adam feels the sting of his words drive deep into his core. He's not sure what Bow really means by that. He liked being She-Ra because she protected people, because people needed her. They haven’t ever needed Adam.

“Bow.” Perfuma says diplomatically. “It is not your place to accuse Adam of these things.” She turns back to Adam. “But he does have a point. You don't seem to do very much field combat in this state, how can we trust you'll be prepared?”

Adam nods. “Because I know the Fright Zone’s tactics well enough to be able to plan for them.” He breathes a sigh of relief internally as Bow nods, seemingly conceding the point. “As for my eyes: I don't know what the chip did to me, but I won't lie to you all. It’s affected me deeply. I feel her anger, her disdain, her need to be free with every aching moment and I can't explain why. And every moment is marked with- with a name I can't place my connection to. It's like something is reaching out to me and it's waiting for someone else to reach back.” The admission causes the room to fall silent for a moment.

“Who?” Mermista says finally. She raises a confused eyebrow.

Adam sighs. “Adora.”

“You used that name before, at the party after we destroyed the pollution machine.” Perfuma says. “Who is she?”

“I have no idea. But I get the feeling she's just going to keep getting important.” Adam looks away. “Her name is everywhere, like the sword is trying to make sure I remember her.” He shakes his head and meets Bow's eyes. “I'm sorry. I'm sorry I couldn't stop them. I don't know what that chip did or why but maybe-” He glances at Entrapta with a smile. She nervously waves back before he turns away towards Bow again. “Maybe once we're through here we can figure it out together. But first, we need to rescue Catra. Will you help me, Bow?”

Bow's shoulders relax. “Yeah. Ok. I can do that.” He looks over the Fright Zone map, eyeing the details carefully. “If we're splitting up, we'll need to distract the bulk of their forces. This courtyard is well suited to that. We can fight our way into the main atrium while Team Mermista goes for Catra.”

Adam nods. “That should give us exactly the kind of opening we need.”

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Catra looks at the stone floor, studying its lack of intricate detail as if she'd spotted some kind of pattern after all. It's been six hours since Shadow Weaver forced her to watch General Juliet be beaten to death. The woman had made a point to sear it into her memory with words, taunting her and telling Catra how she was just the first, if the princess didn't give the location of Mystacor up.

Then, she'd left. No food, no water, just Catra dangling from her aching hands and eyeing the concrete. She hated being alone with her thoughts, hated being forced to confront the emotional anguish that wracks her core. She wants nothing more than to cause pain to that witch, to make her suffer the same way her father and Adam did. That growing rage and desire for revenge is something she’s locked away for years, but each day the Horde continues to hurt people she gets closer to letting it loose.

Her head shoots up when the energy barrier is opened. Two Horde soldiers carry an unconscious form by the arms, tossing the person into the cell with little regard. Catra eyes the bruised and bloodied boy at her feet with fear as she takes in his appearance. His blonde hair is knotted and ratty and his clothes torn all over. “What did you do to him?!” She cries instinctively, hands pulling against the chains.

“This is what happens to those who do not cooperate, Catra.” Shadow Weaver floats through the doorway. “I will strip everything away from you, one by one, as I began when I captured your father those years ago.”

Catra's tears turn from anguish to rage. “Fuck you! Fuck you, you old witch! I'll fucking kill you where you stand, I swear it on my fucking life!” The woman just laughs coldly, bemused by the pointless show of anger from the young commander.

“You and I aren't so different, little princess. You'd make an excellent Force Captain, if it weren't all that damn loyalty to that woman you call mother.” The woman’s disdain for Angella seethes through her words. “Tell me the location of Mystacor, mongrel!”

Catra spits at Shadow Weaver and bares her teeth. “I will make every day of your life a living hell if I ever get my hands on you. I will make you suffer the pain of every Etherian whose life you’ve ruined.”

Shadow Weaver chuckles, floating toward Adam on the ground. “He came here alone for you, did you know? Always the hero.” She shocks him with a bolt of black lightning, waking him up with a fearful twitch in his eye. Catra's heart pounds as his gray eyes pierce into her own.

“Wh-where am I? Catra?” He squints, his eyes adjusting to the darkness. Catra looks down at him in abject horror. He's beaten and battered, the mop of blonde hair atop his head tangled and matted.

“Hush, boy.” Shadow Weaver growls, kicking him. “You'll speak when spoken to.”

Adam grits his teeth, glaring up at the woman. A tense second passes before he throws his first punch. Fist after fist flies toward her, Shadow Weaver dodging each of them effortlessly as if she knows where he’ll aim. The witch sends another bolt of lightning at him, coursing through his body and causing him to scream in pain.

“No!” Catra screams before she really recognizes what she's doing. “Please! Don't hurt him! It's hidden between Plumeria and Seaworth!” Catra pleads, watching as Shadow Weaver finally stops. She chuckles coldly, staring at the magicat for a moment before the entire room seems to melt away around her.

It's an illusion. Catra thinks, horrified. Was it all an illusion? Was Juliet? How can she know what's real and what isn't? She's just been tortured into giving up the location of one of the most guarded places on the planet because she couldn't see through it. The form of Adam dissipates, and Catra watches as Shadow Weaver coldly leaves the room. She suddenly feels like she doesn't have much fight left after all.

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Explosions sound in the sky as the battle enters full swing. Adora is helpless to do anything but watch as pieces of Castle Evernight are thrown every which way into the icy channel in front of her. Her leg aches in excruciating pain as she tries to stand, leaning on one of her swords for support. It's fractured badly enough that if she didn't find medical help soon she might die from infection. Unfortunately, the water that Castle Evernight is butted up against is filled with Horde and Salinean ships alike, engaged in a fiery sea battle even more terrifying than the one on land. Her eyes turn to the snow behind her, a small light blinking faintly in the distance.

She'll need a miracle if she wants to live, and that means she needs to walk.

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Adam opens an eye groggily. Today is the day they begin their excursion and it was no time to be analyzing dreams. He stands and throws on a new signature white shirt. It's going to be a tough fight today and he'd need all the preparation he could get. That's why he finds himself in the training courtyard a few minutes later, throwing punch after punch at one of the training dummies.

"Hey." Bow says and it's only then that he realizes anyone else has come out here. He's been alone for more than two hours by now. The boy smiles at him, a very real and genuine smile that is a jarring contrast to what he'd been yesterday. "I'm sorry for how I acted yesterday. I didn't realize you'd been going through all that after Dryl."

Adam sighs, deciding now is as good a time as any for a break. He takes a seat on one of the benches lining the training ground. "It's- it's fine. Really. It's been tough since then for both of us. We kind of lost our guiding force." He laughs mirthlessly. "I don't blame you."

"Who do you think she is?" Bow asks; it's the first time since Plumeria anyone other than Catra has been interested in Adora.

"I don't know. Catra thought she was the last She-Ra, but the hologram in the Crystal Castle told me she's the one in their prophecy." Adam chuckles. "Guess it's hard not to feel like everything I'm doing is a bit pointless if that's the case."

Bow thinks for a moment. "It must mean something that you keep seeing her in dreams. When you were chipped you were convinced you *were* Adora."

"That's what makes it so frustrating. It feels like the answer should be right there." Adam mutters, shaking his head.

“That's because it is.”

Adam looks around for the source of the new voice, his eyes finding Bow's finally. His exhaustion must be making his brain play tricks with Bow's voice. “What do you mean?”

Bow tilts his head in confusion. “I didn't say anything.” A sense of dread creeps into Adam's stomach. That hadn't been his mind playing tricks, that had been the voice from yesterday morning, only this time it had sounded very real and very close.

“N-nothing. Don't worry about it.” Adam says shakily, ignoring the strange look his friend is giving him. He's obviously losing it to sleep deprivation. “Let's go gather the others. It's almost time.”

Bow nods and stands. He brushes himself off for a moment before helping Adam to his feet as well. The pair make small talk as they begin their walk to the War Room. They have one hell of a day ahead of them. They don’t make it far before Entrapta steps into the courtyard, a misty-eyed look on her face. She doesn’t seem to notice them at first, staring up at the clouds pensively. The duo exchange a look before Adam steps over to her.

“Hey.” Adam puts his hand on her shoulder, and she recoils in horror. The blonde feels his heart crack in two as he realizes she’s afraid of him. He thinks back to his outburst at the end of the Dryl mission, guilt overwhelming him as he remembers who he was in that moment. Prophecy or not, it was unbecoming of him to lash out so angrily at her. “Are you ok, Entrapta?”

She looks away, seeming to find it difficult to meet the blonde’s eyes. “Yeah. Fine. I was just on my way to the armory.” She eyes the doors at the other end of the training yard, clearly desperate to escape the conversation.

“You don’t look fine.” Bow says plainly, earning a sigh from the engineer. She looks between him and Adam as if deciding what she should do before finally pinching her nose frustratedly.

“I- I don’t want to do this. I’m a coward, I know. But I’m not a fighter, guys, I’m just a nerdy asshole with a wrench.” She chuckles. “I’d just be in the way on your mission.”

“That’s not true.” Adam starts. The girl looks up at him reflectively, a flash of anger seeming to come across her face before dissolving back into melancholy. “You’re a genius, Entrapta. The Horde has security systems of every kind all over the Fright Zone. We’ll need your expertise with tech to even consider getting through them.”

Entrapta furrows her brow. “So, what, I’m just a tool for you?!” The outburst surprises Adam, not realizing how deep he’d cut, even if unintentionally. “Was I a tool in Dryl, too? After everything you *screamed* at me. You said it was *my* fault.” She glares at him.

“I- I didn’t know what I was doing. I was still recovering from all the effects of the chip.” Adam says remorsefully. This is the girl at the center of the mural? The same mural that depicts her leading an army of robots into endless battle? He sees so much sadness in her, as if a sharp enough point could crack her at any moment. She doesn’t need anger, she needs *recognition.* “I’m sorry I yelled at you, Entrapta. That wasn’t right of me.” He puts a hand out to shake hers and smiles. “Can we start over?”

Entrapta eyes him suspiciously, looking between Adam’s eyes, his hand, and Bow. A moment passes before she sighs and nods, reaching out to shake the blonde’s hand in return. “It’s ok. Everything that happened back there- I mean- It was a clusterfuck. I don’t blame you for freaking out.” She chuckles. “But, you still owe me. I want to study you in She-Ra form when all this is over. Find out how she works.”

Adam smiles. “Okay. Yeah. Deal.”

Chapter End Notes

Another shorter one before we get into one of the longest chapters I've ever written (My god! 7500 words!) and then

the final arc of Act I! Thank you so much for sticking by me for this! I promise everything will pay off soon!

Chapter 8

Chapter VII: Save Me From The Ghosts And Shadows

The Fright Zone. It stands menacingly before the group of princesses, looming like a monument to pure unbridled evil. The place kind of gives Entrapta the creeps with its sharp twisting metal and jagged, industrial edges. She'd like to not have to stay here for any longer than necessary, which is why when the group finally approaches the pipe jutting out from the east wall, she's a little relieved that things are kicking into gear.

"We're here." Adam's voice pulls the engineer princess out of her thoughts as they approach the pipe. She still doesn't trust him, not entirely. He'd looked at her with such fury that day in Dryl that she can't even fathom how Bow and Catra are his friends.

"I really hope we don't, like, grow extra arms or whatever from this." Mermista deadpans, eyeing Adam irritably. Right, she was supposed to swim the two of them in. Entrapta doesn't envy her one bit as the pair approach the drainage pipe, but she supposes she still has to swim with her. Mermista reaches a hand out that the engineer hesitantly takes.

"It'll be fine. We'll round the corner to the side gate and prepare for our distraction. I trust you guys." Adam smiles sadly. Entrapta follows Mermista into the green slime and resists the urge to gag. It has a consistency like gel, just thin enough to swim through but still disgusting nonetheless. The water princess dives, pulling Entrapta along as they speed through the dark, slime ridden tunnel.

The familiar tinge of anxiety creeps up Entrapta's neck as she and Mermista swim through the sewer pipe. She'd been grateful that she was equipped with a flashlight, because as they swam the opening just continued to darken more and more ominously. It takes them another fifteen minutes of wading through the

disgusting ooze before a hint of light signals they've nearly reached the waste dumping zone below the prison.

Mermista climbs out first, stepping onto the concrete beside the river of green ooze with a sharp groan. Entrapta follows, feeling the slime try to hold onto her as she pulls herself up and out. The waste is a bit fascinating despite her horror at it. Though she is a woman of science and progress, the pollution of the land surrounding the Fright Zone is disturbing in a way she can't describe.

“You'd think they'd have a better system for this than just spilling it out onto the ground.” She murmurs, earning a hum of agreement from Mermista. The water princess doesn't seem to trust her very much, Entrapta can tell. That seems to be par for the course these days. It stabs at her core a bit, to be doubted completely by the people she thinks of as friends. She can't help but wonder if they even care.

“Prison stairs are this way, if Adam's map is correct.” Mermista says, pointing down the large, ominous passageway that carries the ravine of polluted green ooze out of the Fright Zone. Entrapta eyes it warily, the darkness almost imposing as the passage stretches into oblivion. The engineer feels her heart thump in her chest, seeming to practically pound against her ribcage as they begin their walk. After a moment or two, Mermista finally speaks up. “You ok, nerd princess?”

“Please don’t call me that.” Entrapta mutters, trying to stave off the anxiety attack as best as she can. She thinks back to the last time she nearly had one, in the vents above Dryl, and curses herself for being so easily bothered. “But, no, I’m not. I didn't want to come and I let Adam talk me into it.”

“Why not?” Mermista eyes her with false concern. “You're just as valuable as any of us, Entrapta. We wouldn't be able to do this without you.” A drumbeat grows more aggressive in Entrapta's chest. How can this woman lie to her so easily? How can she say such things without meaning them? It just pisses her off.

“Because I’m dead weight!” She growls, not realizing at first that tears are flowing down her cheeks. “Because I just get in everyone’s way. You should have seen the way Adam looked at me when he saw me in Dryl. It was so angry, so full of *venom.* It was like I disgusted him! I’m just a nuisance that others only come to when they need to use my stupid brain. It's all I've ever been.”

“That’s not true.” Mermista starts, placing a hand on Entrapta’s shoulder softly. “I’m sorry I called you that, Entrapta. I thought it might lighten the mood.” The engineer looks up at her, glaring for a moment before shaking her head. Mermista doesn’t say anything for a moment, just standing there for a time while Entrapta processes everything. “I don’t know what Adam’s deal is. He’s-” She chuckles morbidly. “He’s just as broken as the rest of us. I mean, you see it in his eyes, the way he looks like he’s about to jump out of his skin.”

Entrapta sighs, looking up at Mermista sadly. “Have you ever felt like people can only see you one way? That they only have one idea of who you should be and you can’t change that?” The engineer watches as Mermista thinks on this for a moment before nodding. “That’s everything I am. I holed myself up in Dryl because it was better for everyone that way. They wouldn’t have to be disgusted by the parts of me that are ugly, they could just use my brain when they wanted to and leave. I-” Entrapta’s voice cracks. “I’ve wished every day that I was stupider, that I was more useless, because maybe then people would see me.”

“It’s not just you.” Mermista says softly. “I’m the same way. I mean, look at me. Would you have really expected me to be anything other than whiny? I care about people, I have things I love and I hate and I try so hard to show it but it doesn’t come out as anything more than muted sarcasm. I’ve always felt like people only see me as indifferent because showing you care is fucking *hard.*”

“Wasn’t it your idea to come here for Catra?” Entrapta asks, earning an amused scoff from the water princess.

“It was. I mean, before I- before I met Perfuma I thought no one would see that side of me. She had to convince me the idea wasn't insanely ridiculous sounding. Sometimes- sometimes people care a lot more than they seem to.” She groans. “But it’s hard to show everyone your heart when it’s beating beneath a big metal suit of armor.” She pauses, pointing ahead of them. A doorway is in sight, one that likely leads finally to the main part of the station below the prison. Once they get through there, it’s go-time for Operation Save the Cat.

“Looks like the rest of our heart-to-heart will have to wait.” Entrapta snickers, eyeing Mermista. “You ready to stage a breakout?”

Mermista smirks, looking at the doorway intensely. “Hell yeah.”

[---]

Adam looks at the front gate of the Fright Zone. It's been about ninety minutes since Entrapta and Mermista began their swim, which means it's about time to start distracting the Horde. He grips the staff he'd taken from the Bright Moon armory tightly, raising it in the air as the signal to Perfuma and Bow to begin the assault. The archer swiftly fires an explosive arrow that blows the lock off the gate. Alarms begin to sound as the trio steps through it into the Fright Zone's main entry yard.

A dozen Horde soldiers come stumbling in over each other practically as they try to respond to the commotion. Perfuma grabs at least five of them with vines that throw them every which way possible, while Bow fires a shockwave arrow that sends another three flying off their feet. Adam's barely done anything but direct them yet until one of them in particular steps forward.

“How dare you show your face here?!” The woman screams in Hordespeak. The voice is one Adam recognizes all too well, seeing the face of his former squadmate emerge as Lonnie removes her helmet. “You think you can come back here after all you've done?!” Her glare is piercing, conveying a mountain of rage she

must feel at Adam. It tugs at his heart, to remember how they used to be friends. He still wonders even now if he's done the right thing by leaving them behind.

“I couldn't stay Lonnie, not after everything I'd seen.” Adam responds, his Hordespeak a bit rusty after a month or two spent without using it. “There's still time, you don't have to do this. Let us pass and we'll get you to Bright Moon. To safety!”

“Fuck you.” Lonnie swings her staff at Adam, forcing him to bring his own up to meet it. She's an aggressive fighter, nearly hitting Adam twice with two rapid fire jabs. He jumps back, ducking under a swipe at his face and bringing his own slamming into Lonnie’s arm. The cadet groans in pain but doesn't let up, continuing to swing at Adam recklessly. An attempt to parry her ends in his staff being launched from his hands.

Adam is forced to duck and dodge swing after swing. When an opening comes, he drops to the ground and uses his legs to kick out at Lonnie from below. She steps around his blows while trying to get each and every hit she can in. The effort is tiring Adam out fast, but eventually Lonnie slips up and his foot connects with her shin. She tumbles forward, unable to catch herself in time as Adam swings to his feet and points the butt of the cadet's staff at her face.

“You're done. We're going inside.” He looks up at Bow, who's run over with Perfuma to provide support. The pair had incapacitated every soldier in the yard by tangling them in vines or being caught in a net arrow. By the time Adam had gained the upper hand, no one but the Resistance still stood in on the sandy ground. “Tie her up. It's time to begin the full frontal assault.” Adam looks to the main Fright Zone complex as Bow complies. “Now comes the hard part.”

[---]

Catra hasn't seen another soul in days, not since she'd been forced to give the location of the floating city of Mystacor over to

Shadow Weaver. Incredible guilt wracks her for this, that her Aunt Castaspella’s kingdom could be in danger because she did such a thing.

So when the energy barrier of her cell opens, she looks up in surprise. Instead of Shadow Weaver, this time comes a different face: Glimmer's. She carries with her a plate of food and water, something Catra hadn't realized until now that she needs so desperately.

“I’m surprised you aren't going to leave me here to rot. Shadow Weaver got what she wanted.” The first words out of Catra's mouth come as a rasp, her dehydrated throat struggling to form them. She looks in the pink haired girl's eyes for anything besides rage and to her surprise, finds a hint of despair.

“She was going to let you starve.” Glimmer says more dejectedly than she seems to intend. “But I can't help myself. I- I want answers.”

Catra raises an eyebrow as Glimmer unlocks the chains holding her to the wall so she can eat. She quickly begins wolfing down the nutrition bars despite their awful taste. “Answers to what?” She says through a mouthful of food, earning a brief snicker from Glimmer.

“Some princess you are.” The pink haired girl jabs. “You said you knew me, that you're my sister, but we look nothing alike. If my- if our parents are truly alive, then I need you to prove it.”

Catra swallows. “You wouldn't believe me if I tried, Sparkles.” The use of the nickname seems to get under Glimmer's skin, earning Catra a scoff from the pink-haired Force Captain.

“You're right. This is stupid. I don't even know why I came down here.” The girl's demeanor shifts, closes off right before Catra's eyes. The magicat quickly panics, trying to search for some way to do damage control.

“If you want answers you'll need to ask Shadow Weaver. She's who started this whole thing by kidnapping you.” Catra sighs as she takes the last bite of her disgusting-yet-satisfying meal. She watches Glimmer mull it over, seeming to go through a range of emotions before finding Catra's gaze.

“You're wrong. I'm going to go to Shadow Weaver and prove you're wrong.” Glimmer's resolve earns a sly grin from Catra. The Force Captain turns to leave, looking back at the princess from over her shoulder. “And when I do, I'm going to come back down here and make you pay, just like she did.” The words are cold and calculating, reminding Catra all too much of the witch in tone. The magicat watches as she leaves, breathing a sigh of relief that at least she can move around her cell now.

[---]

“Force Captain, to what do I owe the pleasure?” Shadow Weaver paints her voice with hints of faux sweetness to hide how irritated she is at the girl’s intrusion. She and her star pupil have been at increasing odds recently, with Glimmer's approach to the war taking on a much more ruthless element to Shadow Weaver's calculating strategies. The witch notices an angry resolve in Glimmer's eyes, one that she doesn't see often directed at her.

“Tell me she's lying. Tell me my parents are dead and you found me alone in the Crimson Wastes, like you always said.” Glimmer's brow furrows with rage. An unfamiliar feeling creeps up Shadow Weaver's spine: unease. The girl angrily steps toward her in the Black Garnet chamber, black electricity arcing between her fingertips as Shadow Weaver had taught her so many moons ago. The air around them seems to chill with every step Glimmer takes around the large red runestone.

“Glimmer, it was-”

“Bullshit!” Glimmer zaps Shadow Weaver with a powerful bolt of lightning. The witch smells smoke, realizing as she crumples to a knee that her skin itself is smouldering from the jolt. She groans

and looks up at her charge, the girl in question glaring down at her. “You lied to me! You-” Her voice wavers. “You kidnapped me, used me to live out some fucked up fantasy of power!” Glimmer growls, a maniacal twitch finding her eye. “No more.”

Shadow Weaver scoffs. “If I'd known what Adam could do, who he'd become, I'd never have even bothered with you in the first place. You're useless to me compared to his abilities.” She watches the words stab daggers into Glimmer's heart. The girl's expression twists into one of betrayal as she swings a fist at Shadow Weaver's face.

The blow lands squarely against Shadow Weaver's jaw. She cries out as she's pushed backwards, Glimmer looming over her menacingly. “I will destroy you, and you'll only have yourself to blame for raising a monster like me.” She says bitterly. The Force Captain stomps out of the room without another word.

The witch struggles to her feet, attempting to draw on power from the Black Garnet for support. It doesn't come. Her connection to the runestone has been severed, the tether keeping her alive torn apart by Glimmer's resolve. She finds herself beheld to another emotion: fear. The magicat girl gave her the location of Mystacor. If she wants to survive, she-

An alarm blares. “***RESISTANCE FIGHTERS HAVE BREACHED THE BUILDING. REPEAT: RESISTANCE FIGHTERS HAVE BREACHED THE BUILDING. ALL HANDS TO BATTLE STATIONS.***”

Shadow Weaver curses under her breath. They've come for the princess. The only option here is for her to fight like hell. She stands, staring at the Black Garnet with reverence. “Oh, powerful Black Garnet. Hear me: allow me to draw on your strength a final time, so I may protect what protects you.” The runestone sparks to life, arcing out and empowering Shadow Weaver with powerful magic. She turns, and steps out of the chamber to meet the Horde’s foes.

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The large lizard-like man attacked Mermista out of nowhere. They'd been riding the elevator that lifts them towards the top of the prison wing when he had leaped on her from the central tower and nearly knocked Entrapta from the elevator. Now the engineer holds on for dear life as the lift speeds out of control.

“Entrapta!” Mermista calls from the other side of the platform. The lizard guy is on the backstep, meeting the water princesses staff with his claws. “The operator in the tower! He's trying to knock us off!” The engineer looks to see a blonde haired boy nervously pounding away at buttons in the control room. She nods at Mermista and stands shakily, trying to keep her balance as the elevator speeds up and slows down.

She steps towards the tower, her balance precarious as the platform moves upward. A feeling in her gut urges her forward and reminds her they don't have time for any of this. After a few more cautious steps, she breaks into a run, ignoring the feeling of her wobbly balance as she approaches the control tower.

When she reaches the glass that separates her and the blonde kid, she hesitates. Entrapta looks around frantically for a door before she changes her mind. She clenches her hair tendrils into fists and begins to slam them into the glass, much to the kid's horror. A few pounding swings later and it gives way with a resounding *crash.* The boy leaps back towards the entryway to the room in visible shock.

“Turn it off.” Entrapta says, the growl in her voice seeming alien to her. The boy hesitates, not moving a single inch as he stands firm on the other side of the room. “I said, TURN IT OFF!” Entrapta yells, glaring at the blonde in fierce rage. He nods and runs over to the computer interface. A few taps later and the entire platform stops moving close to the top.

The pair are suddenly joined in the room by Mermista and the lizard soldier. The two tumble inside, the water princess swinging

frantically with her staff in an attempt to get him off of her. Entrapta swings her tendrils at him, knocking him aside just long enough to help Mermista to her feet. The pair find themselves on opposite sides of the room to the two Horde cadets, a tense standoff forming around them.

Entrapta chuckles coldly. “So,” She eyes Mermista. “Ready to rumble?”

The blonde swung first, surprising Entrapta with a sharp left hook that she barely dodged. The duo wanted her on the back foot, clearly more intimidated by her than Mermista. Good, she thinks, maybe she can give the water princess an opening. She lunges towards the lizard man first, but is surprised when he anticipates it. The cadet grabs one of her pigtails and pulls, a sharp cry of pain bursting from Entrapta’s mouth. Mermista quickly knocks him off balance with her staff, but doesn’t see the blonde approaching from behind in all the commotion.

She doesn't get very much time to react, because a figure suddenly stands in the window she'd broken not moments before. In each hand are the Blades of Protection, seeming to vibrate in anticipation of a fight. Entrapta takes in the rest of Catra's appearance for a moment. She looks hungry and weak, yet filled with adrenaline. The engineer watches her commander first swing the sword at the lizard boy (She thinks the blonde called him Rogelio?) and almost loses her balance instantly. Catra laughs it off, tossing the swords aside and unsheathing those makeshift claws Entrapta wants to study so badly.

Rogelio yelps in surprise, clutching his arm in pain at Catra's first swipe. Mermista goes in for the kill on her second, using the commotion to knock the other cadet off his feet. Entrapta suddenly feels a little worthless, the sight of her friends taking down the pair without her filling her with a sense of dread she'd forgotten just moments ago. She can't help but wonder where the burst of confidence had come from, but she doesn't have time to dwell as the pair quickly finish their takedown.

“How'd you get out?” Entrapta says, breathing a sigh of relief as she climbs to her feet. “We thought you were pretty heavily guarded.”

“You’d think, but really they kind of just left me tied to a wall most of the time.” Catra heaves a heavy sigh. “Glimmer let me out after Shadow Weaver finally told her the truth about us. She looked pissed.”

“Won't that just get them both in trouble?” Mermista raises an eyebrow.

“Dunno, but I'm not going to squander the chance. Where's the rest of the group?”

“They came in through the main entrance as a diversion. By my calculations they should have been here minutes ago. Something must have held them up.” Entrapta eyes the broken glass of the control tower nervously, watching as a dark shadow seems to creep up through it into the room where the trio stands. She sees Catra’s stand on end.

“We have to go. Now.” Catra says, practically growling under her breath. The shadows form together into the figure of a woman who practically *breathes* evil. She rises from the darkness lurking at the three’s feet, cackling evilly as she looks at Catra.

“Now, now. How did you get out, little mongrel?” The witch cackles. Catra and Entrapta pick a sword up each, backing away slowly. They meet eyes, a silent agreement to what they needed to do coming between them.

“Why don't you ask your little protegé, Weaver?” Catra snarls. The woman seems taken aback for a moment that Entrapta takes advantage of. With a swift punch to the side, she plays dirty and knocks Shadow Weaver off balance, giving her enough time to run towards the window.

“Come on!” Entrapta yells, gesturing at her companions to take each of her hands. They leap from the tower, the engineer holding

onto a broken cable with her hair to slow their descent. When they reach the bottom, she steals an upward glance to see the control tower being consumed with dark shadows. Not another second is spent on it, though, as the group quickly runs.

[---]

The sheer number of guards at the prison entrance had overwhelmed Adam's group quickly. Each attack he parries from one soldier gives another an opening. The three of them are quickly becoming overwhelmed as they fight against insane odds. That's why, when the doors to the prison burst open, he's relieved to see that Entrapta and Mermista have fulfilled their side of the mission.

“We have to get out of here! She's coming!” Catra yells, swiping her makeshift claws at a few of the guards. Entrapta tosses Adam his swords amidst the commotion, and he immediately finds himself relieved to be wielding them again.

“Who?!” Adam says, fighting off another two cadets.

“Shadow Weaver!” The name strikes a chord of fear in Adam. He knows how this will end if they face the witch. It's too late though, his blood runs cold as he spots the woman that lives in his worst nightmares gliding through the doorway. Her breathing is ragged and her side bleeding.

“Adam.” She speaks in that sing-songy voice. “So nice to see you again.”

Adam glares. “Can't say the same for you, Shadow Weaver.”

“Always so ungrateful. I gave you everything I had and you just threw it all away.”

“You gave me nothing.” Adam growls.

“*You* are nothing without those precious swords, boy.” She spits. “Your little resistance can only do so much to stop me. When I gut

you from head to toe, who will save you? The flower prince?” Adam sees Perfuma wince at the use of the title for her. He can't help but feel Shadow Weaver might be right, that he'd be nothing without She-Ra. He furrows his brow angrily, a hint of rage at the woman’s misgendering of Perfuma lit just beneath his gaze.

“Maybe I am nothing. But if you kill me you'll never harvest the magic in them.” The woman falters slightly in surprise. Adam chuckles, remembering all his time in the Fright Zone watching her teach Glimmer. The Force Captain had revealed that little secret to him after one particularly heated lesson. “Cause that's what you do, isn't it? You’re no powerful sorcerer, you're just a parasite who leeches off sources of magic for her own gain. At least the swords chose me, not even the Black Garnet would choose you.”

Shadow Weaver regains her composure with a cackle. “Such uncharacteristic confidence! You won't be spitting such defiance once you've watched me torture that little mongrel girlfriend of yours. It will be lovely to force her to watch her friends die for real this time.”

Adam tenses up at the insinuation. He glares, stepping forward with the tip of his right sword pointed at the woman. “What's your game, Weaver?”

“My game, you insolent brat, is this-” She fires out a bolt of electricity that arcs through Adam's body, firing his nerves and forcing him to tense up as he crumples to the ground. Pain shoots through his body for what feels like hours before coming to a sudden halt. Adam hears the witch cry out, and when he looks up, Catra has jumped onto Shadow Weaver’s back and begun to scratch at her with her makeshift claws. Adam climbs to his feet and uses the opportunity to raise his sword high and transform.

Shadow Weaver growls at She-Ra. “Go ahead, hide behind your precious She-Ra.” The witch shocks Catra this time, and She-Ra yells out in surprise. Her body moves on its own as she swings her right blade underhand into the witch's right arm. A sickening

crunch sounds before she sees Shadow Weaver crumple to her knees in agony, cradling the stump with her remaining hand. She feels a bit sick to her stomach, not intending to do so much damage.

Go! That voice from yesterday suddenly shouts in her mind. Whoever they are, they're right. The group needs to take the chance and get the hell out of here. She-Ra turns to the group and points towards the garages.

"We have to get out of here. There's a side exit that leads to the maintenance bays. If we use that we can escape." She commands, the words sounding almost foreign in her mouth. She doesn't feel like herself, as if someone else is piloting the warrior princess.

Catra eyes her in shock, looking between Shadow Weaver and the warrior princess in horror. She shakes her head, furrowing her brow. "Right. Let's get the fuck out of here." She-Ra leads the charge, heading straight for the maintenance tunnel. Once they're through the door, they see the one leading outside is shut tight.

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A *thunk* signifies that the door behind them has just locked them inside, sending a pang of fear into Mermista's guts. She looks around for another way out as the group approaches the other door, but all there is inside the tunnel is an access panel that seems to control the lights and doors.

"Shit!" Entrapta is the first to speak, approaching the panel. She eyes the wiring inside hesitantly, something that immediately makes Mermista nervous. After a moment of messing around with it, she hums in understanding, muttering a quiet "Aha!" A pang of relief briefly washes over the water princess as the engineer begins to work.

"Warning, maintenance tunnel purge begins in T-minus thirty seconds and counting. Twenty-nine, twenty-eight, twenty-seven…"

A loud voice overhead begins to count down, ominously signaling that everything in the tunnel will be purged. With what? Mermista isn't sure she's willing to find out.

"Entrapta-" Mermista starts.

"I know. I know. I'm working as quickly as I can!" She says as the voice's counting reaches fifteen. "This Horde wiring is all kinds of backwards!" The voice reaches ten, the group anxiously waiting for Entrapta to finish her work when she suddenly cries out in success. The exit door *whooshes* open, and without hesitation the group rushes towards it. Upon crossing the threshold, Mermista turns to see the engineer running towards them. What she doesn't see is the cable wrapping itself around her leg.

"Fuck!" Entrapta screams as she tumbles to the ground. "Wait!" The doors don't comply with her command, shutting automatically as Mermista and Catra try to run back inside. Neither of them make it before it closes completely.

"No! No! No!" Mermista pounds her fists on the door, horrified. Her stomach leaps into her throat, and she continues to scream and pound on the door. There's no sound from the other side of the thick, blast-proof door. After a moment of angry, desperate pounding, Perfuma grabs her by the arm and pulls. "No! No! Perfuma! I can't! She's still in there!"

"She's gone, 'Mista." Perfuma says somberly, her tone so quiet it's barely a whisper. Mermista crumples to the ground, her hands covering her face as she begins to heave a visceral sob that feels as though it comes from the darkest parts of her guts. She let Entrapta down. How could she?!

Then, she remembers what Entrapta said about Adam when they were in the sewer, and her anguish suddenly turns to violent rage. Mermista walks over to the blonde and punches him as hard as she can in the jaw. The boy stumbles back, rubbing where the blow had landed with an angry glare in his eye. "Mermista, what the fuck?!"

“That was for her, you fucking asshole. She didn’t want to come on this stupid mission and you fucking forced her!” Mermista throws a second punch that Adam barely avoids. “She told me about your little episode in Dryl too! She thought you hated her!” Perfuma holds the water princess back to keep her from attacking Adam a third time. Her heart pounds in her chest, her breathing ragged. She yanks herself free from her girlfriend’s grip. “Let’s just get out of here.”

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“We are gathered here today, to mourn the loss of a member of our budding Resistance whom we only just began to know.” Angella begins. The mood inside the throne room is somber, no one daring to make a sound as if to disturb the dead. Much of the trip back from the Fright Zone had been held in silence, the rain pounding outside as they had approached. Angella had put the vigil together for the princess rather swiftly, the small funeral beginning only hours after their return.

Of course, there was no body to bury, not when they had to leave Entrapta behind in the Fright Zone. Mermista feels the bite of anger gnawing at her insides. Anger that they couldn’t do more. Anger at the Alliance for resigning itself to Entrapta’s death. How fucking dare they not even *try* to go back for the engineer’s body? A hand places itself in hers and Mermista looks down to see Perfuma’s in her own. She hadn’t realized she’d been breathing so heavily until now, but she takes a moment to ground herself in the other woman’s touch as Angella continues.

“On first impression, Entrapta was a genius engineer, who buried herself heavily in her work. As our associates in the Resistance came to know her, though, they realized that she was more than that. She was *human* above all else, having fears, doubts, and opinions like all of us. She set those aside for the greater good that day in the Fright Zone, so that our little band of fighters may rescue its commander. Not only that, but so she may help rescue a friend. It would be a disservice to her memory to not continue

our work, not when she’s made the ultimate sacrifice for it. Please join me in a moment of silence for our fallen sister.”

As the moment of silence begins, anguish begins to grip at Mermista’s core. Her thoughts return to the conversation with Entrapta that she will never have. That she promised they’d finish. She doesn’t realize tears are streaming down her face until Perfuma puts an arm around her shoulder and squeezes. How will she ever live with what she’s done? Her anguish quickly turns to panic as the room begins to close in, as the walls seem to grow smaller and smaller, her vision twisting and turning while her heart begins to race violently. She has to get out of here. She *needs* to get out of here. She stands, not even caring that the room has turned its gaze on her as she begins to walk, no, *run* from the funeral.

“Mermista!” She hears someone call, but doesn’t bother to turn around to look.

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Entrapta crawls through the vents, her body feeling weak as she searches for some kind of cache of food. It's been nearly a week she's been hiding in the ducting system of the Fright Zone, patiently waiting for the Resistance to come back for her, and in that time she's only survived by quietly stealing ration bars from some of the cadet’s personal storage lockers. She needs to find wherever they make them fast. As she turns a corner, a deep, booming voice calls out from below the duct she's in. It's commanding with an almost terrifying gravitas. She stops for a moment to listen to the conversation below.

“Force Captain Scorpia. Please brief me on exactly what occurred between Force Captain Glimmer and Force Commander Shadow Weaver at approximately 1100 hours yesterday.”

A second voice, one of the two Force Captains that ambushed her back home, comes in response. “Well, Lord Hordak, the two came to a bit of a disagreement over Shadow Weaver's intentions. You

see, Glimmer found out she was torturing the prisoner for the location of Mystacor.” At this, the man called Hordak seems to heave a heavy sigh.

“What did she intend to do with this knowledge, Force Captain?” He says calmly, intently listening to Force Captain Scorpia's explanation.

“She planned to absorb the source of its power. Just like how the Fright Zone has the Black Garnet, Mystacor is held in the sky by a runestone as well sir. That's my understanding at least.” *Runestones?* Entrapta finds herself utterly intrigued. There is a runestone here in the Fright Zone? She makes a mental note to find this ‘Black Garnet’ and study it.

“And what did Shadow Weaver intend to do once she absorbed the runestone?”

“She planned to overthrow you.” A harsh set of footsteps march in, carrying the voice Entrapta recognizes to be the pink-haired girl at Dryl. “She was planning to take control of the Fright Zone.”

“Insubordination. And to allow herself to be wounded by the Resistance none the less.” Hordak muses, seemingly accepting this explanation. “No matter. Force Captain Glimmer, at attention.” Scorpia watches as Glimmer salutes, standing up straight. “I hereby promote you to the rank of Force Commander of the Horde. Please see to it that the traitor is put in a cell until a decision has come as to her punishment.”

“Thank you, sir.” Glimmer says, a slight hint of pride in her voice. “I believe we may have a perfect opportunity for attack despite losing our leverage. You see, the Resistance will believe we are on the backfoot.”

“Then perhaps it would be an ample time to crash their precious ball they hold every year. The Kingdom of Snows is a valuable location to hold, and we would be much more powerful than the Resistance with it in our clutches.” He turns to Glimmer. “Your first

assignment as Commander is to infiltrate their Princess Prom and divert enough attention to launch a full scale assault on the Northern Reach. Scorched earth, Commander.”

Entrapta hears footsteps as they shuffle out of the room. Fascinating, that the Fright Zone draws much of its power from a source it so heavily argues against. She quickly shuffles through the vents, eager to find the runestone held here and research it. If she can reverse engineer how the Black Garnet works, perhaps she can do so with others as well. She's never had a real runestone to work with before.

Before long, she hears a powerful hum below her, having taken the paths she memorized thus far in the vents forward to where the Fright Zone draws power from. It's a wonder she found it before the food supply, honestly, but whoever designed this place probably doesn't prioritize feeding its soldiers. Through the slats in the vent cover she can see an enormous gemstone, glowing and crackling beautifully in the dimly lit room. What Entrapta can see attached to it are cables that seem to harness its electrical output.

The excitement is almost too much to bear as she quietly opens the vent and drops down to the floor below, softening her impact with her pigtails. She looks up in awe at the runestone, even more majestic than she could ever imagine as it floats gently above the base placed beneath it. She removes her datapad from her overalls, taking the small handheld scanner from it and beginning to run a scan.

Chapter 9

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter VIII: Something Inside This Heart Has Died

“Shadow Weaver.” Hordak begins, approaching the barrier of her cell. “Tell me, was a runestone worth betraying me for?” He watches the woman walk towards him, eyeing him silently for a moment. She's not been in here long, a few days at maximum, but she doesn't look good. They'd managed to stop the bleeding after the boy cut off her hand, but that had been the extent of their tending to her injury.

“I did what I had to do, Lord Hordak.” She starts. “Surely, you of all people understand that the ends justify the means.”

This irritates the Horde leader. “Me, of all people, Weaver? I was informed of your little scheme to acquire its power and usurp me. There will be no new Horde leader yet.” He growls. “Especially not one who betrays its very values. You were told to acquire tactical information, not the location of yet another useless runestone! Magic is useless in the face of progress!” He sighs. “Do not forget what happened last time you went hunting for such a thing.” He turns away from her in disgust. “This insubordination will be your undoing. I hereby strip you of your title as Force Commander.”

“Wait. No. Lord Hordak-” Shadow Weaver pleads. Hordak revels a little in how desperate she already is. Perhaps this punishment does suit her crimes after all. “Who will be my replacement? Who will handle all of my duties? You can't leave me here, Hordak! I'm too valuable!” She is a sickening sight for Hordak to witness: a once terrifying woman reduced to a husk at the thought of losing even a shred of power.

“The girl. You have trained Glimmer well. She has proven a suitable replacement.” Hordak doesn't care to listen to the pleas of the woman any longer as he steps away from the cell.

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A commotion has started in the main area of the prison wing, but Catra will be damned if she can see what's happening. It sounds like a fight has broken out, with all the pounding and sounds of broken glass. She doesn't have time to linger on it, as not long after, the barrier opens once again as Glimmer comes back through.

She looks extremely conflicted, which means that she did exactly what Catra told her she should. The girl walks over to her, looking up at the taller woman with eyes that are almost misty. Catra watches as she looks around the room, before doing something unthinkable. The Force Captain steps to the side of the door. “Just go. Get out of here.”

“Why?” Catra can't help but ask. Glimmer glares at her angrily.

“Just fucking get out of here! I'm letting you go! Your friends are already here! They'll be here any moment to save you anyway!”

Catra eyes Glimmer suspiciously as she starts for the door. She reaches the edge of the cell before looking back at her captor. “You can always come with me.”

Glimmer cackles coldly. “No, I can't. Get out of here before Shadow Weaver sees us.” Catra nods in understanding. Glimmer isn't doing this for anyone but herself, to spite the witch that's brought both of them too much pain to bear. “Wait-” The pink haired girl says as Catra begins to walk away. “You'll need these.” The magicat is delighted to see that Glimmer has brought her their weapons. She slides her claws back on, having felt naked without them for so long, and takes a sword in each hand.

“Glimmer.” She says, earning a glare from the Force Captain. “Thank you.”

The cadet clenches her fist and lets out a deep, defeated sigh. "One more thing. What- what information did Shadow Weaver torture you for?"

Catra blinks in surprise. It's a forward question, if not a little blunt and insensitive. As long as she's vague, it should be fine. "The location of Mystacor."

Glimmer's face twists into pure rage. "She fucking wasted all this time on that?!" The girl groans and waves her hand at Catra. "Just get out of here before I change my mind."

A loud crash signals its time for the magicat to go, and she swiftly runs out of the cell and into the main atrium. Above her sits the moving control tower, a billowing plume of smoke rising above it. Further sounds of a struggle ring out and Catra's magicat hearing can distinctly pick out the voices but not their words: Mermista and Entrapta. She has to help them. Without hesitation she climbs the lengthy staircase towards the frozen tower, adrenaline not letting her slow down.

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Catra's heart beats a thousand times per second as she wakes. Soft, morning sunlight streams in through her windows. She's home, she's safe, but she can't help but wonder when everything will melt away back to that cell. She has to fight the urge to scream, to kick everything apart. The sound of Entrapta's voice haunts her to her core, the way she had run to join the rest of the group lingering in her mind like a gruesome reminder of Catra's failures. The magicat stands, shaking off the memory as she gets ready for the day ahead.

She opens the door to her wardrobe, pulling out a black suit jacket and purple dress shirt, with an accompanying pair of dress pants. This would be a somber princess prom coming on the heels of Entrapta's death, she thinks, but Frosta had insisted it still be held. She slides on the dress shirt, buttoning it up neatly over the dress pants. She smooths it all out, ensuring it's properly fitted

before she slides on the jacket. Though it does still fit well, she wonders if she's gained a bit of muscle, as the shirt and jacket seem to show a slightly more toned figure than she remembers. She reaches back and ties her hair into a neat ponytail, save for some stray strands of hair framing her face. She looks good, she thinks. At least, she hopes she does.

With that, she goes to find Adam. She hasn't seen much of him since the funeral. He'd been pretty distraught himself, especially after Mermista had torn into him in those final moments before they marched home. He hasn't said a peep to her, though, and she wonders what having friends who actually talk about their feelings is like. After a moment of walking she comes to his room, knocking firmly four times on the door to no response.

"Adam! Are you awake? We need to get going soon. It's a pretty long boat ride to the Kingdom of Snows." She hears nothing, concerningly so. "Adam? I'm coming in, you better be decent!" When she opens the door she sees those piercing red eyes staring into the mirror beside his wardrobe. So strange, she thinks, that of all the changes from the chip to linger, that his eye color has remained. She can't help but think it suits him, though. "Adam?"

He jumps, looking over at her like he's seen a ghost. "What? Where am I?"

"You're in your bedroom." Catra says, tilting her head. She steps towards him slowly. "Are you ok?"

"I- I don't know. I keep looking at myself and- and not recognizing who I am. Like someone else should be staring back at me." He waves a hand dismissively, a mirthless chuckle escaping him. "It's probably nothing. What do you think?" He's in a maroon dress shirt tucked into a pair of black pants not unlike her own and layered beneath a matching vest. His hair is combed and tucked behind his ears. He looks nice, Catra thinks, but he doesn't seem particularly satisfied, as he keeps readjusting and straightening the shirt.

“Hey. You ok?” Catra says softly, watching him uncomfortably adjust and readjust his clothes. He waves a hand, making a dismissive sound as he fiddles with it. Eventually, he groans, sitting down on the bed beside her and placing his face in his hands.

“I just feel like we could have done more. She told me she didn't want to come. She was afraid, I set that precedent by not trusting her.” He scoffs. “And even then I didn't realize I'd hurt her so badly until it was too late.”

“Why couldn't you trust her?” Catra remembers how Adam looked at Entrapta in Dryl, that sense of unease he projected.

“I- Do you remember when I found the Crystal Castle?” Crimson eyes meet Catra's own. The princess nods affirmatively. “The First Ones had this painting on the wall. The She-Ra versus a thousand robots and at the center of it all was Entrapta, flanked by Scorpia and Glimmer. They could see the *future,* Catra.”

“They couldn't though.” Catra says thoughtfully, earning a raised eyebrow from the blonde. “If they could, they'd have known Entrapta would die. Unless it's a different person, it can't be correct.”

“I guess you're right. But-” He hesitates. “I can't help but wonder if I let it happen because I was afraid.”

“Yeah. Goodie two-shoes blondie is gonna deliberately send someone to their death. I doubt it.” Catra rolls her eyes and nudges his arm. “Entrapta made her choice, even if you had to convince her. You should have seen the way she looked, fighting in that prison. She was exhilarated. She made sure her sacrifice counted.” Catra says. The blonde’s breathing slows as he seems to accept this answer. She pats him on the back. “Let's get going. Princess Prom's going to be a good distraction for all of us.”

Adam nods, standing again and fixing his clothes one more time. Before long they're on the boat to the Northern Reach, a long day

sitting ahead of them.

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Entrapta's readings from the Black Garnet are off the charts. If she were to obtain even a piece of it for the Alliance they'd have an unthinkable source of power for her robots! She can't wait for them to come back for her so she can share all the data she's gathered. This could be a plethora of developments for the Resistance! Unfortunately for Entrapta, she doesn't hear that the door has opened until it slams shut behind her, causing her to jump three feet in the air.

“What are you doing in here?!” Glimmer's angry tone comes as she marches over to her. As she approaches, Entrapta sees that the girl seems to recognize her, her gaze growing even more fiery. “How did you get in here? Who sent you?!” Entrapta attempts to jump back up into the vent, but is stopped by a quick and sharp electrical shock from the pink haired Horde commander.

“I was just studying it and I'll be on my way!” Entrapta says, struggling to find her senses after the zap. Glimmer eyes her suspiciously, unhitching a small walkie-talkie from her belt.

“Scorpia, we have an intruder in the Garnet chamber. Get down here ASAP and bring some rope.” Entrapta tries to move, to get away, to do anything, but Glimmer is standing on her hair and every sudden jerk is painful. She tries to wrap a pigtail around the girl's leg, but doesn't get the chance to knock her off her feet when Scorpia appears.

“Grab her.” Glimmer says, pulling Entrapta up by the arm and holding her hands behind her back. “Make sure to get the hair too, it's basically like extra limbs.”

Before long they're marching her to a small storage room nearby that seems to double as an interrogation room. They use clasps bolted into the wall to hold her against it, using a tighter pair to

hold down her hair. After the pair is done restraining her, Entrapta comes face to face with her captors.

“Answer my question from before, nerd princess.” The nickname Glimmer uses sends a bite of irritation through Entrapta's body. She hates being called that. “Why are you here? Where's the rest of the Resistance?”

Entrapta hesitates, unsure whether the truth is the best path forward here. She weighs her options for a moment: if she lies and says she came alone, she's protecting everyone in the Alliance. But then again, they're safe back in Bright Moon anyway. If she reveals why she's here still, they may go easy on her.

“I got trapped in the maintenance shaft when it purged. Only barely got into the vents before the whole thing was on fire. They had no time during the rescue to save me.” It's the truth, even if it stings. She watches Glimmer scan her face as if trying to detect a lie before bursting into laughter.

“You're serious?! The Alliance just left you here to die?!” She notices Entrapta's downtrodden look and suddenly her expression grows grim. “You- you're serious.”

“I've been waiting for them to come back for me. They will eventually, I don't doubt it.” Truthfully Entrapta *did* doubt it, because if she were them she'd not bother either. What was she but dead weight to the rest of them? Sure she had had a few moments here and there but ultimately she's probably going to get somebody hurt or worse. Glimmer seems to eye Scorpia for a moment before looking back at the purple haired princess.

“Entrapta, right?” She says evenly. Entrapta nods. “Entrapta. They're- they're not coming back for you. You've been here, what, a week and a half? We had Catra for three days before they stormed in. Rescue isn't coming.”

Entrapta's heart feels like it's stopped beating in her chest. That- that was the truth wasn't it? It couldn't be, but- they'd been so

quick to go for Catra after everything, and yet here she was with no end in sight. Adam's face flashes in her mind, the cautious way he approached her in the courtyard, the outburst in Dryl, they were all the truth of how the Resistance must see her. That bite of irritation carves a hole a thousand miles deep in her chest. This is what happens when she gives other people a chance, this is what happens when she allows herself to believe things can get better. She never should have left Dryl.

Angry tears burst forward from her, as she finds Glimmer's gaze once more. "Just let me go home. I don't care about any of this anymore. I won't bother with this stupid war ever again."

"You should care. They manipulated you. Used you. And then, when you gave them your trust, they abandoned you. Why should you give up and go home now when you have a perfect chance to exact some lasting damage for everything they've done?" Glimmer smirks. "You could study the Black Garnet all you want, and maybe more. Shadow Weaver got the location of a second runestone, after all. Help us, and it's yours."

Entrapta mulls it over for a moment. The thought of betraying the Alliance pains her, but every time she feels bad about it she sees Adam's angry face in her mind. Rage streaks across her heart and suddenly she realizes what she's wanted so badly for so long: revenge. A feeling buried deep below the surface bursts forward like a volcanic eruption. She wants to make Adam pay for not trusting her. She wants to hurt the Resistance for not coming back. No, not wants, *needs*. She looks back up at Glimmer with a vengeful and maniacal look crossed over her face.

"I'll do it."

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"I call it Operation Icefall." Entrapta says as she looks between her new comrades. She'd been hard at work, not getting nearly enough sleep as she designed a weapons system that would take full advantage of the vulnerability of the Kingdom of Snows during

the Princess Prom event. “The Northern Reach is a perfect strategic vantage point, when you think about it. Not only are its waters connected in some way to many of the other kingdoms on Etheria, my own included, but the environment provides a perfect natural barrier to full-scale assault.”

“Then why are we planning to do just that?” Glimmer tilts her head, a strange bemusement crossing her face.

“The only thing you’ll be doing is distracting the Alliance at Princess Prom itself. Keep them on edge, use Scorpia’s princess status as leverage to be there and don’t do anything until you get the signal. Once you have it-” Entrapta chuckles. “Well, rain hell down. The robots your boss designs- I’ve repurposed serve as foot soldiers for the harsh conditions of the Northern Reach, but they’re not perfect. A large, heavily armored ground team is going to take Castle Evernight, and if you keep the Resistance busy inside, they won’t be able to split their resources between a two-pronged attack.”

“A two pronged attack?”

Entrapta grins. “Precisely. Not long after the robots start attacking, the Horde fleet will begin a second assault from the waters just past the castle. Bright Moon doesn't have an army, and they won't be able to split their resources between the bots, navy, and you.”

“So basically, make it seem like we're just there to cause trouble and wait until the ground assault begins to really do any damage.” Scorpia says with a surprising amount of tact. Glimmer raises an eyebrow at her and the woman puts her pincers up in defense. “Hey now, I can strategize once in a while!” The white haired woman laughs.

“Precisely, Force Captain.” Entrapta says. “We have an opportunity to strike a major, if not lethal, blow to the Alliance should this work. And if it doesn't, we'll still walk away having done some major damage and capturing a key strategic point for our cause.”

The engineer grins, her heart twisting with a dark justice at the thought of dealing a blow to Adam's precious Resistance.

“Then what next, Force Engineer Entrapta?” Glimmer's smile is sharp, signaling an eagerness for the coming battle.

“I'll need some schematics. Get me everything you have on the current generation of bots so I can modify them and-” Entrapta searches her mind for a moment, remembering the cliff will be a problem for the boats. “Get me the designs for your missiles.”

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The festivities begin in less than an hour, and for some reason Adam is way too nervous about this. He's standing by the food table in the massive ballroom by himself, tapping his foot anxiously as he watches the Princesses and their guests trickle in one by one. He doesn't realize he's staring until Bow snaps him out of it by tapping his shoulder.

“Hey.” Bow says, smiling. “How are you holding up?”

Adam chuckles. “I've seen better days. Feels like I haven't even had enough time to even process what happened in the Fright Zone.” The blonde shakes his head and stares into the glass of punch in his hand. “Still, can't help but feel like a lot of this is my fault to begin with.”

Bow sighs. “I'm sorry about what I said before. Perfuma was right, you couldn't have known and you were just doing what you thought was right.” Speaking of Perfuma, the pair eye her and Mermista holding hands as they enter the ballroom. The water princess herself looks pained, like she's going through an intense whirlwind of emotions. Adam can't say he blames her.

“Who'd you decide to come with?” Adam asks, looking back at Bow. The boy flushes red and looks away.

“Nobody. I was going to ask Perfuma but-” Bow chuckles nervously. “Well, I don't think Mermista would like that very

much.” Adam nods, seeing a familiar form approach him from the side.

Catra huffs, tapping her foot nervously. “I don't think we're going to convince Frosta to join the alliance any time soon.”

“Why not?” Adam says, raising an eyebrow. Before Catra gets to answer, the ballroom quiets, and the ice princess steps into the center of the room.

“My kingdom has been fighting this war for longer than I have been alive. Our battle has been fierce since the beginning, but we needed no arbitrary Alliance to do our duty..” Frosta begins. Adam can't help but wonder if this girl is fifteen or fifty, seeming tired beyond her years. “And after today, I hope our dear friends will see that we remain strong without them. The Horde wants us to be afraid, so defy them by celebrating who we are!” She raises a glass. “To Etheria!” The crowd toasts with her before dispersing to all parts of the ballroom.

Adam watches lonelily as Catra and Bow begin to mingle with the prom-goers. He's not a people person, he's learned, feeling most of the time that he can't live up to their standards. It's just safer for him to stay on his own.

“Hey.” A woman's voice says beside him. He looks over to see a blonde who could very well be his sister standing beside him. “What's up with you?” Her eyes are a piercing red, same as Adam's now. She stares intensely out at the crowd, her expression not hinting at any particular emotion.

Adam scoffs. “Not really one for parties.”

She chuckles softly. “Yeah, me neither. Guess we have that in common.” Adam follows her gaze, seeing that she's watching Catra enthusiastically converse with a tall reptilian. “But they're enjoying it. Why can't you?”

“What if I can't protect them?” Adam finds himself muttering. Why is he saying all this to a stranger? “What if I fail them like I failed

Entrapta?”

The blonde woman smiles sadly. “Sometimes you just gotta trust that they can protect themselves.” Adam nods, looking back at Catra. He wants to be around her, to enjoy his time with her, but he finds that he just feels *wrong*.

“Adam!” Bow's voice approaches. “Who're you talking to?”

“Oh, just-” When Adam turns back to the woman, she's gone. He shakes his head. “N- no one. How's the party?”

“They're gonna be starting dances soon. You look really worn out. Are you ok?” The archer grimaces.

“I'm fine. Just not in a party mood I guess.” At this, Bow nudges him in the shoulder.

“Come on, Adam! Relax a little. Have fun!” Bow's pleading face is hard to say no to, and before he knows it Adam is out in the ballroom talking to Catra and the tall reptilian.

“Oh darling, it's simply magnificent. I really should introduce you to Peekablue sometime.” The reptilian is dressed in a long, fancy dress that covers them to their neck. Its sleeves cover their arms but not their shoulders.

“Truly, I’d love to meet him.” Catra says with a grin. A pang of jealousy stabs at Adam's gut. He finds that the conversation is a bit out of his wheelhouse, and delegates himself to the sidelines. Eventually, the reptilian breaks away, leaving Adam and Catra together.

“You alright, blondie? You seem tense.” Catra says, giving Adam a small punch in the arm. She fakes a gasp. “Don't tell me you haven't danced with anyone yet!”

“Wait, Catra, I-” Adam doesn't get a chance to fight her on it as she yanks him by the arm to the dance floor. The band is playing an upbeat song, one that Catra quickly takes the lead in. Before

Adam knows it, she's spinning him around. He nearly falls when she dips him to the ground, but he manages to keep his balance as the song ends.

“You should have seen your face! I thought for sure you were gonna eat shit!” She laughs. Adam snickers along, trying his best to forget his woes for a bit and enjoy the party. For a moment, he almost thinks he might, until he sees a patch of familiar pink hair flash in the crowd and panics. The blonde begins to run, but Catra catches his arm as he does so. “Where are you going?! I wanna keep dancing, Adam!”

“I think the Horde is here!” Adam says frantically. Catra grimaces at him.

“Adam. You're being paranoid. Stop worrying for a bit and-” Catra groans when Adam pulls away, breaking into a sprint. He's seen that flash of pink twice now. He runs, wading through the crowd as much as he can until a pincer grabs him.

“Thought you might slip past us huh?” Scorpia grins.

“What are you doing here?” Adam breathes heavily, watching Scorpia's eyes dart away for a moment to an approaching person. Glimmer grins at the pair as she walks up, two drinks in hand.

“Well, well. Looks like we finally have our little reunion, best friend.” She says, the venom in her voice being enough to kill. “Thought you'd been avoiding me, especially after you beat the hell out of Lonnie and didn't even bother to say hello.” She chuckles coldly. “Though, I gotta say, I didn't expect you to cut off Shadow Weaver's arm. That was cool.”

“Glimmer. You know full well why I left the-”

“I don't care. I'm here to have fun. We were invited after all.” Glimmer waves her hand at Scorpia, who removes a piece of paper from her dress and unfolds it for Adam to see. She's right, the Kingdom of Snows had formally sent an invitation to Scorpia by virtue of technically being the Fright Zone's princess.

Adam pulls his hand free from Scorpia's grip. “Enjoy it while it lasts.” He mutters and storms away. He spots Frosta sitting in her throne and decides to warn her about the danger of having Scorpia and Glimmer here. The ice princess eyes him warily as he approaches, seeming fed up already with him for one day.

“You invited the Horde?!” Adam says, loudly enough that a few people turn to look at him. He didn’t mean to be that blunt, but he doesn't care at the moment. Frosta pinches the bridge of her nose and heaves a heavy sigh.

“Yes. I did. Scorpia is still a princess and there is still precedent.” She huffs. “Plus, everyone here can keep a much closer eye on them. They are Horde leadership, after all. I had planned that from the start.”

“I thought you didn't want to be a member of the Alliance?” Adam says. The girl scoffs at him, looking away and out over the ballroom.

“Just because I don't want to join the Princess Alliance doesn't mean I don't want to protect our home.” Frosta eyes him. “Those aren't exclusive. I have a duty just like you to keep this place safe. To keep our planet safe.” She looks up at Adam. “I doubt you know how long the Snows have been fighting them. It's longer than anyone else on the planet. I was born into this war, there was no precious stalemate like what Bright Moon got for a few years. They've attacked our kingdom non-stop for nearly thirty years.”

“Why avoid the Alliance then?” Adam says, watching the people in the ballroom dance.

“Honestly? Besides the fact that they failed us already, it's you I don't like. You're a bad omen, Adam. Everywhere you go destruction seems to follow. I mean, think about it. Exploding ships, robot armies, pollution machines, it all seems to center around She-Ra.” Frosta huffs. “I don't want to send any more of

my people to die, and the way I see it, if death lingers around you, at least they're safe.”

Frosta's words are like a gut punch. Adam hasn't had things put into perspective like that until now, and he can't help but agree with her about it ultimately. Who is he to force her to fight a war she doesn't want? One that she's been fighting longer than anybody and that she just wants to stay away from? If being She-Ra means dark forces focus on Adam and not the innocent, he thinks he can live with that.

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The bright lights and loud music are almost too much for Mermista. She's trying to stay calm, to seem cool in the face of everything, but it's getting out of control. Perfuma stepped away to chat with some of the other partygoers and it's giving the water princess too much time to overthink. She wanders for a bit before finding a quiet corner out of the way and leaning against the wall.

“Trouble in paradise, princess?” Sea Hawk quips as he leans beside her. Mermista can't help but groan. He's the last person she wants to see her like this.

“What do you want, Sea Hawk?” She mutters, barely looking at him. The sailor's gaze softens as he seems to take in her mood.

“Just to make sure my friend is ok.” He says. “You've seemed more distant than usual with me lately.”

He's right, unfortunately. Mermista had been keeping him at arms length after her relationship with Perfuma began, but since the Fright Zone, she'd been basically avoiding both of them. The water princess hadn't wanted to even think about those last moments with Entrapta, and had kept herself holed up in Salineas for days.

“I'm fine. Don't worry about me.* She lies, hoping that he will drop it.

“Mermista, you shouldn't blame yourself for it. Entrapta-”

“Don't you fucking dare say her name.” Mermista snaps finally, her heart racing. She blinks tears out of her eyes as she whirls towards Sea Hawk. “You didn't get to see it fucking happen. The scared way she looked as that cable wrapped around her leg. Every night for a week I saw that in my head when I closed my eyes! ***Every night for a week I wonder if I could have done something differently!”*** She screams. The people passing by have gone quiet, silently staring at her as she has her mental breakdown.

“Mermista-” Sea Hawk starts, looking visibly startled.

The water princess sinks to the ground, grasping at her head. Her hands clutch at her hair, pulling on it. She doesn't even bother to care as tears pour out of her, her lungs heaving a gut-wrenching sob. Perfuma approaches Mermista from the side. She doesn't even bother to acknowledge her.

“What the hell happened?” Perfuma asks frantically. She kneels down and wraps her arms around Mermista gently.

“I don't- we were just talking and she- she just snapped!” Sea Hawk’s voice shakes. “I didn't mean- I had no idea she was-”

“Sea Hawk. Shut up.” Perfuma growls. “You're going to make it worse at this rate.” Something about this sets Mermista off. Perfuma is acting like she's the water princess’s mother, which only serves to get on her nerves. Her anguish is quickly replaced by irritation as she glares up at her girlfriend.

“I’m *not* a child, ‘Fuma. Don't- don't fucking act like I am. I don't need to be coddled.” Mermista sees the flower princess quickly become dejected, a sight that stabs at her.

“We're just worried about you.” Perfuma says, her voice small. “You haven't been talking to us.”

“Maybe I don't *want* to. Maybe I saw some fucked up shit in the Fright Zone that I don't want to think about! Maybe-”

“You think you're the only one who's seen fucked up shit?!” Perfuma growls in a way that immediately disarms Mermista. “We all have. What you and Entrapta went through down there I can't even imagine, but you aren't the only one with demons! The Horde's taken a lot from *all* of us!”

Mermista scoffs, and like usual, she leaves. Walking to wherever is safest, wherever she can be alone without the prom patrol breathing down her neck. She feels bad for running away, but at this point it's the only thing she's good at. Running from her problems is how she best deals with them.

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Adam spots Glimmer dropping something into a trash can. He begins to march over to it, a pang of anger building in his stomach, but as he does a furry gloved hand grabs his sleeve. Seems like he's being pulled every which way today. He turns to Catra, who looks absolutely *livid* with him.

“What the fuck, man?” Catra growls. “You're freaking out! I just watched you sprint after Scorpia and Glimmer and then you go and tattle on them to Frosta? We *need* her in the Alliance, Adam! She's an important piece of the puzzle! You're making us look desperate!”

“Have you considered she doesn't want to be?” Adam grumbles back. “She wants to keep her people safe, and she doesn't see how she can if she joins us. Plus, she invited the Horde specifically so we could keep an eye on them. I'm keeping an eye on them.” He marches over and digs through the trash can only to find a note inside that is written in the pink haired girl's signature scrawl. It reads: ‘Hi Adam.’ Beside it is a crudely drawn picture of Glimmer's face sticking out her tongue.

He hears Catra let out a prickly laugh beside him. “Dude, they're messing with you.”

“I'm not going to let them get the jump on me again. Not like Dryl.” Adam says, looking over at the magicat irritably. “Go have fun, I'll be fine.” His words are put to the test when Scorpia taps Catra on the shoulder.

“Care to dance, wildcat?” She grins jovially. The sight sends a surge of frustration through the blonde. Who do Scorpia and Glimmer think they are? Catra would never dance with a member of the-

“Sure.” The magicat eyes Adam sadly before leading Scorpia away to the dance floor. Horror builds in his guts as he watches them begin to slow dance to the music. Catra’s slipping away from him, and he's letting her. Yet another example of his Grade A social skills.

“You're losing her, princess.” The woman from before, the blonde, seems to appear beside him. Her statement irritates him. Does she think he doesn't know that?

“Seems to be my specialty.” He mutters, glancing at her from the side.

The woman snickers and earns a glare from the boy. “You and me, both. Just hold on tight to her for me, yeah?” She smiles sadly, a weariness Adam hadn't seen earlier hiding beneath it. “Unfortunately, you've got a more pressing issue, it seems.” The woman points to a balcony nearby that overlooks the cliff face.

Adam rushes over to it and peers into the dark below. A dozen Horde ships are flooding into the lagoon. He spots from the corner of his eye a light that begins to approach from one of the boats and his heart nearly stops. “Everybody get down!” The blonde screams into the ballroom. The last thing he remembers is being thrown from the cliff as a deafening explosion surrounds him.

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Catra's ears ring and her head spins as she climbs to her feet. Another missile rocks the center of the kingdom, shaking the entire cliff the castle sits atop. Part of it has collapsed into the sea, leaving behind a gaping abyss. When she looks below, she's horrified to see Adam's limp body falling towards the water. Catra doesn't have enough time, hoping deep down that She-Ra is resilient enough for him to survive a fall from this height. Her heart wrenches in her chest as she fights every instinct to jump after him, instead turning to the crumbling ballroom behind her and assessing the damage.

"Catra!" She hears her name through the smoke. It's Perfuma, calling her over to help move a piece of rubble off of Bow's leg. She heaves it off of the boy, who groans in pain. It doesn't look broken, but it definitely isn't gonna feel great for a few days. She looks up at Perfuma.

"Where is Mermista?" Her voice barely hides her fear.

"I don't know! We-" She hesitates. "We got into an argument! She was having some kind of panic attack and I- I said some things I shouldn't have and-"

"When did you see her last?" Bow says, climbing to his feet with a wince.

"We were by the stage." Perfuma points towards where the band had been standing just minutes before.

Catra nods, but a hand grabs her own before she runs over. When she looks back, she sees a despondent Frosta looking up at her. "Catra."

"We don't have time, Frosta!" Catra tries to pull away but the ice princess' grip tightens instead. The magicat looks back to see Frosta is in tears.

"Please. My people are tired of fighting. We can't lose our kingdom after all this."

Catra nods. “Then help me find Mermista.” A *tsk tsk* sound comes from the magicat’s right. Glimmer sneers at the pair as she steps around them, Scorpia holding an unconscious Mermista tightly with one pincer.

“Still trying to be the best hero you can be, dear sister?” Glimmer cackles. “What a joke.” She materializes her staff in her hand.

“You say that as if the Horde *doesn't* destroy everything in its path.” Catra growls. In an instant she extends the claws on her gloves and readies her stance.

“Destroy? No, no, I'd say *repurpose* is a better word for it.” Glimmer swings her staff, narrowly missing Catra as she ducks around it. With a quick upward slash the magicat scratches at Glimmer's arm, forcing her to drop the weapon. “You've gotten better since Salineas.” The girl laughs.

“I picked up a trick or two.” Catra’s chuckle is cut short by the Force Captain punching her squarely in the jaw. She groans, only having a moment to come to her senses before Glimmer tries for a second blow. Catra manages to dodge it and grab her arm instead. A sharp twist earns a yelp of pain from the pink haired Horde leader.

The others have stayed still for now, seemingly worried that if any of them attack Scorpia it will devolve into a full blown brawl. After a moment of dueling between Catra and Glimmer, Frosta finally gets fed up and throws a sharp ice punch at the scorpion woman's face. The blow knocks Mermista free, and the pair of them use their abilities together to freeze the scorpion woman in place.

Another missile rocks the castle, sending part of it crumbling down the cliff below. Glimmer and Catra continue to dodge and land little punches, with neither seeming to gain the upper hand over the other in the fight. They're equal now in combat ability, meaning that Catra will have to fight extra hard to stay a step ahead.

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Entrapta watches in glee as the screens show the full scale invasion of the Kingdom of Snows. She hadn't accounted for the cliff partially collapsing and demolishing parts of the castle, but so far destruction has been fairly minimal. By the morning the Horde would hold Castle Evernight.

A sting of anguish washes over her for a moment, one that she chooses immediately to blot out with the anger in her heart. He chose this when he treated her the way he did. Adam would pay for the things he had done to her. She would make him.

[---]

Adora pulls herself free from the water, her leg stinging in absolute pain. Where is she? What had happened? She remembers a loud explosion and then falling. She shivers, realizing her clothes are soaked to their core from the freezing ocean. Across the small lagoon, Castle Evernight sits aflame, a dozen boats between her and it.

She looks down at herself, a wave of disgust at her body washing over her. How could she live like this? Or rather, how could Adam? She shakes her head, leaning on one of her blades for support. She certainly can't cross the lagoon, and to walk around with her leg like this would be impossible. She turns around, eyeing the thick, icy darkness closely before a light blinks dimly in the distance. A Horde outpost, likely just beyond the Kingdom of Snows jurisdiction.

Her leg screams in pain as she begins to walk, limping along towards it. That would be her only hope of setting this thing and getting back into the fight. She has to do this, for the Alliance.

For Catra.

Chapter End Notes

This ended up being the first of three parts, wow! It's the most important sequence in the entire act, so I wanted to make it special. I have Part 3 nearly done (That one takes place solely from Adam's POV) and I'm working on the second half of the Battle of the Northern Reach! Though I said I hoped to be caught up to where I was by the end of the year, it seems I will succumb to my own hubris because I want these last three to be right. Stay tuned!

Chapter 10

Chapter Summary

Like ghosts in the snow.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter IX: The Hope To Wish Impossible Things

“Hey there, sleepy.” A woman's voice cuts through the mud that Adam's thoughts are trying to wade through. The thick fog of regaining consciousness is too distracting for him even to wonder whose it is. When his eyes finally flutter open, he sees the sterile ceiling of a Horde outpost.

“Wh-where am I?” He mutters, trying to sit up. His head pounds with a ringing not unlike the one he had heard at Dryl. It's almost deafening for a moment before he finally gets his bearings and looks around. The outpost doesn't look like it's been occupied for a few months now, but that doesn't necessarily mean Adam's guard falls.

“Horde outpost about-” The voice hesitates. “Thirty clicks west of Evernight.” Adam blinks the last of the spots out of his eyes and looks over at her. If he didn't know better, he'd say she could be his sister. She's taller, athletic looking, and blonde, with the same crimson eyes as he. “Was a pain in the ass to drag you here. Your leg is broken bad, Adam.”

“How do you know my name?” Adam inquires, his heart racing. “Who are you?” The woman chuckles. She'd been leaning against the opposite wall of what Adam now sees is the outpost's little rec room. She steps forward and crouches to look at his leg.

“Yeah. That's gonna need to be set. I think there's a splint in the storage room, but it's not gonna be fun to grab it.” She touches Adam's broken leg, sending a sharp bite of pain shooting through to his ankle. He winces, and curiously, he sees the woman wince too.

“Tell me what's going on. Why am I here? Where's Catra?” Adam growls, getting tired fast of the woman's deflections. “Last thing I remember is the explosion and then falling.”

The woman grins at him, which only serves to piss him off more. “One thing at a time, princess. Leg first, then we'll have time for Q&A.” The statement earns an eyeroll from Adam, who looks down at his throbbing leg. She's right, he thinks, that if he doesn't tend this now it'll create a much bigger problem later. Begrudgingly, he nods, and waits for a moment while she gets the splint. His leg throbs to the sound of her footsteps. When she returns, she looks as pained as he feels. “This is gonna hurt.”

“Not the first time I've broken a bone, lady.” Adam mutters. She chuckles and shakes her head.

“Yeah, but it's the first time you've broken one this badly. What Shadow Weaver did- those were fractures. This is a clean break.” She looks at him, a worried expression crossing her face. How does she know about the things Shadow Weaver did? He never even told Glimmer about the way the woman had broken his arm after a particularly brutal failure in training. He opens his mouth to question her again, but she shakes her head. “Not now. I've gotta set this, and you're probably going to black out.”

“What do you-” Adam screams in pain as the girl sets his tibia, a sharp shock going up into his thigh. His vision turns white and the ringing in his ears grows deafening as he struggles to maintain awareness. He thinks he hears the woman's voice through the static, but it's faint. After a moment, he succumbs to darkness.

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[*Remember how we used to be?]*

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“Hey.” He awakens to the sound of snapping. His head is spinning, his vision blurry as he comes to. The woman from before stands in front of him, and she looks like hell. Her face is pale and covered in sweat, as if she herself had been forced to bear that pain from setting the bone as well. Adam looks around the room, realizing she's carried him into the barracks. Rows of cots sit along each side of the room, a small set of lockers adjacent to it. “You passed out pretty bad. Had to walk-” She seems to catch herself. “Had to carry you in here. Wasn't easy.”

Adam’s head stops swimming enough to allow him to sit up, his eyes finally focusing on the blonde in front of him. “You *carried* me?”

She breaks into laughter, and it's warm and wonderful and reminds Adam of Catra's in every way. That thought makes him sad. How long has he been out here? Has Catra even bothered to come looking for him? The last thing he- Oh gods. The last thing he remembers that happened between him and Catra was an argument. They had been out on the balcony when the missile hit, arguing about Catra getting all buddy-buddy with the Horde. He fights back tears. Catra probably hates his guts for all of it. He'd been so angry about Entrapta and the Horde crashing Princess Prom that he'd snapped pretty bad at her. He can't help but wonder what kind of friend does that at all.

The girl snaps her fingers at him, breaking his train of thought. “You're spiraling, Adam.” She says, staring at him intensely. “I understand you've been through some shit, but we can't stop right now. I looked while you were out and- and the communications array is offline. We won't be able to send a signal out to the Alliance without it. You'd be stuck here.”

“Wh- what about you?” Adam mutters, looking up at her. “I don't even know your name. Why are you helping me?”

“Let's just say it benefits both of us for you to make it back to the Resistance.” She says, a twinkle in her eye. “As for my name- it- it isn't important.” She stands, and strangely Adam's leg throbs as she does so.

“What then, you're just going to leave me in the dark about everything then? I've never even met you and you've saved my life. The only thing I-” Adam hesitates, remembering the blonde woman from the crowd at Princess Prom. “The only thing I have to go on is that you're the same girl from Princess Prom. The one that I tried to follow before Frosta's guard stopped me.”

She smiles. “Well, then, I'm surprised. I thought I'd kept a pretty low profile.” The girl shakes her head, looking to the doorway. “Either way. We've gotta take care of that comms array.” Adam's stomach growls and she smirks at him. What about him is so goddamn amusing to her? “And get some food in you.”

“These outposts are usually pretty well-stocked, even if it's just ration bars. Maybe they'll have the good ones.” Adam says, beginning to stand. He sees the girl wince again and she quickly points to a crutch she'd laid by the cot. His suspicion of the woman seems to have no merit, but he can't help but wonder exactly why she's being so cagey. Every time Adam moves she reacts as if she's feeling it too, which doesn't make very much sense at all to him.

He follows her on the crutch back into the common room, looking around fully for the first time at the little outpost. It's made to station maybe four or five at a time, likely as a science outpost and, given its close proximity to the Kingdom of Snows, an espionage station. That would explain why the comms array has been deactivated. It probably has to be to avoid detection by Castle Evernight.

“Shouldn't it be pretty simple to turn back on?” Adam says, looking at the computer console. Now that he can see the main room more clearly, it's built into a panel beside the large steel

entry door. Green text flashes on a black background, indicating that the console is active but not in use.

His rescuer grimaces. “Not exactly. Our-” She hesitates. “*Your* access codes are not going to work anymore. We'd be lucky if Shadow Weaver forgot to wipe their systems clean of any trace of them.” She stops for a moment, thinking. “Even then, that doesn't keep the array from signaling back to the Horde the moment we turn it on.”

Adam deflates. “So we're screwed then. I literally know less than nothing about engineering a fucking comms array. I could maybe have used Glimmer or Lonnie’s codes if they still worked, but that means jack shit if they'll trace it.” He sees her face light up as she seems to put something together.

“That's not a bad idea. What if we send up that flare and encode the message inside it? The Horde won't send more than a couple foot soldiers at best to investigate an outpost like this. But-” She grimaces. “Doesn't account for the stolen codes. They'd probably be suspicious because of that.”

“Is there a log of the last people who were here?” Adam wracks his brain for solutions to this particular caveat. “Maybe we can trick the computer into thinking it has a different person’s command codes. Make the Horde think someone left it running by mistake.”

The other cadet nods, looking around in the filing cabinet beside the terminal for any kind of logbook. After a few minutes of searching, a quick ‘a-ha!’ denotes that she's found it. She quickly flips it open and grins. “Jackpot.”

“Please tell me it's Kyle.” Adam says, not even questioning whether she knows who that is. “They'd never even bother to question it. He-” A sour feeling settles into Adam's stomach. He never liked ragging on Kyle the way the others did, but if this was going to work he was their best option. “He'd be the most likely to leave it.”

“Looks like just three were stationed here six months ago. A Force Captain named Huntara was the last out. Funny, though, have you ever heard these names?” She furrows her brow. “Sunder and Leech.”

“None of those ring a bell.” Adam shrugs. “Can we disguise Glimmer's codes with the Huntara person's? Might be easier to swap two Force Captains.”

“Worth a shot.” She taps something into the console before groaning. “It's deactivated from the outside. We're going to have to climb that stupid tower on a fucking broken leg.” Adam eyes her suspiciously, and she quickly waves her hands as if to make him forget what she just said. “I mean you! You'll have to do that! I'm going to stay here on my perfectly healthy, normal, not-broken leg!”

Adam goes to transform one of the swords, and when he does he realizes the gauntlets aren't on his arms. They're on the girl's. A shooting sense of terror drives its fangs into his gut as he begins to piece things together. He looks up at her in horrified surprise, and she returns the expression. This isn't just some girl who rescued him, this is-

“Adora. My name is Adora.” She starts, reaching an arm out as if to try to calm his panic. Adam remembers the voice in his head before the Fright Zone. He remembers the way he stared into the mirror in his room back home and swore he was looking at someone else. The way his head felt when he came to- that was no coincidence. Bow had told him he was conscious and aware during their excursion to Dryl, but that he didn't seem to know who he was. Dread fills his body at the implication, and suddenly his mind is filled with a memory that is decidedly not his.

The moments after the chip’s infection, he'd felt a rage like no other, but something else happened deep down. When he'd transformed back into his regular state, he can remember the horrified way Adora had felt upon seeing his body, on the way she had felt such disgust and rage upon being misidentified by her

comrades. Up until that point, she'd been a buried idea, a vague concept of a deep secret. The chip had manifested from Adam's alter-ego an identity and given her a name he'd secretly wished was his.

He begins to weep. “You're her. The girl from my dreams. The one M/A/R/A told me was in the prophecy. It was *you* I saw walking through the snow in my dreams that morning before the Fright Zone. It was *you* that looked into that mirror and felt like another person looked back. You're- you're She-Ra.” Adam glares at her angrily. “How long have you known?”

Adora grimaces. “I wasn't fully aware of who I was until the walk.” She bites her lower lip. “Even then, I'd been experiencing everything through your eyes until you woke up. That's when things got weird. I didn't want to freak you out, I just wanted to make sure you were safe. Make sure everyone is safe.”

Adam huffs. “You're She-Ra alright. That chip really did a number on us, then? What would have happened if I'd never picked the sword up? Would you have still existed?”

“I have no idea. I'm just as confused as you are.” Adora looks away dejectedly. “Either way, we still have to activate the comms. I'd rather not have to deal with the headache of understanding our situation on top of that.”

“Fine. But- fuck, Adora. I don't even know how to process this. How will we tell the others? What will Catra-”

“We don't. Catra won't say anything because she won't know. Remember how you were worried you were going insane? Well that was my fear too. I- *we* don't need to make everything that much weirder. This is our problem to solve and I'm sure the answers are with M/A/R/A.” Adora says, her gaze steely. Adam nods, taking a deep breath and closing his eyes. When he opens them again, she's gone, and the gloves are on his wrists.

That tower out front won't be an easy climb.

“I know. I know.” He mutters under his breath as he limps on the crutch to the door. He'll have to leave it behind, he knows, but he might as well try to avoid standing on his bad leg as much as possible. He sets it up against the wall beside the door, taking a deep breath as he pushes the button to open it.

The doors *whoosh* open, allowing the frigid air of the Northern Reach to flood inside. He's not properly dressed for this, but he'll only be out here a moment. He steps over uneasily to the tower, located only about twenty feet from the door. Adam feels a little daunted as he looks up at it, but pushes that down and begins to climb.

This really fucking hurts. Adora's voice in his thoughts says. *We really need to search the medical supplies for painkillers afterward.*

“Ditto.” Adam mutters. He reaches a small platform about midway up. The ladder from here to the top is even smaller than this, but Adam presses on without fretting. Every rung of the ladder makes his leg scream in agony, as if a metal spike is being driven into the bone. He stops to breathe a bit as he reaches the top, eyeing the large control switch with relief. The worst is over.

Or so, he hoped. A gust of wind tries to blow him from the top of the tower, and he barely holds on. His fingers are beginning to grow numb from the cold, and if it weren't for the sheer adrenaline he'd be unable to pull himself back up. As he does, he practically hears Adora laughing in his mind. Or is that him? He's struggling with the distinction.

He flips the switch to power it on, and begins his descent. Two more gusts of wind try to send him plummeting to the ground, but he stays steadfast as he finally reaches the bottom on his own terms. The comms are active, and now he can hopefully call for rescue. Adam makes his way back inside.

[---]

[*When the sun would fill the sky?]*

[---]

Adora crosses the threshold of the door. She's not sure about this, having not had to mess with Horde codes since she- since *Adam* was a cadet. She remembers Glimmer's well enough, having used it to breach the doors in the Fright Zone not that long ago.

“Jesus, ‘Dor. This is what it's like on the other side?” Adam's voice scares the living shit out of her as she works. Her heart practically beats out of her chest. “It's like I'm watching a movie of myself.”

“Yeah, well, least it's *your* body, asshole.” She grumbles, trying not to think about all the pieces and parts that are wrong down there.

Adam scoffs. “It's never really felt that way anyway.” He admits sheepishly. “It's like always feeling wrong without knowing why.” Adora finds herself sympathizing with that. It must be one of the things they share from before the chip interfered. She makes a mental note to have Adam make a list of those in Bright Moon. The less she’s out the better, and Adam can go back to normal.

“I think I've got it.” She says, typing in a few last second commands on the panel. She finds herself thanking her lucky stars that Adam was familiar with the Horde's technical systems to an extent before he left. “So this code is going to signal as Huntara’s. It'll be suspicious that it's started pinging again, but if I did this correctly they'll flag it as a power fluctuation. Nobody should be coming to investigate.”

“What about the one to the Alliance?” Adam inquires, standing beside her and looking at the screen. It's quite strange, Adora thinks, for him to be standing literally beside his own body as she pilots it around.

“It's masked in the Huntara signal. Bow should be able to pick it up on his tracker pad if I'm correct. Only thing is- it's gonna take a few days for them to come, so I hope you're ready to get cozy.”

She sees Adam grimace beside her. “C’mon, princess, you're alive aren't you? You're friends are gonna-”

“Our friends.” Adam glares at her.

“Wh- what?” Adora starts to feel nervous. “No, they're not mine. I'll probably be gone soon anyway, no need to get cozy.” She feels a pang of sadness stab her at her core, but she pushes it down and ignores it.

“And what if you aren't, Adora? Why are you so ready to give up and disappear?” The cadet growls at her.

“I- It's just easier that way. C’mon, let's scrounge around for some food, yeah?” She does her best to deflect from the conversation. Adam wouldn't understand why joining him in Bright Moon is a bad idea anyway.

Adora flicks the light on inside the storage room. It's cramped, and there isn't really much besides the medical supplies and a few ration bars, but it'll do. She finds herself thanking whatever gods may be above that they are the gray ones. At least she won't be choking the bars down today. She grabs one of them and returns to the common area to see Adam sitting at the little table, seemingly zoned out. She sits down on the other side and begins to eat in silence.

***

[*Those days would never end.*]

***

Four days have passed since they arrived at the Horde outpost. No one has come yet, but Adora finds herself wondering if this is about the time that will change. They've had enough time for Bright Moon to receive the signal, so any day now someone should be coming. She doesn't have complete faith that anyone will be, but her hopes aren't completely dashed like Adam's yet.

She awakens to the sound of the metal door screeching open. A mixed sense of panic and excitement barrels through her as she rises out of the cot. This is it, this when they finally get the fuck out of here.

“Hang on.” Adam says quietly. He's leaning beside the door. “Listen.”

Adora hones her hearing in on the voices. It's multiple people coming through that doorway. One of them is deep and rumbly and feels vaguely familiar. The other she recognizes near instantly.

“Why did they send us all the way out here anyway?” Kyle grumbles. “Huntara's codes haven't been active in forever. She's either dead or deserted.”

The other voice, which Adora now recognizes as Rogelio, says something in response. Kyle chuckles mirthlessly at him. They're getting closer to the door, clearly inspecting it for signs of a break in. Sooner or later they'll figure out that she and Adam are there, she's just not sure how much time they have.

“Adora.” Adam eyes her. “Let me handle this. I have an idea.”

“I'll be fine. Just-”

[---]

[*Those days would never end.*]

[---]

Adam doesn't let Adora argue with him. He knows how to get his former squadmates to go away and he needs her to trust him. He isn't quite sure how the switch happens, but one moment he's leaning beside the door and the next he's sitting on the cot.

Not cool, man. He hears Adora say in his head. He mentally apologizes to her before positioning himself where Rogelio and

Kyle won't be able to see him when they enter the room. Their voices are almost on top of them now.

“Something's wrong, Ro. This place looks like someone's living here.” Kyle's anxiety is evident in his voice as he nears the door. “Huntara! We know you're in here! The jig is up!” Rogelio laughs, seemingly at Kyle's dorky statement.

The metal door opens, letting a blinding light pour into the barracks. The two figures appear in it, shadowy from the bright lights behind them. Adam waits patiently for them to look around, trying for the element of surprise, before Kyle finally trains his flashlight on him. The other boy yelps as Adam lunges, swiftly knocking him off his feet and grabbing him in a chokehold. Rogelio quickly puts his hands up in surrender.

“What the fuck are you doing here Adam?” Kyle groans.

“Got a little discombobulated in that battle. Been stranded.”

“That signal was you, then.” Rogelio says in Hordespeak. Adam is surprised, as it's rare for him to speak basically at all but a few words at a time.

“I couldn't get any kind of signal out in time before it sent out whatever the fuck it did. Nobody knows I'm here.” Adam says. “Just let me rot here in peace. I don't want to go back to the Fright Zone.”

“And why should we leave you stranded out here? Eventually they're gonna want to populate this place again. It won't stay empty forever.” Kyle mutters.

“Then I'll figure it out from there. I'm-” Adam doesn't get a moment to respond before his plan is derailed by Kyle knocking him off balance. The boy breaks free and twists his arm, reminding Adam that he was in their squad for a reason, even if he's timid and unsure of himself. Adam pulls his arm free and takes a step back, dodging a jab from Rogelio in the process. He

doesn't get very far, though, as a moment later Kyle knocks him off his feet with a quick sweep.

Need help?

The former cadet ignores Adora's jabs. He slides backwards, trying to keep them far enough away to get back to his feet. The efforts are unnecessary, though, as the three of them hear the metal door open once more.

“Did we call for backup?” Kyle mutters. Rogelio shakes his head no, and the pair look between each other in horror. Adam climbs to his feet as a voice begins to echo through the main room.

“Hello?!” Bow yells. “Are you in here Adam?” He seems to rustle around for a bit. Adam hears the door to the storage room open as he searches. A second voice then joins Bow’s.

“Are you sure these are the right coordinates?” Perfuma’s voice comes. A pang of sadness comes as he realizes Catra didn't come with them to rescue him.

“I'm sure! They-” He hears the two of them stop. The blonde looks between Rogelio and Kyle, who have taken to a corner and are making as little noise as possible. “Someone's been here. Recently. These supplies have been opened in the last few days.”

Adam takes his chance. “Guys! In here! The Horde is here!” He shouts. Rogelio growls at him, leaping forward and attempting to knock him off balance. As quickly as he shouts, Perfuma and Bow rush into the room. In seconds, the pair have the Horde cadets cornered. Adam winces as he rushes behind the two, his leg throbbing from the use.

“Thought you were a goner.” Bow breathes. He glares at the two Horde soldiers. “We were never here. If you follow us I will tie you up and leave you in the snow, understand?” The two nod furiously, clearly intimidated by Bow of all people. “Come on, Adam. Let's get you out of here.”

The pair help him limp along, gathering what little he and Adora had in their miserable time here. Eventually, he finds himself on a ship from Salineas, on its way back to Bright Moon. Castle Evernight is a smoldering heap in the distance and crawls with members of the Horde. For the first time ever, the Alliance has truly lost.

[---]

[It was sweetness of your skin. The hope of all we might have been. To wish impossible things.]

[---]

Obsidian, Act I

Wolves At The Gate

By AzimuthStars

Chapter End Notes

Hey all! Thanks for being so patient! It's been a rough leadup to finishing this chapter. I ended up scrapping the other one and I've begun working on Act II as a whole, which I will likely finish and edit before releasing it in any capacity. The chapters are gonna get longer and more developed from here on out, I just wanted to get this one out there so Act I was complete. As for the story, there's a definitive reason I've portrayed Adam and Adora in this way that will be explained in much more detail in the next act. Thanks for reading!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!